

Hist 402 Napoleon

Numbered Transcript

HIST 402 • Lord Andrew Roberts

Contents

Lecture 1. Rise of Napoleon

Lecture 2. Italian & Egyptian Campaigns

Lecture 3. Transforming France

Lecture 4. Work Habits & Achievements

Lecture 5. Austrian & Spanish Campaigns

Lecture 6. Napoleon's Invasion of Russia

Lecture 7. Hundred Days & Waterloo

Lecture 8. Final Years & Legacy

Lecture 1: Rise of Napoleon

At a glance — Roberts traces the rise of Napoleon from his origins to the threshold of power.

- 1.1 Ladies and gentlemen, I'd like to start with a quotation from Napoleon when he was speaking about a play called *The Templiers* by François Raynouard. He said this, "The hero of a tragedy, in order to interest us, should be neither wholly guilty nor wholly innocent. All weakness and all contradictions are unhappily in the heart of man, and present a coloring eminently tragic."
- 1.2 Over the next eight hours, I'd like you to try to bear some of that in mind. What he was trying to say, he was speaking autobiographically, of course, because Napoleon was always speaking autobiographically. And so bear in mind this concept of being neither wholly guilty nor wholly innocent, and the weaknesses and contradictions of his personality being unhappily in the heart of man, and the extent to which that, ultimately, creates a coloring eminently tragic.
- 1.3 Napoleon Bonaparte was born on the 15th of August 1769. His birth and his background are tremendously important for the person who he became, so I'm going to expound on it for some time. The first aspect of him, of course, is his parents, Carlo Bonaparte and his mother, Letizia. Carlo was a minor noble. He was in that penumbra, that very interesting penumbra—you get it a lot in this country as well—between minor nobility and haute bourgeoisie.
- 1.4 They were rich enough—his great uncle Luciano, who was the Archdeacon of Ajaccio, where he was born in Corsica. They were rich enough never to have to pay for their own oil or bread. When you go to the Casa Bonaparte in Ajaccio, which I hope you all will, there is an actual mill inside the house which grinds the corn into bread. You have this sense that they're rich enough for their own olive oil, they're rich enough for their own wine, they're rich enough for their own bread.
- 1.5 They were obviously landowners in Corsica, but not rich ones. You don't have rich landowners in Corsica. They didn't have a feudal system in Corsica. And so although they were grand in a sense, they didn't have much actual cash. Napoleon, in fact, said later on in life that luxury is an unwholesome thing on Corsica, which is certainly something you'll recognize if you ever try to stay in a hotel there.
- 1.6 The death of Napoleon's father when Napoleon was 14, was a key moment, of course, in his life, as in anyone's. His father was a notary, a lawyer, and he had a very unsuccessful lawyer's practice, and then he died. What he did have was an Enlightenment view of the world—he was a supporter of Pasquale Paoli, the Corsican nationalist leader—and he also had a big library. This was very important because Napoleon absolutely loved spending time in the library. Disraeli said of himself that he grew up in a library, he was born in a library. Well, the same really is true of Napoleon. He was a great autodidact.

- 1.7** The other key thing about being born in 1769 is that, firstly, it was only six years after France's disastrous defeat in the Seven Years' War. France had been beaten on pretty much every front. It was the first world war, in a sense, because it was being fought all around the world in the West Indies, East Indies, Mediterranean, and English Channel, and so on. And the French were comprehensively defeated. So he grew up in an atmosphere of resentment and revanchism and the desire to get their own back, essentially, from the British. Which they managed to do, of course, when he was a very young man in the American War of Independence.
- 1.8** And what the French did was to declare war on England in 1778 after the catastrophic British surrender of General Sir John Burgoyne at Saratoga. They, therefore, managed to be on the winning side. France was on the winning side of the American War of Independence, but it broke them financially. The amount of money they spent on the ships and men to intervene meant that the Ancien Régime, the regime of the Bourbons—which had gone back for centuries, really back to the Middle Ages—was financially broken.
- 1.9** In 1789, this young—he was one month short of his 20th birthday—Napoleon, sees the whole panoply of the French Revolution unfold. At this point, he is a Corsican nationalist. He believes in Pasquale Paoli. He doesn't see himself as a Frenchman. He sees himself very much as a Corsican. This is encouraged by his mother.
- 1.10** His mother, Madame Mère, Letizia, who takes over the family after the death of her husband, Napoleon's father, Carlo, is a woman who abounds in common sense. It's a very difficult thing as an historian to get over the concept of common sense to the reader. You can say somebody's got common sense, but it's hard to explain how and why it works. It's a bit like charm or charisma or sex appeal. You know it's there when you see it, but it's very difficult actually to write about it.
- 1.11** Madame Mère had a tremendous amount of common sense. It must have been incredibly powerfully painful for her when her son, Napoleon, was sent off to school in France on the mainland—the continent, as Corsicans called it—for his education, because he left at the age of 9, and he didn't come back until the age of 17. He didn't see his family for eight years.
- 1.12** But he did go because he was a minor aristocrat and therefore got free education. You had to prove that you were French, that you were an aristocrat—which meant having 16 quarterings to your coat of arms—and also that you couldn't afford it. If you were able to prove all three of those things, which Madame Mère was able to do, then the boy could go to a military school. And there he was able to become both well-educated by the schools. Autun, he went to then Brienne Military Academy, and then ultimately, essentially, university in the military academy in Paris.
- 1.13** But also he was a tremendous autodidact, and that is incredibly important when it comes to Napoleon; he taught himself. As I said earlier, he loved his father's library, but

he also loved the libraries at his schools. He particularly admired Julius Caesar, and Hannibal, and Alexander the Great, and he read Plutarch, and he read about all of the great leaders. And he said this, "The reading of history very soon made me feel that I was capable of achieving as much as the men who are placed in the highest ranks of our annals." And this is a really important aspect of his personality.

- 1.14 There are any number of books about Napoleon. It's been estimated that there have been as many written about him as there have been days since his death, which is over 200 years ago. And these create huge amounts of myths, needless to say. And in these lectures, I'm going to try and strip away the myths from the reality.
- 1.15 One of them is about his height. He was actually 5'6, which is exactly my height. So you can see how personally I take it when I read that he was a midget and a dwarf and so on. He wasn't. He was the exact average height for a French officer at that time. You must try somehow over the next eight hours to ignore everything you saw in the Ridley Scott movie also, for example, which managed to get absolutely everything wrong.
- 1.16 A key point about him was that he was, as I say, 19 years old, almost 20, at the outbreak of the Revolution. At the time of the Fall of the Bastille, on the 14th of July 1789, he was at that stage in life in which he was still, of course, a nationalist, but looking out towards the world, trying to understand the world.
- 1.17 The French Revolution started with a series of people who wanted to overthrow the Ancien Régime, definitely, but they certainly didn't want to impose a Reign of Terror, the kind of Reign of Terror that you got by 1793 and 1794, which killed 40,000 people guillotined in France. They didn't want that. What they wanted was a revolution along the same lines as the English Revolution of 1688 to '89, one that brought in essentially a constitutional monarchy. It was a defeat for these people, the moderates, as it were, when the king was executed in January of 1793, and the Jacobins, the most extreme of the revolutionaries, took over.
- 1.18 But what it did mean was that there were huge numbers of opportunities for a young soldier. He had become a member of his artillery regiment, called the LaFère regiment. Suddenly, 75% of officers in the revolution fled, understandably, because they were being guillotined. Of those 75 % of them, many went to Britain and abroad, but it meant that suddenly there were massive opportunities for huge advancement.
- 1.19 This was the key thing about the positive aspects of the French Revolution: it opened up the concept of meritocracy. It was an opportunity for you to get to places in society, to get rank and status in society, that had been completely impossible before. Before, under the Ancien Régime, you only ever got to the same rank and status as your father and grandfather. Now, anything was possible. We see this, by the way, in Napoleon's marshals, who are the sons of barrel coopers, and innkeepers, and domestic servants. And nonetheless, they are able to become kings in the case of two of them, and princes and dukes and so on. So suddenly, essentially, the sky is the limit for anybody who is

both talented, and intelligent, and hardworking, and risk-taking, and ambitious. And in all of those things, you have Napoleon Bonaparte.

- 1.20** But at the same time, he does come from the aristocracy, and so there is the danger of the guillotine. Ironically, the closest he gets to being guillotined is not because he's an aristocrat but because he was a Jacobin. He was a supporter of Maximilien Robespierre and the most extreme revolutionaries. When Robespierre was overthrown in the Thermidor coup of July 1794 and executed along with his brother Augustin, because Napoleon was a friend of Augustin, he was arrested and put in prison at Antibes, and he was there for 10 days. But fortunately, the Thermidorians, the people who were taking over, especially the new prime minister called Paul Barras, did not want to go down the Reign of Terror route, and they only executed about 20 of the extreme Jacobins, including, as I mentioned, Robespierre and his brother.
- 1.21** However, at this stage, you also have a tremendous danger to the whole of the Revolution, which is posed by the capture of Toulon, the most important of all of the French naval towns, the dominant town in the port in the south of France, the home of the French Navy—still is today. It was captured by a combination of the British, the Neapolitans, the Sardinians, the Spanish, and French royalists. All of these enemies of the French Revolution got together, and in the late summer of 1793, they captured Toulon.
- 1.22** I don't know how many of you have been to Toulon—do go. It's a fantastic city to visit because of the battlefield, because you have a harbor, you have two harbors. You have the inner harbor and the outer harbor. The Royal Navy warships and Spanish warships and so on were moored in the inner harbor. Also, the captured French Navy was there as well, about 13 ships of the line, various frigates and so on.
- 1.23** In order to expel the Royal Navy and the Spanish navies from the inner harbor, you essentially have to be able to dominate the outer harbor. In order to do that—and you see this the minute you go to Toulon, you can't miss it, it didn't take the great genius of Napoleon, topographical genius of Napoleon, to spot it—there is a promontory called the Eguillette. Basically, he had to capture that promontory. Then after that, he could fire red-hot cannonballs down onto the fleet and force it to—even the threat of that—would force the Royal Navy to leave the Harbor of Toulon. Toulon would be captured.
- 1.24** But he had to capture the Eguillette, and the Eguillette was dominated by Fort Mulgrave, and it was held by Spanish, and British, and Neapolitan, and so on, soldiers. The Siege of Toulon essentially all came down to the capture of Fort Mulgrave. Napoleon, who at the time was only 24 years old, but of course had had this huge advancement because of the émigrés and the aristocrats who were leaving the French army, was put in charge of the artillery of the siege. The artillery, of course, when you're besieging a fort, becomes an absolutely key aspect of the capture of that fort.

- 1.25 Working with someone called André Masséna, who becomes a very important figure in the rest of his story, they do capture the fort. Napoleon himself was wounded in the thigh by a pikeman, an extremely dangerous moment for the Revolution, because if they had failed to capture that fort, then the whole of southern France could have been ignited in an uprising against the Revolution.
- 1.26 But in December 1793, it falls—the 18th of December, a very important day for Napoleon—it falls. Later that same day, the Royal Navy left the harbor, evacuated the harbor. They didn't manage to set fire to the French fleet, and so lots of French ships were captured. This for Napoleon was a great moment, not least because he was made a general on the back of it, a general at the age of 24.
- 1.27 What kind of a person was he? He was a man of great sensibility. One doesn't always think about that about Napoleon because of his, essentially, his ruthlessness. But nonetheless, he was. He enjoyed writing essays, and sometimes actually he overshared. I think he gave us too much information when he explained the loss of his virginity to a prostitute in the Palais-Royal in Paris. But he also wrote romantic literature.
- 1.28 He wrote a book, a short book, I do recommend it, called *Clisson et Eugénie*, which is about the very brave, young, handsome general Clisson, who falls in love with the beautiful and attractive Eugénie. That actually ends in disaster because Eugénie falls in love with Clisson's aide-de-camp. So it has an unhappy ending. But nonetheless, it shows that Napoleon is not just some kind of a thoughtless soldier. He's somebody who sees himself as a man of literature, a man of the arts. He loves music and writes about the theory of music and so on.
- 1.29 But when he gets to Paris, after he's been let out of Antibes Prison because of his Jacobinism, and starts to work in the Topographical Department of the Ministry of War—which sounds a boring job, but actually is a tremendously important one because there he was involved in planning a future French campaign in Italy to try and drive the Austrians out of the north of Italy. What he does when he's in Paris, is to involve himself to a degree in politics.
- 1.30 He also falls in love with Joséphine, who—there are so many myths about Joséphine. She was born, of course, in Martinique in the West Indies. She's supposed to have lost all her teeth by chewing on sugar cane. It's difficult to know whether that's true or not, but there aren't many paintings of her with her mouth open, certainly. She was, as I mentioned earlier, how difficult it is for a biographer to explain sexiness to the reader. She was undoubtedly very sexy. He fell head over heels in love with her, wrote her the most magnificent erotic letters when he was on campaign in Italy. Those certainly also bear reading. He completely lost his heart to her.
- 1.31 Also, whilst he was in Paris, he was called upon—by the way, she had been the mistress of Paul Barras, the prime minister. It gave him an entrée into the political world in which he had hopes and ambitions. Barras was quite keen to get rid of Joséphine

because she was so expensive to maintain. She was a fantastically spendthrift woman. It virtually took the whole of the French treasury to be able to pay for Joséphine's dresses and her various other indulgences, which, fortunately, when Napoleon took over, they did have the French treasury to spend the money.

- 1.32** But what Joséphine also gave him was a certain degree of social respectability, because here was this Corsican, this outsider. He spoke with a thick Corsican accent. He was now going out with, and in love with, this woman whose first husband, Alexandre de Beauharnais, was a military hero but had been guillotined by the French Revolution. This was quite extraordinary.
- 1.33** Of the three quarters of the officers, three quarters of them all left, of those three quarters were arrested or indicted at some stage for various political misdemeanors against the state, and 80 of them were condemned to be executed, and 55 actually were guillotined. So it was a scary thing to be, especially an aristocrat, but an officer in the French army between 1792 and 1799. Alexandre de Beauharnais, the Comte de Beauharnais, was one of those people who had been executed.
- 1.34** It was terrifying also for Joséphine because she was thrown into a dungeon. You can still see it, if you go to Paris, you can visit the actual room in which she was held. In the next-door room, they have the skulls of about 30 priests who were murdered in one day in the September Massacres as well. It was a terrifying moment for her, but she got through because of the fall of Robespierre, and she was able to enjoy life again. She married Napoleon in very early March of 1796. But by then, he had established himself as a real force to be reckoned with because of something called the "whiff of grapeshot."
- 1.35** Now, the whiff of grapeshot was the phrase given by the Victorian historian, Thomas Carlyle, to the day—it's also called Vendémiaire—the day in October of 1795, when the royalists, having been defeated in Toulon, nonetheless, tried to rise in Paris itself. This had to be put down by the Convention, which is the name given to the French parliament, the French legislature, the republic, essentially, and the Committee of Public Safety, which was the small executive committee which ran the government of France, of which Paul Barras was the leader. In those days, it's called Vendémiaire because of the French Revolutionary calendar, and that you'll get other words later on in these lectures—Fructidor, Brumaire—these are the words for the months that the French used until the Empire.
- 1.36** In Vendémiaire, Napoleon was appointed general of the interior, and he was going to be able to use the artillery to put down this uprising. But the trouble was that they didn't have any artillery in central Paris, extraordinarily. He had to ask General Murat, a young cavalry hussar, to take his squadron of cavalry, about 300 cavalry, to charge to Sablons, which was on the outskirts of Paris, and collect the guns necessary and hoist them up, and bring them back to central Paris, which they managed to do just before the royalists arrived at Sablons to try and capture the cannons themselves.

- 1.37** Then Murat and Napoleon stationed the cannons at all the key nodal points inside Paris that they needed to command, for when the uprising took place. When the next morning, the uprising did take place, Napoleon had the—these are essentially on the bridges and near the bridges of Paris, but also on the Rue Saint-Honoré—Napoleon had the cannon necessary and used grapeshot.
- 1.38** Now, grapeshot is essentially a bag about this big, which can fit, a little bit longer maybe, can fit 300 balls of lead, bullets, essentially. It's a linen bag. When it leaves the muzzle of the cannon, the bag, of course, rips open and the grapeshot fires at a very wide angle and obviously extremely fast. Certainly, everybody in this room would be killed immediately were I to fire—apart from me, that is—were I to fire a cannon loaded with grapeshot because it goes out like that and it causes total devastation.
- 1.39** Napoleon used this against the uprising. In two hours, the entire uprising was put down. There were over 300 people killed, many wounded. He used a man called Guillaume Brune, who becomes a marshal later on, who's an important figure because he helps put down the uprising with Napoleon. The result is that Paul Barras and the government are very much in Napoleon's debt. They appreciate that he is somebody who can use real ruthlessness to establish the Revolution's control.
- 1.40** He marries Joséphine in early March. Then two days later, he only has a honeymoon of two days. He goes off to Italy because Barras has given him—as essentially a thanks for the whiff of grapeshot—the command of the Army of Italy. Remember, he had been working out, he had been planning, the Italian campaign himself all the way through his time in Paris, ever since he got to Paris and was working in the Topographical Department. So he knew exactly what he wanted to do when he got to Italy.
- 1.41** He went down in his carriage with Murat, who became his aide-de-camp, and was very close to him. Also a childhood friend called Marmont, who again becomes very important later on. Auguste Marmont was an artillery expert, and he had been in the same regiment as Napoleon, and they had roomed together in Paris. He was another aide-de-camp.
- 1.42** When they got down to Nice, that was where the Army of Italy was based—Nice has only recently become a French city this time was always a part of Piedmont-Sardinia. He met Alexandre Berthier. Berthier was a genius chief of staff. They hadn't met before, but Berthier had heard about Napoleon and vice versa. Also, they had been in correspondence because Berthier was the chief of staff of the Army of Italy, and therefore, they had been corresponding when Napoleon was in the Topographical Department.
- 1.43** This key moment of where he meets Berthier on the 25th of March 1796, he recognizes in Berthier, who was a meticulous planner, was a master—he kept in his brain, and also in his advanced filing cabinet, the knowledge of where every unit was in the whole of

the Army of Italy. He was somebody who was pedantic at times, undoubtedly, but absolutely got things right and was with him all the way until almost the end.

- 1.44 Napoleon and Berthier together, then the next day, the 26th of March, met two other key people: Masséna, who you've already heard about, who helped attack Fort Mulgrave; and also Pierre Augereau. These were two of his three divisional commanders for the Army of Italy. When he went in, he said—the first time he met these men, they took off their caps, their hats. I'm so sorry, no, they didn't take off their hats, which he took personally. He then took off his hat. They then took off their hats. And he then put his hat back on again, daring them to put their hats back on again, which they didn't do.
- 1.45 So he established a form of social mastery over them in the opening stages of this meeting. But what really established mastery over them was his complete knowledge of the facts and his plan of campaign of how they were going to force the Austrians out of Italy.
- 1.46 They weren't going to be able to do this with new weapons. Actually, the weapons of the Napoleonic Wars were pretty much the same as the weapons that had been used in the War of the Spanish Succession, a hundred years earlier by Marlborough. You still have cannons and cavalry, breastplates, swords, bayonets on the end of muskets, and so on. The actual weaponry that was used wasn't hugely different. What was totally different, though, were the tactics.
- 1.47 Napoleon had—well, to go back a bit, France had, from its defeat in 1763 onwards, a new group of military intellectuals who wrote articles and wrote books about how tactics had to change. Napoleon read them, of course, when he was in his military academies. He didn't invent these ideas himself. As I say, they'd already been swirling around, but he was the one who put them into practice. They concentrated on *vitesse* — i.e., speed—the importance, the vital importance of keeping momentum up.
- 1.48 In the old campaigns, including the War of the Spanish Succession, 100 years before, you basically captured fortresses and then, once you'd besieged the fortress, you then moved on to the next one. It was a slow and laborious process, but that was how wars were fought. Napoleon was not going to do that. He would go beyond the fortress. He would leave a force to ensure that the people inside the fortress didn't sally out and cause trouble for his lines of communication, but he wasn't going to allow fortresses to slow down his assaults.
- 1.49 The other big aspect that was different was living off the land. It was taken for granted—and Napoleon actually inherited a very poor and downtrodden army in the Army of Italy. Lots of them didn't have shoes. They had uniforms that hadn't been altered, hadn't been upgraded for months and months. They had four months backpay still owed them, which obviously is very bad for morale, and they hadn't eaten well. Actually, the army that he found in Nice was extremely badly provisioned.

- 1.50** What he was going to do was to live off the land. The army was going to essentially plunder and loot and pillage everywhere that it moved on to. It was going to go keep itself as well provisioned as it could through that. As I say, it was also going to ignore cities except for Mantua, which was the great stronghold of the Austrians in the north of Italy.
- 1.51** But what he needed to do before anything else was to defeat the Austrian army and the Piedmontese army, which was threatening, and indeed, which attacked him before he had a chance to attack it in April of 1796. The way he did this was to employ a tactic which he was to use again and again throughout his career; you still see him using it in the 1814 campaign, which was a full 18 years later. That was to strike hard at the strongest of the two enemies and try to ensure that they weren't able to coalesce. So always drive at the hinge between your two opponents.
- 1.52** As I say, it's a Napoleonic tactic that worked incredibly well in the Italian campaign, but then again, and again, and again. In fact, the great military theorist, Carl von Clausewitz, he holds this up as the most important of the tactics; it's to work out which is the stronger of your two enemies and hit him hardest.
- 1.53** You see it actually in the Second World War as well, when the Roosevelt administration was able to—was declared war on by Adolf Hitler on the 11th of December 1941. What he does is to—what the Roosevelt administration does—is to decide to attack Germany rather than avenge Pearl Harbor, which took place four days before the German Declaration of War against America, because the Nazis were so much more powerful than the Japanese. You go for the stronger enemy.
- 1.54** This is what Napoleon does in a series of brilliant battles in the Ligurian Alps of Piedmont in the spring of 1796. There's the Battle of Mondovi, the Battle of Dego. He then allows one of the young advance guard leaders, a man called Jean Lannes, to push forward to the Po. He crosses the Po at Piacenza, and the scene is set for the great Battle of Lodi.
- 1.55** What happens is that as soon as the Austrians are pushed back, and he then is able to attack the Sardinians and Piedmontese, he forces the Piedmontese to sign an armistice called the Armistice of Cherasco, which takes the Piedmontese out of the war altogether, and he can then just concentrate on the Austrians. This tactic of his is tremendously successful, especially once the armistice is signed in April of 1796.
- 1.56** Then at Lodi, which—again, do visit some of these battlefields. I go into the details of them in my book. They're wonderful, especially Lodi, because it still has the bridge over the Adda River. Not the same bridge, it's now a bridge that trucks drive over. At the time, it was a long, thin, wooden trestle bridge, a causeway more than a bridge, really. You could only get six men across shoulder-to-shoulder.
- 1.57** But what happened was the advance guard under Lannes, supported by Marmont's artillery and by Murat's cavalry, and by Masséna and his great division, and also by

Augereau—who had been so impressed with Napoleon back on that first meeting that they had on the 26th of May— they all came together in coordinated attacks. And this was another very important aspect of Napoleonic warfare—as well as speed, and ignoring cities and so on, and living off the land—to be able to inter-coordinate the attacks was another key aspect of his war-fighting capacity.

- 1.58** What he did at Lodi was to essentially capture the bridge after what was called at the time a harangue. Harangues, they don't have the negative connotation of somebody haranguing somebody else that you get today. They were pre-battle pep talks where Napoleon would speak to the troops prior to sending them over the bridge.
- 1.59** Now, needless to say, if you are one of Lannes' grenadiers, you don't particularly want to charge over a thin 600-foot-long bridge with Austrian artillery at the other end of it—not least because they were primed with grapeshot, and we've already established how lethal that can be. It does take tremendous courage for the men to do this. And as well as the harangue, you get covering fire from Marmont on both sides.
- 1.60** And Napoleon himself actually goes to, who is an artilleryman after all, goes to position the cannon in exactly the place that he wants—each cannon he goes to, to make sure. He also sends a cavalry contingent miles downriver, which crosses over at a ford and comes up behind the cavalry. And he has landmen, and lots of other people go onto that bridge, including Berthier, in fact, even though he's chief of staff. Marmont is on that bridge as well.
- 1.61** When the grapeshot starts to be fired, they jump off both sides of the bridge, and they only come up to their midribs in the water, and are able to continue to fire at the Austrian artillerymen who were covering the bridge. And the bridge is captured and the Austrians are forced back. On the 15th of May 1796, so five days after the Battle of Lodi, Napoleon enters Milan.
- 1.62** And what he said of that battle, of the Battle of Lodi, was that it was the first time that he was able to recognize in himself his ability to be a great man. He wrote this at the time, and when he was on exile in St. Helena, many years later, he said it again, that this was the moment that he recognized that he could be a great man. You remember the quotation about the annals of history that he read when he was reading about Hannibal and Alexander and Caesar and so on. This was his moment to become someone like them. Today, he is considered to be one of the seven great captains of history.
- 1.63** On the 15th of May, he enters Milan to great celebrations. By the way, all the way through the Napoleonic Wars, whenever you enter—a victorious general who's led a conquest enters a city—the inhabitants of that city will always cheer. When somebody else arrives three days later from the exact opposite side, they'll cheer them, too. They're not stupid, the inhabitants of these cities.

- 1.64 But when he turned up to Milan—and there's a wonderful scene at the beginning of Stendhal's *Charterhouse of Parma*, a great novel, and it opens with Napoleon entering Milan. He knew he had won the first phase of the Italian campaign, as it came to be called, and which is still taught today, certainly in American and British military academies as the perfection of a military campaign because of the new tactics, because of the speed, because of what's called the tactic of the central position, and because of various other aspects to do with the logistics of the battle: the way of the campaign, the way in which they were able to live off the land and so on.
- 1.65 It's often said that amateurs talk about tactics, but professionals talk about logistics. You have to understand the way in which armies are vitted, and the way in which they are able to get their reinforcements and their ammunition and so on, in order to be able to understand how Napoleonic warfare worked.
- 1.66 He knew he had won the first phase, but he also knew that the next phase was going to be extremely difficult because the Austrians were not going to accept that northern Italy was lost. They still had Mantua, this extraordinary— again, please, ladies and gentlemen, do go to visit. It's a beautiful city, apart from anything else, Mantua. But also, the minute you get there, you can see how difficult it was for Napoleon to capture it, because on three sides of it, there's a lake, a very wide lake. It's got incredibly thick, strong walls.
- 1.67 At the top, the Austrians had huge numbers of cannon, well over 100 cannon, more like 150, I think. They were able to fire across the lake at any entrenchments or any camp that Napoleon could set up. On the fourth side of it, the last and fourth side of it, there was a lot of marsh and also a big wall. So it was an immensely difficult place to capture. In fact, Murat tried to capture it by boat one day, but the Po River was too dry and they weren't able—basically, the boats went down and they couldn't get over the walls.
- 1.68 How on earth was it going to fall? And what the Austrians were going to do was to relieve it. And they made three huge efforts with enormous armies, armies of twice the size of Napoleon's. Napoleon had around 25,000 to 30,000. Under Alvinczi, the Austrian commander—the previous Austrian commander who had been defeated in all those battles I mentioned earlier—Provera, was sacked. And they brought in Wurmser, General von Wurmser.
- 1.69 Wurmser comes down on both sides of Lake Garda in the autumn of 1796 to try to relieve Mantua and to turn the whole of the War of Italy the other way, and essentially to win the second phase after they've been defeated in the first phase. I will tell you about the second phase on our next episode. Thank you very much.
- 1.70 We began by speaking about the conditions of his birth, and in particular, growing up with the opportunities that the privilege provided, but not such excessive privilege as to have him guillotined. This thrust him into the world at a fairly young age, but then a few years progressed before he had that sense of greatness. I'm wondering how you

perceive the balance between that greatness being externally imposed through fate or destiny, or whether it came from some internal force or compulsion of personal willpower or ambition?

- 1.71** Yeah, it's a very good question because it was both. He had an incredibly strong sense of his own private driving of personal destiny, and he believed in his star. He believed in luck. He used to ask whether his marshals were lucky, and he would appoint generals on the basis that they were lucky. He had this sense. He wasn't religious.
- 1.72** He had, from his father, the Enlightenment sense that you get from Gibbon at the time, that there is some kind of supreme being, but it's not the Christian God that he'd been brought up to worship. But he did think that there was something that guided the affairs of men, and that when he's working with this force, this providential force of destiny, then he's going to do well. He notices later on and mentions later on in his career when it turns against him.
- 1.73** That said, he also knew how to create his own luck. The ambition in him was not such that he would just sit back and hope that good things would befall him. He was very thrusting, very ambitious, very keen to grab opportunities whenever they came. He set himself up for his good chances, essentially, by this amazing autodidacticism where he is reading the entire time and he's thinking, and his interlocutors are the best and cleverest people that he can find when he goes to Egypt— I'll be telling you about soon—he brings savants, these various intellectuals with him and so on. He believed in making his own luck, in the power of luck, and also in a sort of star that was guiding his destinies. Sorry, madame.
- 1.74** When you're teaching a history lesson, especially on Napoleon or in general, what are you hoping that the audience might take away from learning about someone like Napoleon; and in their daily life, what they could apply?
- 1.75** You're going to get that in a bit. Right at the end in Lecture 8, I think. But overall, it's slightly what we were mentioning earlier about teaching yourself, and learning, and learning from history, from reading a lot of history, from thinking about it. It's not just an intellectual parlor game. It does have a lot of messages, it strikes me—which I will go into—about self-advancement, about bettering yourself, about taking advantage of opportunities to learn in order to be a better person for yourself. But also in order to set yourself up well with the wherewithal necessary to be successful. Because this was the driving force about Napoleon.
- 1.76** He is the most successful, self-made man, essentially. He is somebody who, again, I'll be mentioning later, crowns himself with the crown. He doesn't allow the Pope to do it. He does it himself, underlying the fact that he is the author of his own success and achievements. I think that that kind of drive, that kind of ambition, is not just something that is worthwhile when it comes to trying to become dictator of France, but

that we could all use in our own lives. So hard work and deep thinking about how history can help you get on, and a bit of luck, and also real drive.

- 1.77** My question is similar to his, but I want to specify that a little bit. From history, the great leaders I've noticed are aristocrats. Most of them are from the elites. Just a thought experiment: do you think Napoleon would achieve what he achieved if he didn't have any of those opportunities?
- 1.78** Yes, I think he would have because of the French Revolution. This was the moment, the first moment in history, where ordinary people really could achieve very great things. You'll be hearing later about Bernadotte, who comes from a very ordinary background and becomes a king. That's true also—I don't want to spoil it for you all—of other people that I've been mentioning in the course of this first lecture. They really have got "the sky's the limit" for people who didn't come from upper class backgrounds.
- 1.79** Now, there are still a few members, I think about five or six of the 26 marshals of France did come from the upper classes. But that still leaves an awful lot of people who didn't. Yes, I think Napoleon would have been one of those people if he had not been on that penumbra that I mentioned earlier between the haute bourgeoisie and the low nobility who would have got to the top.
- 1.80** You described some of Napoleon's personal characteristics, such as being ruthless, at the same time being an autodidact, and some kind of doing team building by promoting people from the workforce to being a general or a nobleman. I'm interested in Napoleon's skills today. What kind of manager would he be? Would he be able to run a company like Apple, for example? What made him successful then? Would it be making him also successful nowadays, where we don't have so much war?
- 1.81** Yes, I think it would. Obviously, he wouldn't be able to use a whiff of grapeshot on his enemies, or his shareholders, or anyone else. But undoubtedly, no, the qualities that he saw in himself and that he brought on by all of his hard work and his ambition are not just worthwhile in terms of warfare. Of course, also they can be expanded.
- 1.82** Now, this is the 18th century. There are all sorts of—I mean, everything is different in so many ways. There are lots of things you could do then that you couldn't today. The obvious difference is that there were no women at all in any decision-making roles in the 18th century, in this part of the 18th century, at least—at least in the way that we would expect it in business, or in military, or in politics or whatever. In that sense, it's completely different from today.
- 1.83** However, I think his drive, his ambition, his sense of self-esteem, his risk-taking, all of these things are as applicable in the modern-day boardroom or indeed, work floor as in a battle outside Milan in 1796.

Lecture 2: Italian & Egyptian Campaigns

At a glance — The Italian and Egyptian campaigns that made Napoleon's military reputation.

- 2.1 General Wurmser started marching down both sides of Lake Garda in June of 1796. To face him was Masséna, who was pushed back by the much larger forces, but nonetheless managed to hold Wurmser back for long enough to allow Napoleon and Augereau to be able to get up to Lonato, which was the place where they fought Wurmser on the 3rd and the 4th of August, and then at Castiglione on the 5th of August.
- 2.2 Castiglione was a great victory for Augereau, and I don't think I've told you enough about him. He was an extraordinary character. The French army loved characters, and there was no bigger character than Pierre Augereau—big in that he was tall, but also because he had the most incredible backstory. Born in Paris, one of the very few Parisians, actually, of the Napoleonic marshals. He was an enlisted man. He started right at the very bottom as a private, became a sergeant, was quite a foul-mouthed character, and he managed to go up the cursus honorum of the French army until he killed two men in a duel.
- 2.3 The first was a young officer of the guards. This was under the Ancien Régime. Of course, that was an extremely dangerous thing to do. The other person he killed was a fencing master. So he must have been particularly good with his sword to be able to kill a fencing master. The fencing master said to him, "Do you want to be buried in the countryside or in the town?" At which point, Augereau ran him through with his sword, and he said, "It's going to be you who's buried in the countryside or the town."
- 2.4 He then had to leave France because he didn't want to be arrested for murder, and joined the Austrian army fighting the Ottomans. He then skipped over to Russia, spent some time in Russia. Then he went and joined Frederick the Great's Prussian army, where he absconded—he and a large number of men who were also with him absconded—to Switzerland. He fell in love with a girl in Athens, whom he took to Lisbon, where he was arrested by the Holy Inquisition, the Portuguese version of the Spanish Inquisition. He managed to get out of jail before he was executed. And by that stage, the French Revolution had started, so he came back to France.
- 2.5 This is the backstory of—I mean, quite a lot of them have pretty extraordinary back stories, but Pierre Augereau is a magnet for extraordinary tales. And the victory at Castiglione was his. In fact, years later, when people moaned to Napoleon about Augereau, and there was a lot to moan about, he would say, "Yes, that's true. He can be a difficult fellow. However, he saved us at Castiglione."
- 2.6 In all of these battles, of course, there's an element "one man does not win them;" they're all an element of cooperation, especially in Napoleonic battles, where he ensures that one commander fixes the enemy in place while he then brings from all

around the rest of the countryside other commanders to attack the flanks and sometimes the rear of the enemy. So one must always see all of these battles as a group effort. However, Castiglione is undoubtedly Augereau's moment.

- 2.7** What it does is push Wurmser into Mantua and the rest of the Austrians out back up north towards Austria. This lasts until January of 1797, when the Austrians make another great attempt to recapture Mantua—sorry, to relieve Mantua. This is defeated at the battles of Rivoli and La Favorita.
- 2.8** At Rivoli, it's Masséna who wins the great victory. What Masséna does is fix the enemy in place and hold them. This is under a new commander called Alvinci. He holds Alvinci in place as Napoleon and Augereau and Marmont and others swarm around Alvinci's army and win. It's on a plateau, Rivoli. It's a beautiful battlefield. I do recommend you go and visit it one day. Masséna is very proud of that victory. In fact, when he becomes a prince, he's called the Prince of Rivoli.
- 2.9** But also, two days later, Napoleon sends him marching to Mantua, and outside Mantua, at a place called La Favorita, Masséna manages to catch up with another Austrian general, Provera. And he is able also to completely defeat Provera, who has to surrender with 7,000 soldiers and about a hundred cannon. This means that Wurmser, who's in Mantua, can't do anything; he can't win. So on the 2nd of February 1797, he surrenders Mantua. This is a huge moment for Napoleon, because no longer does he have to worry about what's going on behind him. He can now concentrate on attacking Austria itself, invading Austria itself.
- 2.10** Of course, all these victories are making him more and more popular back in France, where he's starting to acquire a cult of personality. There are drawings of him and paintings of him and so on, often drawn by people who never saw him. The actual painters essentially made up what he looked like because they had no idea what he genuinely looked like. So the very early paintings and drawings of Napoleon look absolutely nothing like him whatsoever. But it's indicative of the fact that he is becoming more and more important.
- 2.11** He has a philosophy of leadership which can be summed up by his own phrase: "The French do not care for liberty and equality. All they care about is honor." This goes to the very heart of the Napoleonic leadership concept. Is that he plays on the importance of honor, of duty, and also of the negative sides of that, the aspects, the other aspects, the obverse of that, which, of course, is shame.
- 2.12** If a unit does badly, if a unit runs away—all units in all Napoleonic battles run away at some stage—that is not held against them. If they run away twice, it most certainly is. He once gave a speech after a battle where he got the soldiers of the 39th and the 85th Demi-brigades—they were called. He said, "Soldiers of the 39th and 85th, you are no longer fit to be in the Army of Italy. Hand me your standards and we will unpick the

gold braid." Essentially, those who were on their standards, he broke up, or threatened, at least, to break up the regiments and allow them to go and join different regiments.

2.13 This was considered so shameful by the 39th and the 85th that they begged him to be allowed to stay as a single unit and not have their standards defaced. In the next battle, as you can imagine, they fought unbelievably bravely and were hugely successful. But he understood not just the positive aspects of leadership, but also the concept of shaming those who did not do well.

2.14 But when it came to the positive aspects, if he saw somebody be particularly brave on the battlefield, or if through his telescope—through all the enormous amount of gunpowder smoke which could sit on a battlefield and make it very difficult for commanders to see where troops were, let alone the topography of the ground and the folds in the countryside—if he did directly spot somebody being brave, or a colonel holding his men in place when they were under attack, especially infantry under attack from cavalry, he would make it his business to go over there and take off his own Légion d'honneur, his own medal, and pin it onto the soldier there and then, even during a battle.

2.15 If you got the Légion d'honneur, you also got a pension, which a lot of these people, if they came from the peasantry or if they came from destitution, which a lot of them did, obviously, to get a pension for life, which also then went on to your widow, was something absolutely life-changing. An ordinary soldier could suddenly be the equivalent of a millionaire. One can understand the powerful effect of that on the courage that was shown in battlefields.

2.16 He also took care of people. A lot of the armies, the legitimist armies of Austria, Prussia, and Russia—the ordinary men, the ordinary soldiers, were completely treated as dirt. The Duke of Wellington famously said, he called his own troops the scum of the Earth. That's not the way Napoleon ever talked about his troops.

2.17 When he stopped on bivouac, when his tent was built up, he would make sure that the lowliest drummer boy who was involved, who was part of his guard, would be invited around the campfire to be warm. He would make sure his sentries had eau-de-vie and wine. He wouldn't necessarily want to have drunk sentries. I would have thought, but nonetheless, he would make sure that they were taken care of. He was one of those officers who treated his men well because he liked them, and they liked him.

2.18 He would encourage them to joke. When he was riding past, they'd shout, "Oh, le petit tondu," which means "the little bald guy." Most people like me, who are balding, don't like to have it mentioned. But nonetheless, he didn't care in the slightest, and he thought it was part of the camaraderie of the troops and the way in which he was able to establish a personal connection with his soldiers.

2.19 They would shout jokes at him or remind him of earlier battles. When one of them complained about not having had a new uniform for five years, he would say, "Well,

you didn't say that at the Battle of Castiglione when it was ripped up." The chap would start feeling pride that he was wearing the same uniform as at the Battle of Castiglione. So there are lots of psychological ways that Napoleon used in order to become essentially beloved by his troops, and they would be willing to go to the ends of the Earth for him, which was fortunate, only to the fact that in Egypt and Moscow, he was about to take them to the ends of the Earth.

- 2.20 I mentioned earlier about how difficult it is to explain somebody's charisma, and yet you know when you see it. Well, this was very much the case with Napoleon. People would go to Napoleon wanting to set out all of the problems and difficulties about why something was impossible to do, and would come away from the meeting believing it was possible to do because he very often said that the word impossible was not in the French lexicon. That is proper leadership.
- 2.21 I think also his sense of humor is something that is very often ignored. He had a tremendous sense of humor. There are about 80 Napoleon gags in my biography of him. He was constantly making jokes. It must have been tremendous fun to have been around him, except obviously in battles where they died like flies. But nonetheless, it would have been fun to have been in the entourage of Napoleon. There's a marvelous moment where the Cardinal Archbishop of Reims writes to him this most incredibly over-the-top, oleaginous letter about how wonderful Napoleon is and how great he is and how he doesn't get anything wrong and so on. And Napoleon writes in the top right-hand corner of the letter, "Please pay 4,000 francs to the Cardinal and Archbishop of Reims out of the theatrical fund."
- 2.22 He also, on another occasion, was having lunch with his family—now, he had eight brothers and sisters, who I'm going to come on to in a moment—sorry, he was one of eight. He had seven brothers and sisters, and earlier ones died—they were constantly squabbling over titles and lands and so on. Of course, this came from his own; everything came from his own genius and nothing from them. He did say at one of these dinners where they spent the entire time arguing about which one should get which emoluments, "You'd have thought that we were all trying to attribute the lands of our late father," the king, which, of course, they weren't. Everything ultimately came from him, but he would joke about that.
- 2.23 He undertook the beginning of the invasion of Austria, and there was a series of battles, including the first one that he actually lost, the Battle of Bassano. It was a very difficult campaign because you had to go up. That part of Italy, the Tyrol and Veneto, can have some very treacherous mountain passes. It's extremely difficult to establish lines of communication. Augereau was in charge of one column, Masséna another, and the third was commanded by Jean-Baptiste Bernadotte.
- 2.24 Now, his relations with Bernadotte are important and interesting and were always difficult. Bernadotte believed himself to be just as talented as Napoleon. Bernadotte was married to—at least by 1798—he was married to a woman called Désirée Clary,

who was Napoleon's ex-girlfriend. Napoleon was engaged to her before he jilted her for Joséphine. Actually, Désirée was also the sister of Julie Clary, who was married to Napoleon's brother Joseph, his eldest brother. It was very interlocked, this relationship.

- 2.25** Bernadotte was a true republican. He didn't trust Napoleon. He always thought that Napoleon was perhaps going to try to become what was called the sabre—the sword—of a coup to overthrow the Republic. But nonetheless, in this push into Austria, Napoleon needed Bernadotte, and he needed Bernadotte's division that came from the Army of the Sambre-et-Meuse, which, by that stage, was part of the Army of the Rhine.
- 2.26** When his division of 12,000 men came across one of the Alpine passes in midwinter—not an easy thing to do, the St. Gotthard Pass, I think it was—and came down and joined the Army of Italy, the Army of Italy were not happy that they were there because it meant that all of the money and booty and plunder that they'd have, that they were looking forward to taking in Austria, would have to be divided out by even more people. Fights broke out to the point that at one point, 350 people were injured in these huge, essentially pub brawls that went on throughout the areas where Bernadotte's division was.
- 2.27** Luckily, all of this was put to one side by the time of the actual fighting, the actual invasion, which Bernadotte's division did very well, although it did crop up a bit later on as well. The relations between Bernadotte and Napoleon were never easy. They were political; they were involved in military strategy. They had that sexual element, of course, of him marrying Napoleon's ex-girlfriend. There was a lot going on in this relationship.
- 2.28** But by the 18th of April 1797, you have the Armistice of Leoben, which was the point at which, when Bernadotte was only 80 miles away from Vienna, the Austrians decided to make peace, or at least end the war. The peace was later signed—a peace called the Treaty of Campo Formio—a few months later. But it basically meant that Napoleon had won. He'd won the campaign. Masséna, as the second-best commander there, had been fighting as had Augereau all the way back to those opening scenes at the time of the Austrian attack back in April 1796. A year later, they were completely victorious. They had pushed the Austrians out of northern Italy, and they got within 80 miles of Vienna.
- 2.29** So one can imagine that this was a tremendous moment for Napoleon. But at the same time, back in Paris, the royalists were about to cause another great threat because they had won the elections to the legislature—the April elections in 1797—and were starting slowly but surely to unpick the revolutionary settlement. Napoleon recognized, as did Paul Barras, the Director and the leader of the five-man Directory, the executive body of the French government, that there was going to have to need to be another coup.

- 2.30** It wasn't going to be one that was going to be bloody like the whiff of grapeshot of Vendémiaire of 1795, because this time the politicians were in the legislature; the royalists formed a majority in the legislature. So it wasn't going to be a question of shooting down people in the street, but it was going to be a coup. It's named the Fructidor coup because it took place in the month of Fructidor, which is September.
- 2.31** What Napoleon decided to do was send Augereau to Paris to the legislature. Basically, at dawn on the 4th of September 1797, he had the legislature surrounded; he had troops and gendarmes arrest the leading royalists. He condemned—I think it was 160 of them—to be executed. They weren't, not all of them, but nonetheless, they were condemned to be. He had about 30 sent off to Guiana, French Guiana, which was essentially a death sentence.
- 2.32** You will remember it all, obviously, from Alfred Dreyfus, but it was part of the French penal colony system for many, many years before Dreyfus. He essentially purged the Directory. Lazare Carnot, who was a minister of war, was forced to flee France, but a lot of the rest of them were rounded up.
- 2.33** Unfortunately, this went to Augereau's head, and rather than being recognized, he didn't want to just be recognized as Napoleon's sword. He actually believed he was his own sword, and he demanded to be put in charge of the Army of the Rhine rather than a friend of Napoleon's called Louis Desaix. Napoleon essentially had this overmighty subject, whom he had sent to Paris to overthrow the legislature, setting himself up as a power in his own right. It was only later, because Napoleon and Barras managed to work together, that they were able to cut Augereau down to size and send Augereau off to an unimportant posting on the borders with Spain.
- 2.34** There's always a sense—and this is a very important aspect of Napoleon—that he can never stay still because he always has to move forward, because he fears that if he does stay still, others will take his place and take his prestige. Despite all these amazing battles that he's won, others will take credit for them, like Augereau did with Castiglione and Masséna did with Rivoli and so on. So you have this worry that you often do get, of course, with modern dictators, that they are juggernauts who have to move forward.
- 2.35** The way he was going to move forward was one of two ways—either he was going to invade England with what was set up to be called and was called the Army of England, or alternatively, he had a secret plan, which he came to with the support of the French Foreign Minister, Maurice de Talleyrand, to invade Egypt.
- 2.36** What that would do strategically would be to cut Britain off from the whole of its Eastern Mediterranean assets and trading partners and trading routes and so on—this was, of course, years before the Suez Canal was built—and was going to, therefore, be a serious blow to Britain if he was able to turn Egypt into a French colony. At the time, it was an Ottoman colony. The Turkish Mamluks were the soldiers who were running

Egypt for the—actually, they really ran Egypt for themselves, but they were under the nominal tutelage of the Ottoman Sultan in Constantinople, modern-day Istanbul.

- 2.37** What Napoleon did was, whilst making the British think that he was about to invade England, secretly got together a huge army called just the Army of the Reserve, so it didn't even sound like it was about to go anywhere important. He built it up—this was all organized by Berthier and Lannes—built it up. Berthier gave up being in charge of the Army of Italy and instead went over to be the chief of staff of the Army of the Reserve. In a lightning maneuver, he brought the army down from the center of France, from Lyon, to Toulon. He launched the Egyptian campaign, leaving Toulon on the 18th of May 1798.
- 2.38** Not only did he take his army of about 38,000 men, huge numbers of cavalry and artillery, but he also took 160 what we call savants—intellectuals, writers, artists, draftsmen, a historian or two—some interesting figures who were highly intelligent and were going to create what is essentially modern-day Egyptology. They were going to draw the pyramids to go into the ancient history of Egypt, and try to crack the hieroglyphs that they found on the Rosetta Stone and so on.
- 2.39** So this wasn't just a military operation for Napoleon. Napoleon wanted to be part of the Institut de France, which is a great intellectual institution of France. He wanted to map out everything to do with Egypt, and did—his intellectuals did anyway—in a magnificent 21-volume history called the Description of Egypt.
- 2.40** By the way, on the way to Egypt, a few of the more basic soldiers like Lannes had no idea why on earth these intellectuals were being brought on a campaign. They thought it was completely ridiculous. Lannes threatened to throw one of them overboard at one point. He didn't like going to the lectures that Napoleon organized for the savants to give on board the ship, L'Orient. All in all, Lannes and others, Junot, thought that it was a complete waste of time. But Napoleon did it because Napoleon was interested in these intellectual aspects.
- 2.41** They landed successfully in Alexandria and fought a minor engagement against the Mamluks there, but they were essentially unopposed as they marched through the desert to Cairo. It was a horrible, horrible march. I've forgotten, unfortunately, the name of the eye disease that struck a lot of the soldiers, which meant that even blinking was like blinking with razor blades on your eyes. It was absolutely gnarly. They were thirsty; they ran out of water occasionally, so they had to hop from one oasis to the next. Lots of them were mad. It was a terrible march to Cairo.
- 2.42** Then, outside of Cairo, they had to fight the Battle of the Pyramids. There, it was essentially the Army of Italy that was taken over. There were lots of other detachments. But the way in which the great commanders of the Army of Italy—not Masséna; he stayed back in Europe, but Lannes, in charge of the infantry—created six great squares of infantry. Squares are vital and used a lot in Napoleonic warfare

because each infantryman protects the back of the other; you can't outflank a square. They are also almost impervious to cavalry.

- 2.43 There are very few examples of squares being broken by cavalry in the Napoleonic Wars. It happens to two squares in the Battle of García Hernández in 1813, but otherwise, it doesn't happen very much. The reason is that a horse will not charge at bayonets, at steel being pointed at them, perfectly reasonably. When they do break, it's often because it's wet weather, a horse is shot by someone in the square and then skids into the square, knocking enough men out for the rest of the cavalry to get in.
- 2.44 Then, of course, you've got a massacre on your hands because the cavalryman, either with a sword or with a lance, is able then to slash at the unprotected backs of all of the others. When a square breaks, which it does automatically once cavalry is inside, you can get up to 90% casualties. But none of Lannes's squares break.
- 2.45 The Mamluk cavalry attacks it, but they don't get inside any of them. Marmont's artillery fire at the Mamluk infantry, and Murat's cavalry then attack the infantry, who are disorganized and forced them either into the desert or into the Nile. It's one of the great Napoleonic victories. Essentially, the Mamluks were using very old tactics and very old weaponry. Lots of them were using weaponry from the Middle Ages, when, of course, the French were using gunpowder and shots. It is a massacre.
- 2.46 The day before the battle, Napoleon said to his troops, "Forty centuries are looking down upon you," because it was possible to see the pyramids. They were quite far away, and you had to look carefully, but nonetheless, "forty centuries are looking down upon you." Not actually correct. Historically, it was more like thirty-five centuries, but forty centuries sounds an awful lot better, needless to say, and it's a brilliant propaganda line, isn't it?
- 2.47 You're telling the troops that they're about to fight this battle, and they're being watched by forty centuries of history in the shape of the pyramids. It's a tremendous, sheer line. He comes out with these on a regular basis because of his love of language in his orders and his bulletins and his harangues, and of course, in propaganda.
- 2.48 One of the things he does take to Egypt—along with 800,000 liters of wine, because, of course, there is no wine in Egypt; he reckons his troops need 800,000 liters of it. But another thing he takes is a printing press because he wants to be able to churn out these orders and bulletins and essentially propaganda.
- 2.49 Nobody really believed everything that they read in the bulletins. In fact, there's a great line of a French phrase that goes "to lie like a bulletin." They rather assumed that bulletins were going to be propaganda, but they were obsessed—the senior commanders were obsessed—with the glory that they would get.
- 2.50 If Masséna, for example, was not mentioned enough at the Battle of Castiglione, he would write to Napoleon and complain that Augereau got a better write-up than him,

and when was he going to get a nice write-up, and so on, which by the time of the Battle of La Favorita, he did get from Napoleon. The lust for glory was an absolutely essential part of the general élan of the French Army, of the Grande Armée, later as well. Napoleon knew precisely how to work on this, to press the necessary buttons.

- 2.51** Then you have an uprising in October of 1798 in Cairo, which is put down utterly ruthlessly. This is a very important aspect of the Napoleonic warfare, of all warfare, frankly. Nonetheless, it was a truly terrible thing. It's easy to be lulled by the glory of the uniforms and the extraordinary victories and so on, and forget, which one must never do, especially anybody who's interested in military history, quite how awful some of these massacres were. It's a terrible form of warfare. You get it in Egypt, with the classic example being Jaffa.
- 2.52** This was after putting down the uprising in Cairo, where Napoleon actually writes to Berthier and says that any rebels found under arms, i.e. still with their weapons, must be beheaded and their corpses thrown into the Nile so that they will go down the Nile and everybody in Cairo will be able to see what happens to people who foment uprisings against the French. So it's totally ruthless.
- 2.53** And then when he attacks Syria in January of 1799, the same thing happens at Jaffa. Essentially, what happens is that he captures thousands of Turkish artillerymen. Obviously, artillery being used against him is something that he can't have happen. He doesn't believe that he's going to be able to feed them as prisoners. Also, they have promised, they gave their parole when they were captured in Gaza, they gave their promise not to bear arms against the French Republic. Then they were caught six weeks later, bearing arms against the French Republic.
- 2.54** The rules in Middle Eastern warfare were, if anything, even more vicious than the ones in European warfare. He had them all taken down to the beach and executed. Some swam off into the Mediterranean and were shot, but otherwise thousands—we don't know how many thousands, around 3,000, I think—were killed in cold blood. So never underestimate the ruthlessness of Napoleon when it comes to, essentially, uprisings or people lying to him about fighting on when they promised not to.
- 2.55** He then gets to Acre and suffers his second defeat. You remember, he was defeated at Bassano; his second defeat takes place at Acre. Marshal Berthier, his chief of staff, had already fought the British at the Battle of Yorktown in 1781, where, of course, we were surrounded on the Yorktown Peninsula, and we were unable to reinforce General Cornwallis there because the Admiral de Grasse, the French admiral, had managed to cut off the peninsula, and the Royal Navy wasn't able to resupply Cornwallis.
- 2.56** Exactly the opposite is the case at the Battle of Acre, which is put under siege in the early summer of 1799; there, the Royal Navy can resupply Acre, and it does. If you ever go to Acre, you'll see they have 10-foot, 13-foot walls. It's a crusader fort, one of the great crusader forts of the Holy Land—you shouldn't really call it the Syrian campaign

because Napoleon never even so much as set foot in what is modern-day Syria. It's more of the Holy Land campaign.

- 2.57** What Acre does—Akko, as it's called today—is essentially to hold out. But it's led by a French royalist, Phélippeaux, who was at school with Napoleon, both at school and university with Napoleon. He knew Napoleon well, the same year as him, and he was in charge of the defense of Acre. The Royal Navy was there; they brought cannons off the ships in order to pound at the French siege lines.
- 2.58** The siege went on for 65 days. Lannes was wounded. He had three attempts to capture Acre, and each time they were pushed back. The last time he was quite badly wounded. Napoleon was standing next to Berthier when a cannonball landed close to them, and he fell back into Berthier's arms, but he was unaffected. It was a tough siege because also it was getting hot. You imagine how hot it can get in the Middle East in the summer. They ran out of water at one stage. It was an extremely difficult and hard-fought siege.
- 2.59** They made 40 attempts to get into Acre. The defenders of Acre—the Turks, led by this Frenchman, and the British Royal Marines—fought them back each time and made 24 sallies against the earthworks that the French were putting up as well. As soon as they got into the French trenches and earthworks, they, of course, filled them in and tried to blow them up. It was almost like a First World War battle to and fro at Acre before Napoleon realized that he wasn't going to take the place, so he retreated to Cairo.
- 2.60** By the time he got back to Cairo, he was reading from newspapers that had been very cleverly dropped off by the British admiral to Marmont, who was governor of Alexandria at the time, news of what was going on back in France. So they were reading the British and the French newspapers, and Napoleon learnt that disastrous defeats had been taking place while he was in Egypt and on the Holy Land campaign.
- 2.61** What was going on essentially was that they'd lost northern Italy again. So all of those victories that had taken place in 1796, by 1798, were nothing, because the Austrians had come back. Not just the Austrians, but also the Russians. The Russians were also taking Switzerland, which was considered to be the next stage on from the actual invasion of France.
- 2.62** An Anglo-Russian force was in Holland under the Duke of York, the son of King George III, the famous Grand Old Duke of York, the same man. There had been a series of defeats, and France was in danger. Using that, either as his excuse, if you're anti-Napoleon, or as his genuine reason—which I think is much more realistic—Napoleon decided to end the Egyptian campaign and return to France as soon as possible.
- 2.63** He got his closest supporters and friends. Berthier was on the ship—the ship, by the way, was called the Muiron, which was named after his ADC, Jean Muiron, who had died at the Battle of Arcole in the 1796 campaign. On board the Muiron were Napoleon, Berthier, Lannes, Marmont and Murat. They went back in a ship, desperately

keen, of course, not to be intercepted by the Royal Navy, because in those days, the Mediterranean was pretty much a British lake.

- 2.64** They were very lucky to have managed to get from Toulon to Alexandria in the first place, because Admiral Nelson was in the wrong part of the Mediterranean and had only got the message late for whereabouts Napoleon actually was. He was trying to intercept the fleet, but he wasn't able to. However, on the 1st of August 1798, he did find the French fleet at Alexandria, or at least at Aboukir, near Alexandria. On the 1st of August, he completely destroyed the French fleet in the Battle of the Nile.
- 2.65** It shouldn't really be called the Battle of the Nile; it should be called the Massacre of the Nile, because of the 13 French ships of the line, all but one of them was—I'm so sorry, of the 14 French ships of the line, 13 of them were sunk or captured or scuttled. It was an absolutely massive victory for Nelson, and it stopped the whole of the rest of the French army from being able to be taken back. The only people who could be taken back were with Napoleon and his small entourage, who managed to escape the British squadrons in the Mediterranean and managed to get back first to Corsica, and then after that, on the 9th of October 1798—sorry, 1799, to Fréjus on the south Coast of France.
- 2.66** What Napoleon didn't know, really, was what reception he was going to get because, of course, in a sense, he had done a magnificent and glorious thing in turning Egypt into a French colony. However, he had then gone into the Holy Land and been forced back and lost the Battle of Acre, and then he'd had to skip the country himself with a small group and leave the rest of the French army to fend for itself in Egypt.
- 2.67** In fact, what happened was that the French army had to surrender three years later to the British, but they weren't to know that at the time. So he wondered and feared that he wasn't going to be treated as a returning, conquering hero, but instead as somebody who had essentially absconded.
- 2.68** That was very much what Bernadotte thought and told Joseph Bonaparte. Bernadotte said, firstly, it has not been a victory. Secondly, when Napoleon gets back, he ought to go into quarantine, and his ship should be quarantined, and he shouldn't be allowed off the ship. But Napoleon took no notice of that, not least because, actually, it was a 47-day journey to get back from Alexandria to Fréjus. If there had been plague, it would have manifested itself by then.
- 2.69** What he then did when he landed was to discover that, yes, he was a massive national hero. By the time he got to Lyon, there was a young writer called Marcellin Marbot, who was the son of a general, and he became a general himself, in fact. Marbot records how there was dancing in the streets, there were illuminations, there were fireworks, and a theatrical troupe put on a last-minute show called The Hero's Return.
- 2.70** They loved looking at these strong, tall, bronzed soldiers with their long scimitars that they had taken off dead Mamluks in various battles. They looked up to them as the

coming men, the great men who were going to be able, a lot of people hoped, to overthrow the Directory government, by that stage, not just because of the defeats that I mentioned earlier, but also because of the massive corruption that all of the Directors were into and incompetence. The unpopularity of the government was such that Napoleon spotted an opportunity to overthrow the government of France.

- 2.71** Now, there were plenty of people who didn't want this to happen. Bernadotte, I've already mentioned. Augereau, also, by that stage, was very anti-Napoleon because of the way he had been treated after the Fructidor coup. There was a general of the Army of Germany called Jourdan, who also didn't trust Napoleon. These people—perfectly reasonably—they were republicans, they had been taking part in the French Revolution, and they didn't want some general coming in like Oliver Cromwell and basically taking military power and making himself into a dictator. It's perfectly understandable that these men were not willing to support that.
- 2.72** But the key thing was that they didn't do anything to stop it either. When Napoleon got to Paris after being treated as a hero in Lyon on the 12th of October, when he got to Paris a few days later, he was treated like a massive hero there as well. These pro-Republican, anti-Napoleon generals stood down and didn't do anything when, on the 9th and the 10th of November 1799, Napoleon carried out what was called the Brumaire coup—Brumaire because it happened in November, which means "misty;" it's the month of mistiness in the French Revolutionary calendar.
- 2.73** What happened was on the morning of the 9th of November, Napoleon got his friends together—Lannes in charge of bringing over officers from the infantry, Murat from the cavalry, and Marmont from the artillery, Berthier bringing over the generals. They had a big breakfast at the Rue de la Victoire, the Street of Victory, which was brilliantly and appropriately named place for where Napoleon's house was. They had this big breakfast, and they brought in large numbers of horses that had been hired from the local riding school to make sure that everybody at the breakfast would join in the uprising and the military coup of the Brumaire.
- 2.74** The key figure, though, wasn't any of those generals I mentioned. It wasn't even Bernadotte, Augereau, or Jourdan; it was a man called François Lefebvre. Lefebvre was a gruff old soldier who, because he'd been wounded a few months earlier, was put in charge of the 17th district. He was the governor of the military 17th district, and that is the district of Paris and its environs.
- 2.75** He was more powerful, essentially, because he was in control of the soldiers in Paris than anyone else, including Lannes, who had been made, a couple of days earlier, the head of the legislature guards. What Lefebvre did at the breakfast was to be brought over by Napoleon. Napoleon explained what he wanted to do in terms of overthrowing the Directory. Lefebvre hadn't got much time for the Directory either because of its incompetence and corruption and so on. He said, "Right, let's go and throw all these lawyers in the river," the Directory being dominated by *avocats*—by lawyers.

- 2.76** Once that was clear that they weren't going to be opposed by other soldiers within Paris, Napoleon went to the upper house of the French legislature, the Council of the Ancients, and got them to pass a law to say that France was in danger from internal conspiracies and in danger of an uprising—which it wasn't. This was an entirely manufactured excuse, essentially, for him to take over.
- 2.77** Then the next day, the other thing the Council of the Ancients did was to pass a resolution whereby the Council of the Five Hundred, which is the lower house of the legislature, would meet at Saint-Cloud—which is south of Paris, or at least it's outside Paris, not very far outside Paris. It's a beautiful place, and I do recommend you going there. There was the Orangery there, the old Orangery, which is where the legislature sat—and Napoleon turned up with his entourage and his supporters and harangued the —
- 2.78** First of all, he went into the legislature, which these various politicians, who wore red, big red tunics like togas, they all shouted at him, and they understood that he was about to try and overthrow their form of government and make himself a dictator. They yelled at him and shouted at him. One person scratched one of his bodyguard's cheek and ripped an epaulette off another one's uniform.
- 2.79** This was the excuse that Napoleon needed when he was bundled out by his brother Lucien, who was the President of the Five Hundred. Outside in the street, where Augereau was extremely sarcastic and came out and said, "Well, you've made a fine mess of things." It looked as though it wasn't going to come off this coup. But actually, this was the moment that Napoleon told Murat that he could go in and clear the legislature. Murat, with troops at the double, moved into the legislature with troops with fixed bayonets and shouted, "Clear out this rabble." The elected representatives jumped through the windows of the Orangery and ran off into the dusk, all wearing their red togas.
- 2.80** It was then that one of two things was going to happen. Either the people of Paris were not going to put up with it and they were going to rise up and stop Napoleon and the coup—which the mob was all powerful in French politics and had been since 1789, 10 years of it. Or alternatively, they were so furious with the Directory that they weren't going to do anything. The second of those two things happened. By the end of the 10th of November 1799, Napoleon was in control.
- 2.81** Now, some of the politicians, including Barras, who had thought that he was just going to be their sword—their sabre—the strong man who was going to do the coup, but then leave it all up to the politicians of the Directory to run things, could not have got it more wrong, because this was the moment that Napoleon declared himself First Consul—a role that obviously comes from ancient Rome, but didn't have any particular resonance with French politics.

- 2.82** He then started to establish the military dictatorship that he had been planning, essentially, ever since he got on board the Muiron, and maybe even earlier than that in Egypt. He made Berthier his Minister of War. He gave Lannes a very important military post. He made Murat head of the Consular Guard, quite a strong guard in the center of Paris.
- 2.83** There was another man called Bessières, who had saved his life in the Italian campaign and became head of his bodyguard, and he was put in charge of a much, much bigger and stronger bodyguard, and he made Marmont the man who was in charge of—he made him the Counsellor of State and put him in charge of artillery matters at the Council of State. So he put his key people in key roles. Lefebvre became the President of the Senate and so on.
- 2.84** His opponents, people who hadn't supported the coup, like Jourdan, was forced to flee France. He was equally harsh on various other people who had moved into much less important areas, much less sensitive areas. He made Masséna the commander in chief of the Army of Italy. So you have this small body of friends, essentially, who grasped the opportunity of taking over France.
- 2.85** But the most ironic thing, really, was that while he had been on the Muiron coming back to France, there had been a series of victories which had made the military situation much better by November than it had been earlier in the autumn. Masséna had won a significant victory. The Anglo-Russian forces under the Grand Old Duke of York had been defeated by General Brune. The danger in Germany wasn't anything like so bad. Masséna had also won a great victory—the Second Battle of Zurich—in September 1799.
- 2.86** So actually, the military situation that Napoleon took over when the military coup was over was an awful lot more positive than the one that he had been reading about in the newspapers back in the summer of 1799. In my next lecture, I will tell you what Napoleon does with the power that he has grasped in the Brumaire coup. Thank you very much.
- 2.87** I just wanted to ask about Napoleon's Corsican identity and whether that ever held him back amongst the French soldiers and whether he was fully ever embraced as one of their own.
- 2.88** Yes, Napoleon's identity, his Corsican identity, was something he was very keen to dump as quickly as he could. From the French Revolution onwards, he thought of himself as a Frenchman, and he became very angry when people referred to him as Corsican. He would be sharp with mayors who would bring up his Corsican background.
- 2.89** He spoke, as I mentioned, with a Corsican accent. He was constantly accused by his opponents of being Corsican in that he believed in vendettas and clannishness. You see the clannishness definitely with what he does later on with his family and the way he advances them. But he wasn't a man for great vendettas, in fact. Jourdan, for example,

is allowed back, so is Marshal Victor, back into the fold fairly quickly after the Brumaire coup. So he tried to slough off his Corsican identity as quickly as possible and resented it when anybody else brought it up.

- 2.90 What happened to Egypt after Napoleon invaded over the long term? What implications did Egypt have because of Napoleon's invasion? What happened after he left so abruptly? Did it become a satellite French state?
- 2.91 He handed over to General Kléber, who was a very good general, but who was assassinated by a fanatical Islamist terrorist. That was a problem for the French. But the real problem came in 1801 when the British attacked Alexandria and defeated the French. The French army, by then under General Menou, had to surrender to Sir Ralph Abercromby's British forces. They were picked up—it was one of the reasons that Napoleon made peace with Britain. I'm going to be telling you about that in the next lecture.
- 2.92 What he did was to ship back the army to France, very disaffected, as you can imagine, and angry that Napoleon had left them without warning. But Britain was able to go through all the luggage and baggage because they were being taken back in British vessels, because, of course, the French fleet had been sunk.
- 2.93 One of the things they found was the Rosetta Stone—this extraordinary stone, which has three different languages, which has allowed the hieroglyphs to be decrypted. Instead of in the Louvre, it's sitting in the British Museum today, pleasingly.

Lecture 3: Transforming France

At a glance — Transforming France — Napoleon as reformer and statesman, not merely conqueror.

- 3.1 If Napoleon was just a conqueror, somebody who was just interested in taking over countries and controlling them, building an empire, just simply territorially, we would not be interested in him. We wouldn't be here today. It was because he was also a lawgiver that he suddenly becomes a much more interesting figure to history than just a soldier. Because what happened essentially when he took power in the Brumaire coup was that he decided to change France completely, and ultimately, because of his conquests, the rest of Europe, too.
- 3.2 He had crossed the Rubicon very much, taken this decision to change everything by taking his own life into his hands. If the Brumaire coup had gone wrong, he'd have been guillotined for treason. He wasn't doing that lightly. It wasn't just simply for his own aggrandizement. It was because he knew what he wanted to do with power when he had it.
- 3.3 I'm going to go through some of the things that he did in the Consulate, which is the period between his taking power in November 1799 and his declaring himself emperor in May 1804, those nearly five years in which he completely changed France.
- 3.4 In no particular order, he signed a Concordat with the Pope. Now, at the time of the French Revolution, the Catholic religion, indeed, all religion, had been frowned on. The Catholic Church—the power of it— was ended by the French Revolution. Great cathedrals, like Saint-Sulpice, were used to stable horses. The bishops were expelled, and all in all, the whole panoply of the religious life of France, which went back well over a thousand years, was destroyed and wrecked. And this, of course, was a great weakness for the government because ordinary French people were still overwhelmingly Catholic.
- 3.5 Napoleon saw, by 1801 and 1802, especially in 1802, when the Concordat was passed, a way of pretty easily turning his back on the Revolution and embracing the will of the French people with regard to reestablishing their church. He did it in such a way that the bishops, instead of being emigrés and enemies of his regime, became essentially clients of his regime, and they were paid directly by the state, which was another form of power.
- 3.6 He had another brilliant idea in 1802, which was to institute the Légion d'honneur, which today is, of course, a much-coveted honor in France—the top honor of France. It was then, too, as well. The very name of it goes back to—remember I mentioned how he believed that liberty and equality were not the things that drove a Frenchman? It was the concept of honor.

- 3.7** So the Légion d'honneur was something that had initially about 8,000 members. Three-quarters of them were military, but a quarter of them weren't; a quarter were to do with the administration of France and various important aspects of French public life. People would be given this red ribbon and an enamel badge. He was to say that men are ruled by baubles, and the greatest of all the baubles was the Légion d'honneur—something that, as I say, is still today quite rightly coveted by Frenchmen.
- 3.8** Then he undertook massive educational reforms, and these are very important as well. The Sorbonne University essentially became the Sorbonne under him. Now, there had been a university, of course, in Paris for hundreds of years beforehand. But what he did was to invest in it, to change the administration, to reform it, essentially, and to bring it under the control of the state, where it got much bigger and where it extended the number of subjects that it would cover.
- 3.9** It was a tremendous success, as was the extension of the concept of the lycée, which exists today, of course, just like the Sorbonne does. The lycée system was quite a military system. The children were put into what were effectively cadet uniforms. A lot of these schools were breeding grounds for future officers. So some of the lycées that still exist today are the result of Napoleon's educational reforms.
- 3.10** Then he created the Conseil d'État, the Council of State, which still meets every Wednesday today to vet the laws of France. The [Cour de comptes] also works today in working out the finances of France—not terribly well right at the moment, but nonetheless, overall, it's done a good job over the last 200 years. You can't blame Napoleon for the problems that France has today financially. But what it does do and did do was to have a series of subcommittees, the military subcommittee that Marmont sat on, for example, that I've mentioned earlier, which looked into important aspects of the state and the ways in which these could be improved.
- 3.11** He created the Banque de France. When he took over in 1799, because of the Directory, inflation had run wild. It was in the tens of thousands of percent. Now, nothing, as we learn, of course, from Germany in the 1920s, also, nothing demoralizes a country faster—other than military defeat—than the currency being devalued. It was devalued year after year after the French Revolution, and by the late 1790s, it was out of control.
- 3.12** And what Napoleon did was, by creating the Banque de France—one of the early governors of the Banque de France was Marmont's father-in-law, in fact—was to get rid of the days whereby people paid each other through what were called assignats, which were pieces of paper that became essentially pretty worthless very, very quickly, and went back to specie, i.e. gold and silver, and things that were actually trusted by the population. That very quickly got inflation under control and allowed him to set up a financial system that people believed in and trusted.

- 3.13** The next area that he was very impressive over was infrastructure, particularly roads, bridges, and reservoirs. When you go on your romantic trip to Paris, you will cross over one of Napoleon's bridges—you'll notice them because they have gigantic ends that are engraved on them. There are four major ones over the Seine. The reservoirs brought in fresh water from miles outside Paris, which, of course, was essential to fighting cholera and did a great job in that. Road building was, again, something that could be used, and indeed, in the 1814 campaign, was used in a military capacity, but also was very good for trade.
- 3.14** Trade was another area that Napoleon really concentrated on. He took some very easy decisions, such as the fact that the French Revolution had always looked down on luxury, despised luxury. Well, Napoleon didn't. He brought back the silk trade to Lyon, for example. He deliberately, as First Consul, wore a beautiful red velvet coat that had been made in Lyon. He wore gold braid and so on.
- 3.15** He had his officers dressed beautifully and expensively. He made sure Joséphine only would have, at her court, women who were dressed in French-made dresses. This was to encourage the luxury trade, which, of course, became so important to the French economy as it had been in the Ancien Régime, and indeed, of course, as it is today. That, too, along with the bridges and the roads and the reservoirs and so on, the reintroduction of luxury was something that stimulated an economic area that took off.
- 3.16** Then what he did was to invite back the émigrés. You remember how I mentioned that 75% of officers who were aristocrats fled France to avoid the guillotine? Well, he invited them back, and they came back in large numbers and were welcomed. A lot of them joined the army. You can see the aristocrats in the French army flooding back by the time of the 1800—the Marengo campaign, as it's called. They brought back a great deal of military expertise with them.
- 3.17** Also, although they weren't able to take back their lands and châteaux that had been stolen from them by the Revolution, nonetheless, they contributed to French public life. Probably more importantly, they were no longer the outside threat that they were. Now, this isn't to say that there wasn't a pro-Borbon royalist threat; it still existed, and I'll come onto it. But it was not a natural assumption across the whole of the aristocratic and upper classes that Napoleon's regime had to be brought down. So the émigrés were important.
- 3.18** Then there was the fighting in the Vendée in the southwest of France, which had been the royalist uprising, and that was defeated by a series of measures, some of them positive and kind and generous to the royalists. They were allowed quite generous amnesties. But also, it was clear that anybody who didn't take an amnesty was faced with a very vicious, dirty war.
- 3.19** They managed to capture Georges Cadoudal, who had been brought over across the Channel to France. He was executed, and so were a few of his lieutenants. But overall,

there was an amnesty, and the fighting in the Vendée was essentially ended by 1804. That's not to say that there weren't subsequent uprisings much later on in the reign—ten years later, there were. However, at the time, this was part of the Consulate's successes.

- 3.20 So there you have a series of things which were essentially making France a better place for ordinary Frenchmen—the education, the Gendarmerie, the Conseil d'État, the Banque de France, the bridges, reservoirs, roads, the émigrés, Vendée, and so on—this is what he calls "the blocks of granite." He said that in his reign, he was putting down blocks of granite; that however much you might criticize his dictatorship—
- 3.21 One has to remember that back in the 18th century, the word dictatorship did not have the negative connotations that it has had in Europe since the 1930s, since the dictators of Mussolini and Stalin and Hitler, and so on. The concept of a dictator had actually quite a positive aspect in the early 19th century because it seemed to refer back to people like Cincinnatus in ancient Rome, who, once he had won the battle, then went back to his plow and gave up the power of dictatorship.
- 3.22 It's pretty rare, needless to say. George Washington did it, of course. But other than that, it's not too easy to come up with terribly many people who have military victors who have. But this was why Napoleon wasn't thought of at the time as a dictator. Again, something that I will—sorry, not as a negative aspect of being a dictator.
- 3.23 The thing, however, for all of these positive reforms, administrative reforms, economic reforms, and so on, the thing that really established his regime, that meant the consulate was not itself overthrown in the same way that the Directory and the Committee of Public Safety and the Convention and so on in the past had been overthrown. The reason it didn't suffer its own Brumaire coup in the way that the Vendémiaire coup or the Fructidor coup had taken place was because of the Marengo campaign.
- 3.24 What happened there was that Napoleon ordered Berthier to get together a huge army in the center of France. Again, it was called the Army of the Reserve, which had enough of a boring title that nobody really worked out whereabouts it was going to go. More and more people were based around Lyon, but then it got closer and closer to the Alps. But Napoleon stayed in Paris and went to balls and parties. So the spies that every European capital had, watching Napoleon, didn't clock that suddenly he was going to cross the Alps and fall upon the plains of northern Italy to try to destroy the Austrians there. He did this in the spring of 1800.
- 3.25 You'll all know that fantastic painting by David of him crossing the Alps on a rising steed. If you look at the bottom right-hand corner of that painting, you'll see on the stones there the word Charlemagne. What David—the wonderful painter, but also a propagandist for first the Revolution and then the Consulate and later the Empire—what David was doing was equating, in the public imagination, Napoleon with the great

conquerors of the past. I think Caesar is also down on that, or Hannibal, who obviously also crossed the Alps.

- 3.26** These are specific historical points that these painters are making, not just David, but lots of the others, Gros and Gérard and others, are making the point that Napoleon is deliberately seeing himself in the historical context of a Roman emperor. You get that with the concept of consulate—the whole phrase of Consul goes back to ancient Rome. You get with the concept of the Senate, a lot of the architecture, the fact that he chooses eagles to put on the standards, the military standards. These are all very overt and obvious throwbacks to ancient Rome.
- 3.27** He comes across the Alps—now, first of all, he didn't do it riding on a horse, by the way. He actually did it on foot, sometimes on a donkey. It certainly wasn't on a horse that was rearing up, which would be extremely dangerous anyway when you go across these tiny paths in the mountains of the Alps. But it was in itself an extraordinary thing to be able to take an army across the Alps. Admittedly, he didn't have any elephants like Hannibal did, but nonetheless, he did manage to get the whole army across. On some of these mountain passes, they were so thin that only one man could go down them.
- 3.28** It's true that they were held up at little forts along the way by Austrians and Hungarians, who bravely held back the French forces, but never for very long. In fact, one of the major forts, he managed to get past in the dead of night by putting straw around the wheels of the guns and so on, and managed to get by that way. But what it did mean was that when suddenly he debauched into the plains of northern Italy, he was able to take on the Austrians.
- 3.29** Now, the reason that he had managed to get the numbers working in his favor, even though there were more Austrians in northern Italy than there were French, was because of an extraordinarily long and exhausting siege that Masséna undertook when he was in—sorry, the Austrians were undertaking it, besieging Masséna in Genoa. What he managed to do, Masséna managed to do in Genoa, was to hold out— Masséna and also his second-in-command, called Nicolas Soult—they held out for the necessary weeks that meant that an entire Austrian army had to essentially split off from the Austrian army that was going to be having to fight Napoleon, many miles to the east.
- 3.30** It was an appalling siege. There were lots of terrible sieges in this period—seige of Zaragoza is another one. But it's the moment when all the cats and dogs were eaten. They got down to eating rats. They were eating at one point a mess that they managed to make, which had all sorts of things like hair powder and bits of sawdust and so on—stuff that you'd never imagine would give you any sustenance at all. Men died of, and indeed, women and children died of starvation. There were reports, at least, of cannibalism. It was as bad as it got. The people of Genoa were not allowed to meet in groups any larger than four because the French recognized that if they did, they might

try to surrender the city to get to the gates, open the gates, let the Austrians in, and be able to eat again. It was one of those truly terrible sieges.

- 3.31 But it did mean that by the time Napoleon had broken through, come down from the Alps, he was able to fight a much smaller Austrian army based in Alessandria than would have otherwise been the case. Masséna, the soonest he was able to, did surrender, but by that stage, the Austrian general, Ott, was far too far away to be able to do anything about the Marengo battle, which itself took place, I think, on the 14th of June 1800, only a few days after, General Lannes and General Victor had managed to win a battle called Montebello, which also drew off Austrian forces.
- 3.32 Then they got together and fought Marengo. Marengo would have been lost, probably had General Desaix, Napoleon's great friend Desaix, not got onto the battlefield in time. Napoleon was retreating back further and further, and then Desaix came in on the French left flank and managed to stave in an Austrian attack. Although Desaix was killed at that battle, Napoleon was victorious.
- 3.33 It's interesting, actually, Napoleon lost a lot of friends, proper close personal friends. It did affect him. It's completely wrong to assume, as so many people have, that he was just such a heartless conqueror that he didn't care about the losses. He felt for the losses. He understood the human side of tragedies. He could write to the widows. This is not a man who is psychopathic when it comes to the cost of these victories.
- 3.34 But what Marengo did, which turned out to be a huge victory and pushed the Austrians straight out of northern Italy all over again, was to establish himself as the undisputed master of France. Although it confirmed his rule, the Bourbons were still willing to plot to assassinate him.
- 3.35 On Christmas Eve in 1800, six months after Marengo, Napoleon and Joséphine—in separate coaches, Joséphine going first—were going to the Opéra. They were living in the Tuileries Palace. They went down the Rue Saint-Nicaise, and Joséphine had to turn back her carriage because she wanted to change her scarf, and then went back to the Opéra.
- 3.36 What Napoleon then was doing in following the carriage afterwards— Lannes was in the carriage, I think Berthier as well—was, all the details of this, of course, are in my book. What happened then was that a coach was drawn across the road by a small girl. As Napoleon's coachman, César, knowing that he was going to be late for the opera if he didn't hurry up and wasn't going to put up with being stuck in a traffic jam behind this coach, he whipped the horses and shot past the coach, at which point, as he was just out of range, essentially, the cart blew up, and about 30 people were killed, many wounded.
- 3.37 It was a Bourbon plot. Of course, they knew automatically it was a Bourbon plot, but the way that they could actually find out how it was done was—and this poor eight-year-old girl was obviously a patsy for this assassination attempt— was by going

through the rubble. Lots of houses fell down as well in those days before concrete, and they found the axle of the cart and traced the axle back to the cart builder, who then said that the cart had been bought by a particular person a few days beforehand. They managed to track down the person, and the whole plot was unraveled, obviously, after it had failed.

- 3.38** It blew the carriage windows in of Joséphine's carriage, and Hortense, Joséphine's eldest daughter, was slightly cut by the flying glass, but otherwise, nobody in Napoleon's immediate entourage was killed. He went to the hospital to visit some of the survivors.
- 3.39** But what he took away from this was essentially that the Bourbons would not give up attempting to kill him. This wasn't the only assassination attempt. There were plenty of others; it was just by far and away the closest one to killing him. Therefore, what he needed to do to end them was two things. One, to take the fight back to the Bourbons, and two, to establish his power on a footing which meant that even if they did manage to kill him, they wouldn't be able to end his dynasty or the power of the Bonaparte family, and that the Bourbons would not come back to power on the basis of his assassination.
- 3.40** What he did was to crown himself, in May of 1804, crowned himself Emperor of the French, and with the remainder after his death, to go to his elder brother Joseph. That actually was the beginning of the end of murder plots. But his attempt to take the fight to the Bourbons themselves led him into an act of vendetta—I mentioned at the last lecture that he wasn't a man given to vendetta. Well, he jolly well was when it came to the execution of someone called the Duc d'Enghien.
- 3.41** The Duc d'Enghien was a Bourbon prince, and they had spotted that he was across the border, just outside France, but across the border in a neighboring German principality. Essentially, what happened was they kidnapped him and took him to Vincennes, which is the place where the original donjon—dungeon—exists. It was where the Marquis de Sade and various other high-level people were kept in the French prison.
- 3.42** It was a bit like the Bastille, only much easier to defend—it's a marvelous place, actually. It's also where the military archives of the French state are. I do recommend going to Vincennes and having a look at this magnificent castle. It was also where Louis XIV lived before he moved to Versailles. The Duc d'Enghien was taken down—after a kangaroo-court hearing, a court martial—he was taken down to the moat there and shot.
- 3.43** It's a pretty serious moment for Napoleon because the legitimists all across Europe saw this as being a vengeful course—a vendetta—against a prince of the blood. But again, it did lead to a pretty much total ending of at least the Bourbon plots against Napoleon's life.

- 3.44 There was a short-lived peace with Britain called the Peace of Amiens, which lasted between 1801—sorry, 1802 and 1803. It was only about fourteen months. That was the period at which the British army allowed—sorry, the British Navy allowed the French who had been defeated by Abercromby to come back, Menou's army, to come back to France. But unfortunately, the peace collapsed because— lots of reasons: the French blame the British, the British blame the French.
- 3.45 When one actually looks at it as objectively as possible, for a Briton, I, in fact, do blame Britain because there were various promises that we made, including the demilitarization of Malta, that we didn't carry out. Equally, although it wasn't actually written down, there was a de facto—sorry, a de jure and de facto understanding that Napoleon would not establish French power all over Switzerland, which he did during the period of the Peace of Amiens. So there's a bit of blame on both sides, frankly, about the fact that it broke down. And underlying it, of course, was the simple fact that Britain and France had not got to the nitty-gritty of what they opposed in each other. The peace was only ever really going to be a breathing space between that and the next battle.
- 3.46 So in 1803, when the peace did break down, Napoleon set up the Army of England, and he created big camps on the Atlantic Coast, on the English Channel, essentially, that would be ready at a moment's notice, if the Royal Navy was able to be drawn away from the English Channel to cross the channel and invade England. The clue is in the name: the Army of England. So these camps, big camps at places like Saint-Omer and Boulogne, were commanded by the leading generals of the day: Marshal Ney, Marshal Soult, Marmont, and so on.
- 3.47 On the 19th of May, i.e, the day after he crowned himself Emperor of the French—not Emperor of France; it's an important semantic detail— Emperor of the French, so Emperor of all of the French, wherever the French are. He then announced what was called the marshalate. Twenty-six people each became marshals and were able to command a corps.
- 3.48 Now, a corps is a little bit like, as I mentioned, about the changing of the tactics as opposed to the changing of the weaponry. The key new concept of Napoleonic warfare—even more important than those that I mentioned at the outset of the Italian campaign, about Vitesse and living off the land and the maneuver of the central position and so on—even more important than that is the corps system.
- 3.49 He didn't invent the corps system. He was very much a proponent of it, though, because the idea was that you have a group of corps each under the command of a separate marshal, which would have an infantry element, a cavalry element, an artillery element, its own staff, its own medicine, its own communications system and meds and hospitals and so on. They were all essentially little mini armies in themselves, and they were commanded by the marshals.

- 3.50** What I'm going to do now is go through a few of the marshals, the more significant ones. And although this obviously isn't chronological, I'm going to tell you about some of them and the importance of some of them and the strengths and weaknesses of some of them, because they are some of the most colorful people in the whole of the Napoleonic epic. You have the whole adventure, essentially.
- 3.51** We've already mentioned Berthier, the chief of staff, who was the top marshal. He was the one who came at the top of the list of the marshals as it was published on the 19th of May, 1804, the day after Napoleon crowned himself.
- 3.52** Let me actually go back to the coronation. There's one very important moment in the coronation at Notre-Dame, which was when Napoleon took the crown. He didn't actually take it from Pope Pius VII. He took it from the altar. Instead of having the Pope crown him—the very fact that you have the Pope at the coronation is in itself a big moment for the French state, and after the Concordat—he crowned himself. There is no more powerful sense of Napoleon being a self-made man, the ultimate self-made man, essentially, in European history, than this key moment where he takes the crown.
- 3.53** It's actually laurel-leaf, this gold laurel-leaf crown. He had already been crowned—he already had a crown on his head—but he takes this crown of victory, this crown of the Conqueror, essentially, and places it over the crown that was already on his head. That's not what you see, by the way, in the David painting, but that's what genuinely happened. The David painting doesn't have him already wearing the crown. It also has strange other things, such as he painted Madame Mère, Napoleon's mother, into the painting and gave her a major place in the painting, even though she didn't actually attend the coronation. There are historical inaccuracies in that fabulous painting that I'm sure many of you have seen at the Louvre.
- 3.54** But nonetheless, what it does underline is this sense of Napoleon having his own destiny, believing in his own star, following his own luck and his own providence and his own judgment and so on, and essentially making himself the emperor rather than God having made him the emperor via the Pope.
- 3.55** The second most important marshal in the list was Murat, the young man who brought him the cannon on the day of the "whiff of grapeshot" and who was, by then, Napoleon's brother-in-law, because Murat married Caroline, Napoleon's sister. Actually, on the day of the Brumaire coup, he, rather romantically, sent a squadron of cavalry to Caroline's school to make sure—Caroline was 18 or so at the time—to make sure she went to Madame Campan's Academy for young ladies and made sure that Caroline was safe on the day of the coup, just in case things had got dangerous. A romantic gesture, and he winds up marrying Caroline. So, he's family and is able to be brought on and promoted by Napoleon, which he very much is.
- 3.56** Then you have André Masséna, who I've mentioned many times before—a great general. Pierre Augereau, the fencing master and dancing master as well. He taught

dancing in Vienna at one stage of his career, who killed the two men in the duels. Bernadotte, of course, he becomes a marshal despite the fact that Napoleon doesn't trust him. But again, he's related to him via Joseph's wife, Julie, whose sister, Désirée, is married to Bernadotte, so he's family as well.

- 3.57** Nicolas Soult, the second-in-command at Genoa, is an impressive soldier, and he's in charge of one of the corps of the Army of England. Guillaume Brune— he was in charge of the Army of Italy at one point. He was the bruiser; he was the strong man. They sent him off to the Vendée to undertake the "dirty war," the counterinsurgency struggle in the Vendée against the royalists. I'll be telling you much later on about how that wound up for him.
- 3.58** Jean Lannes, the Roland of the French army, he was called—the beau sabreur, the romantic figure who was tall and handsome, and everybody loved him. He was incredibly brave. Both at the Battle of Arcole and another battle, he actually left his hospital bed. He'd been shot, and he left his hospital bed wounded in order to go and fight in the battle. Then, after the battle, he went back. In Arcole, he was shot again. He was shot the third time. He returned to his hospital bed, having captured the bridge. I mean, these guys were unbelievably tough, as you can imagine.
- 3.59** He had a sadness when he was in Italy because his wife gave birth to a son, also called Jean, but 14 months after she had last seen him. Although Jean Lannes wasn't tremendously good at mathematics, he could work out that the boy was not his. And so he divorced his first wife. He had a happy second marriage.
- 3.60** Then also in Egypt, whilst we're in Egypt, Napoleon himself discovered that Joséphine had been unfaithful to him with a cavalry hussar called Hippolyte Charles. He was unbelievably fierce, as you can imagine, but he started his affair with Pauline Fourés, who was the wife of a brother officer in the Army of Egypt, whom he sent off on an expedition rather sneakily to go back to France, but who got caught by the Royal Navy.
- 3.61** When the Royal Navy realized that Lieutenant Captain Fourès was the husband of the woman Napoleon was sleeping with, they put him on a boat back to Egypt. And so he actually turned up in Cairo and found his wife sleeping with Napoleon. They were given a divorce immediately. Then, when Napoleon left Egypt, he passed Pauline on to Kléber, the general who was going to take over in Egypt.
- 3.62** You have Adolphe Mortier, who everybody likes. He's pretty much the only one of the marshals who nobody has got a bad word to say about. He's a popular figure. Michel Ney, nicknamed the Bravest of the Brave by Napoleon, who does recognize this extraordinary figure who is justimpossibly brave, but not that clever. He was also completely impossible to have as your subordinate because he would alwaysdo whatever he wanted. Unless he was serving under Napoleon at the time, he would not listen to any of the people who were put above him. So it was a completely impossible figure to have fighting under you.

- 3.63** Then there was Louis Davout. Davout had been on the Egyptian campaign. He was, along with Masséna, the greatest of the marshals as a strategist. He was somebody who, like Masséna, was able to command independently in war, and he could be trusted with large bodies of men far away from Napoleon.
- 3.64** I mentioned earlier about Jean Bessièrès. He was the bodyguard, but he was also a very close friend of Murat's. Lannes hated him because he thought he was a toady to Murat. You're already, I hope, picking up the idea that these people are not a band of brothers. They're mostly a nest of vipers, frankly, the way they get on with each other, or in this case, don't, is important. Davout is an aristocrat who is an absolutely superb soldier, but no one much likes him. He has a problem because he's a real stickler, and so he isn't very popular.
- 3.65** François Lefebvre, I mentioned earlier, being the key figure in the 17th district at the time of Brumaire, he really got his marshal's baton. You literally got an 18-inch or so baton with velvet and little Napoleonic eagles encrusted on the baton when he became a marshal. Lefebvre got his political support at Brumaire, although he was a hero of the Revolution and helped win the Battle of Fleurus.
- 3.66** Then there was Étienne Macdonald, who was half Scottish. His father had been a Jacobite in the Jacobite uprisings against the Hanoverians in the early to mid-18th century. He was a good, solid soldier when he was under the command of Napoleon. Things slightly went awry when he wasn't.
- 3.67** This is also true of Nicolas Oudinot, who had the distinction of suffering no fewer than 32 wounds in the course of the Napoleonic Wars. Thirty-two. Extraordinary. His body was just absolutely full of slashes and holes and bullet holes and so on. Yet he lived to a ripe old age.
- 3.68** Marmont, of course, I've mentioned before—the school friend and artillery expert. Then there was Marshal Suchet, who had been with Napoleon a long time and also turned out to be a very good soldier as an independent commander, especially in Spain. There was Marshal Poniatowski, who was not appointed until 1813—I'll come on to him in a moment. He's the only non-Frenchman, if one assumes that Macdonald was a Frenchman, he was the only non-Frenchman to be a marshal. He was a Polish prince. Then right at the end, Marshal Grouchy, Emmanuel de Grouchy, an aristocrat who I will come on to again.
- 3.69** You've got these. That's not the whole 26. There are a few others as well, but they are the most important and some of the most colorful. The one thing you can be certain of is that, apart from Mortier, they all pretty much hated each other. Napoleon wasn't able—there were still a few friendships; that's not totally true. Augereau and Oudinot were friends. Bessièrès and Murat were friends. There were a few people who had served together and liked each other.

- 3.70** But the problem was that when the marshalate was invented, Masséna complained that there were 18 of them when it started, and so it didn't represent a great honor as far as he was concerned, but it did as far as most of them were concerned, and they felt that as marshals, they wouldn't be controlled by anybody else. There wouldn't be marshals above them. Especially Ney felt that. This was to cause unbelievable trouble in future conflict.
- 3.71** There you have the Army of England strung out along Boulogne and going into Holland and so on, ready for this sudden attack on England. Instead of that, the army suddenly has to move in August of 1805 in a completely opposite direction. This is because the Austrians have invaded Bavaria, Napoleon's ally.
- 3.72** They're called the Napoleonic Wars—well, they're called the Revolutionary and Napoleonic Wars—but that implies that most of these wars were started by Napoleon, that Napoleon was in some way responsible for them. That is not the case. Of the seven great coalitions—they're called the Wars of the Coalition—only two of them were actually started by Napoleon. The others were started by—and those, by the way, are the Portuguese campaign and the Russian campaign, which are the two most disastrous for him; those are the ones he started, but the rest were started by different coalitions of European armies, ones that are almost all of them financed by the British.
- 3.73** There's a very good book about this that's called *Guineas and Gunpowder*. Actually, guineas, i.e. those gold coins that the British minted and gave to Austria and Prussia and Russia to keep fighting against France, were just as important as gunpowder, almost, because it was because of them that the Austrians and Prussians and Russians were able to pay for their armies against the French, which is why Napoleon became fixated against the British and felt that ultimately he had to defeat Britain.
- 3.74** But when the Austrians and indeed the Russians started to march westwards in August and late summer 1805, Napoleon had to respond to defend his ally, Bavaria. He did so in a lightning-quick campaign in which he took the whole—not the whole, but the huge majority—of the Army of England, which was then part of what was called the Grande Armée, the Grand Army, across from the coast of the English Channel, 600 miles eastwards, turning through a 90-degree arc down to capture Ulm in Bavaria, and suddenly falling on the exposed flank of the Austrians.
- 3.75** It was essentially an extraordinary act of genius from the chief of staff, Berthier, to be able to keep every single person in this 160,000 or so—that's a slight exaggeration, but not mildly off—massive army coming into Bavaria and ultimately into Austria and Bohemia. The battlefield of Austerlitz is in the Czech Republic, modern-day Czech Republic. Each unit knew where it needed to be when he gave enough time for them to march and rest and to be ready to fight the minute that they came onto the battlefield.
- 3.76** The Austrian general, General Mack, who called himself the Unfortunate Mack, was forced to surrender with an enormous force, some 33,000 men. Mack surrendered with

this very large force because he'd been enveloped. One of the theories—I'm not sure whether or not there's anything to this—about why he managed to be enveloped was that the Russians were 11 days behind schedule. The reason was that they had been using the Gregorian calendar, which is 11 days behind the Julian calendar, which was being used by the Austrians. I still haven't worked out whether that's truly the case, but nonetheless, it would be one of those quirks of history if it were.

- 3.77** But whatever the case, the Russians were far too far back to be able to help Mack. They were present, however, at the Battle of Austerlitz, which, unlike the scene in Ridley Scott's terrible movie, was not won because cannonballs were fired through the frozen lakes and the Austrian and Russian armies charged into the freezing cold waters of the lakes. It was actually won through a brilliant series of maneuvers that Napoleon oversaw with superb timing, and especially Marshal Soult moving his division onto what's called the Pratzen Heights.
- 3.78** Again, I do recommend that you go to visit the battlefield of Austerlitz, which is remarkably unruined. I always think that any military historian who writes about a battle has to go there. It's otherwise a bit like a detective not visiting the scene of the crime. When you do go there, you can see from where he stood—which is on a hillock called the Žuráň— exactly where the Pratzen Heights are and how, when the sun burnt off in the morning—it was very misty and there's undulating ground. So some parts of the ground could stay in mist for longer than other parts of the battlefield.
- 3.79** That was where Soult's division was essentially hiding in the mist until what's called the Sun of Austerlitz, because the battle was fought on the exact anniversary of Napoleon's coronation—the 2nd of December 1805. What happened was the Sun of Austerlitz burnt off the mist, and the Russians didn't know what to expect. Suddenly, Soult's division attacked and took these Heights.
- 3.80** So you have the 18th of May 1804, which was the day that Napoleon declared himself emperor. You have the 2nd of December 1804, which was when he crowned himself emperor, and you have the 2nd of December 1805, when he wins his greatest victory and is in a position to redraw the map of Europe. Thank you very much.
- 3.81** One of the preconditions to the Revolution in France was the overproduction of elite aspirants in the form of lawyers and minor nobility. Do you think that Napoleon recognized the danger this could pose to his rule in the future? Were any of his reforms attempts to integrate more of the people into the state?
- 3.82** Yes, it's a very good question. He realized the danger that could be posed by having too many clever people not being helpful and supportive of his regime. That was one of the reasons that he reorganized the legal system—the Code Napoléon, which I stupidly haven't mentioned and therefore must start off next time in talking about the Code Napoléon. That was, in a sense, there to try and make lawyers less powerful, to give them less to do, to ensure that the legal system was so overt and obvious to everybody

that you didn't need to go to court in the first place because it was written down whether or not you were going to win or lose.

- 3.83** What he didn't like was the idea—and you see it with the Directory and especially with Lefebvre saying, "Let's chuck all the lawyers into the river." He didn't like lawyers being able to be overmighty, essentially.
- 3.84** I want to know the economic status of France and its colonies during Napoleon. Was it significantly better before and after Napoleon?
- 3.85** The economic status of France?
- 3.86** Yeah, economic changes of his ruling.
- 3.87** Oh, yes, very much. Getting the financial system right, stopping the inflation, all the various trade fairs and things that he did. He believed in economic autarchy. He did believe that the French Empire should be able to trade with itself. Also, he very much believed—and I'll be coming onto this—that they needed to cut Britain out of the world trading system as much as they possibly could. But yeah, the economy got better until it didn't, until about 1813, when the massive problems started. I'll be coming on to that as well later.
- 3.88** You mentioned the Ridley Scott film, and I was wondering if there were any other popular depictions of Napoleon that were more accurate. Also, I was wondering if you were to advise on a film about Napoleon, what would you focus on? Would it be an odyssey that spans his whole life, or would it be a particular time period which you think captures it, and what theme would the film be?
- 3.89** The sadness, really, about the Ridley Scott movie is that it didn't need to invent things like the cannonballs, smashing the ice and destroying the Russian army or the French army using the pyramids for firing practice, firing cannonballs at them and so on. It was entirely unnecessary. You've got a \$300 million movie, which could have been really good. All it needed was a historical consultant. We're very cheap. I don't know.
- 3.90** I have been a historical consultant on various things in the past. There's a Netflix show called Churchill at War at the moment, which I helped with. It's not difficult to get rid of stuff that isn't true. But unfortunately, Ridley Scott decided not to do that.
- 3.91** With regard to me being given \$300 million to make a movie—which is a lovely thing to think of, and thank you very much—I'd probably concentrate on the Consulate and early Empire period. But the trouble is you can't really make a movie about—Winston Churchill, I was about to say—about Napoleon, without having the Retreat from Moscow and the Battle of Waterloo. And those, of course, come very much at the end of his reign.
- 3.92** We already discussed how, in order for Napoleon to get to where he was, he has to be a logistical and operational genius. Also, when it comes to his laws, he also has to be incredibly strategic. By observing Napoleon, what would you say that people in the

modern world can take from him, either in their everyday lives or when organizing an organization, for example?

- 3.93** I think two things, really. Planning was so important for him. He and Berthier would put out the big plans of the maps on the floor in Napoleon's palace, and they would move around troops, explaining what they would do under certain circumstances and contingencies. One of the generals remembers them moving around the map and banging their heads together as they were trying to do that. So huge amounts of planning and organization beforehand.
- 3.94** And that's something that, of course, doesn't need to just be military. All of us can use that in our lives. When I see my wife planning what she's going to be doing in any particular week, it can be down to the last minute, and it works. Certainly, we do whatever is in her plan. That's the first aspect of it.
- 3.95** The other one is just sheer drive, the energy, the capacity to—his working week was an extraordinary thing. He would never sleep more than four hours. He would sometimes nap on the fly, as it were. But he'd have chickens being cooked for him, roasted for him all day round, and if he wasn't able to eat them, then other people in the palace would get them. But if ever he was hungry, he would be able to eat. So he slept and ate entirely on his own time frame. You get this. In fact, that's such a point. I might make it in the next bit.
- 3.96** He was—and you can do this if you're Emperor of France—everybody really worked around him, and he didn't care whether it was night or day. He would wake up in the middle of the night, and if he had an idea, he would follow it. He had secretaries that would rush to him at any time of day or night to take dictation and so on. That's not necessarily something that's too easy to do, especially in an office atmosphere and environment in today's world. But it's an example of how he worked his life. Right. Well, thank you very much indeed, everybody.

Lecture 4: Work Habits & Achievements

At a glance — Napoleon's singular work habits and civil achievements.

- 4.1 Napoleon Bonaparte had very singular working habits. This isn't necessarily something that we're all going to be able to copy, owing to the fact you pretty much have to be an Emperor in order to do it.
- 4.2 He only slept about four hours a night. Otherwise, he would catnap whenever he needed to. He could sleep in a carriage going down a rutted road, if necessary. He would have secretaries available at all times of day and night for him to dictate. If he was sitting in the bath and suddenly came up with an idea—he usually liked to have newspapers read to him when he was in the bath—but if suddenly something came up, he would be able to dictate a letter. There are some 38,000 letters, published letters of Napoleon's, published by the wonderful Fondation Napoléon in Paris. And on occasion, he would write 20 plus letters a day, all dictated, that is, some of them quite long.
- 4.3 He had these working habits, and especially, by the way, he could eat at any time of day or night. So he would be having a chicken roasted for him all day and night. If he wanted to get up in the middle of the night and eat a chicken, it would always be ready for him. And the chickens that had been roasted that he wasn't eating would then be sent off to his entourage or to the servants in the palace.
- 4.4 These, as I say, are not necessarily things that everyone can do today. But what he found was that he was therefore able to work by squeezing every minute out of every day. That was how he ran his, what turned out to be, an enormous empire.
- 4.5 One of the things that he spent a lot of time on in the consulate was the Code Napoléon. Now, up until the Ancien Régime fell in 1789, France had literally scores of different legal systems. Different areas would have their own legal systems. There was the Roman law that existed in France, various types of French law. Some had a basis in precedent, a bit like the British Common Law, but a lot didn't. Frankly, this was disastrous, especially for trade, because you were buying, and if you wanted to buy and sell something across one side of France to another, contracts would be liable to different interpretations under different laws.
- 4.6 So what he did was to standardize the whole of French law. It wasn't just French law. Obviously, when he started conquering other countries, some of them would adopt it. Indeed, the Rheinland still used what's called the Code Napoléon up until the early 20th century. You can see parts of it in modern-day European law, even in the law of the state of Louisiana in America.
- 4.7 The Code Napoléon essentially was a book. You can buy it. It's a thick volume. It was published in 1804, and it tells you everything that you can do. It's very different in that sense from Anglo-American law, where you can do anything unless you're told not to.

TheCode Napoléon explains everything that you can do. It was tremendously useful in bringing the whole of the country together under one system of laws for the first time, literally for the first time since the end of the Roman Empire.

- 4.8 That is why the Code Napoléon has an honored place in Les Invalides, where Napoleon is buried, that wonderful pink porphyry tomb that he has in the center of Paris by the Banks of the Seine. Around the tomb, there are base reliefs of all of his great, what he called blocks of granite, of all the major things that he achieved for France, quite regardless of the military victories. He does mention the military victories, of course, they're in stars around the actual tomb itself on the ground. But if you want to see the legacy set out in stone, essentially, of Napoleon, that's where to go. And pride of place is given, quite rightly, to the Code Napoléon.
- 4.9 We finished in the afterglow victory of the Battle of Austerlitz, where the day after the victory, Napoleon had Emperor Francis II of Austria and Tsar Alexander I of Russia meet him for a discussion about the future map of Europe. In the peace that he essentially imposed on those two emperors, the French did incredibly well in terms of territory. So well, in fact, that the Austrians, who had lost a great deal of territory—all the details you'll be able to see in my book—were, from that moment on, desperate to get revenge. Revanchism was part of the DNA of Austria from the Austerlitz settlement onwards.
- 4.10 One would have thought that when the Grande Armée had managed to pull off such an extraordinary feat as to march 600 miles and destroy a much larger Austro-Russian army in a matter of days, then nobody would want to go to war with Napoleon anytime soon. Not so. The Prussians declared war on him the very next year, in 1806.
- 4.11 Napoleon responded, as he always did, very aggressively to this declaration of war. The Jena campaign was the result with a battle in Prussia at Jena that took place on the same day, 14th of October, 1806, as another battle took place a few miles away in Auerstädt. Now, Napoleon believed that he was fighting against the King of Prussia's main army. He wasn't. Actually, that army had moved and was instead being engaged by Davout's single corps.
- 4.12 Such was Davout's brilliance that he managed to do a double envelopment of the much larger army—when I say much larger, literally two and a half to three times the size. He captured a great deal of it. The King of Prussia, Frederick William III of Prussia, managed to escape, but a large number of Prussians were captured. Napoleon recognized that Auerstädt was a great victory for Davout, and when Davout was made a prince, he was called the Prince d'Auerstädt.
- 4.13 On the actual day itself, however, Bernadotte, who, of course, had his own corps, could hear the fighting going on in Auerstädt. If he had moved his corps to Auerstädt, he could have fallen on the Prussian flank and turned a great victory into an absolute total victory. It was something that would have routed the Prussians, probably captured the

king, and ended the war. To the great fury and lifelong resentment of Davout, he didn't do that. He neither moved his force onto the battlefield of Auerstädt nor got to the battlefield of Jena either.

- 4.14** He could hear the guns of both. These guns sometimes could be so noisy. The percussive element of them was huge. The Battle of Waterloo could be heard from Kent, which, of course, is a very long way away and across the English Channel. So one can imagine how noisy these battles were. They all must have had the most terrible tinnitus. They were nonetheless trained to, if they weren't engaged, march to the sound of the guns. We will come on to this issue much later on at the Battle of Waterloo.
- 4.15** But what it did mean was that by the end of the 14th of October, 1806, the Prussians were in complete disarray. They pulled back. Napoleon captured Berlin. They pulled further back and further back. Lots of them were captured on the wayback. The French, especially the cavalry, Murat's cavalry, were incredibly tough and aggressive. Town after town fell to the French. It wasn't until the Battle of Eylau in January 1807, when the Russians came to the support of the Prussians, that this great French sweeping wave through Prussia came to a halt.
- 4.16** The Battle of Eylau took place in what is today Kaliningrad. That little Russian enclave that you get off next to the Baltic states and Poland. It's another great untouched battlefield, but along with the battlefield of Friedland, which is also there, it's next to impossible to get to, irritatingly, because it's, as I say, within—nowadays, at least—within a Russian military enclave. When I was able to get there, I was very impressed by how untouched it was.
- 4.17** You can still see the areas of wooded ground and where the churches were, and so on, that allows you to map out what happened at the battle. It was a particularly awful battle. It took place in a blizzard. Augereau had to march his Seventh Corps into this blizzard in order to try to smash through the Russian center, which is always a very difficult thing to do because the Russians were very solid, hard-fighting men. They were not about to give way to Augereau. As he was in this blizzard, there was nowhere to see whether he was veering off to the right or the left.
- 4.18** In fact, he was veering off and veered off straight in front of the main Russian battery, which, with cannon balls and also with grapeshots, essentially destroyed his division of 15,000 men. It was a massacre. He lost between a third and a half of his men killed and wounded. It also seems to have, I mean, already he was pretty doubtful about Napoleon, as we've heard, but it seems to have hardened his heart very much against Napoleon for the rest of his life.
- 4.19** Shortly after the Battle of Eylau, there was the Battle of Friedland—and, by the way, sorry, at Eylau, the reason that Napoleon won Eylau, even at magnificent, huge, vast, terrible cost, primarily, of course, the Seventh Corps, but also other corps, was because

Murat mounted one of the great cavalry charges, if not the greatest cavalry charge in the history of the Napoleonic Wars—well over 10,000, maybe anything up to 16,000 cavalry were unleashed by Murat to charge right the way across the battlefield of Eylau in the snow, but not the blizzard, so you could see where he was going, even though, of course, it was pretty freezing, and he managed to punch a hole in the Russian line and win the battle. The poor old Seventh Corps was disbanded afterwards, and Augereau, who was wounded in that battle, went back to France.

4.20 The Battle of Friedland was won in part by Marshal Ney, who turned up at exactly the right time. Many of the marshals were involved in that battle, and it was a victory. They managed to—it was fought stupidly by the Russians in essentially the Oxbow part of a river; the town of Friedland was in this Oxbow. Once the bridge over the river was destroyed, it was impossible for this very large Russian army to escape, and so it was captured. As a result, the Tsar was forced to sign the Treaty of Tilsit in July of 1807, the peace treaty with Napoleon.

4.21 Alexander I is an interesting, somewhat mercurial figure, a mystic, a young man, highly intelligent, good-looking. He and Napoleon create what seems to be a genuine friendship at Tilsit. Because they wanted to both keep their national dignity, what happened was they moored a raft in the middle of the River Neman between Russia and Poland. They met on this raft with various senior advisors. The raft had a tent on it and a rather beautifully caparisoned tent, and they sat down to discuss the nitty-gritty of how they were going to split Europe between them.

4.22 This happened—they signed the treaty in July of 1807, and it allowed Napoleon to concentrate on the creation of his next grand plan, which was to isolate and destroy Britain, not by invading it—that was impossible because on the 21st of October, 1805, Admiral Nelson had destroyed the Franco-Spanish Combined fleet at the Battle of Trafalgar and had sunk and captured so many vessels that it was now impossible for Napoleon to invade Britain.

4.23 But what he was able to do was to establish the protectionist continental system, as it was called, whereby the whole of the European continent would be prevented from trading with Britain. There were some parts that they just couldn't pull that off. There was a huge amount of smuggling that went on in the Baltic. There was Livorno—Leghorn, it was called, modern-day Livorno—where quite a lot of smuggling went on, as well in Italy, in the Papal States. But overall, especially with the Russian trade with Britain collapsing after the Treaty of Tilsit, Napoleon believed that he could force the British to the negotiation table by destroying British overseas trade.

4.24 Now, British overseas trade, of course, was not just with Europe. By the early 19th century, there was a good deal of trade with South America, and there had always been a good deal with the East Indies and the West Indies. But nonetheless, the loss of all European trade would have been devastating to the British economy.

- 4.25 Napoleon very much believed in what's called the Colbertian concept of economics, whereby you try to destroy the enemy's autarchy, its economic dependence, not through the Adam Smith way of actually producing materials at a cheaper price and better materials, if possible, through the free market and through competition—even though Adam Smith had written *Wealth of Nations* in 1776, and there were French translations available, we don't know whether Napoleon ever read any, but certainly he stuck to the old Colbertian system, whereby you physically try to stop your enemy from having any trade at all with either yourself or your allies. He had strong allies by then, not just Bavaria, but also Denmark, and now, of course, also Russia.
- 4.26 The British responded by increasing their trading relationship with Portugal. Of course, we had had a treaty with Portugal ever since 1386, the longest surviving peace treaty in human history, and it was one that worked very much both to the Portuguese and the British advantage. So what Napoleon decided to do was to invade Portugal. If he captured Lisbon, he would be able to, he believed, cut off all trade with Britain. He was going to do that with the help, in 1808, of the Spanish.
- 4.27 The Spanish, of course, had been fighting against France up until 1795 and had a very strange relationship, frankly, with France, revolutionary France, but also with Napoleonic France. It comes to a head in 1808 when Napoleon's help for what was also a Spanish invasion of Portugal turned into, to all intents and purposes, a French invasion of Spain. General Junot got into Lisbon, and the Portuguese royal family fled to their very extensive empire across the Atlantic in Brazil. And Junot then had to face a fight against who was then Sir Arthur Wellesley—later the Duke of Wellington—in Portugal, who lands in August 1808.
- 4.28 In Spain, at the same time, you have what Napoleon ultimately was to call the Spanish ulcer. The reason it turned into such an ulcer was because the Spanish nationalists were unwilling to have a new king imposed on them in the shape of Napoleon's brother Joseph. Spanish politics, especially the royal family, the Bourbons, that were, of course, closely related cousins to the French Bourbons, were a pretty weird lot, frankly, by the early 19th century.
- 4.29 You only have to look at Goya's portraits of Charles IV and the Queen of Spain to realize that they, pretty much, were at the very lowest—they were swimming in the lowest part of the DNA pool by then. Charles IV and his wife hated their own eldest son, Ferdinand VII. This was totally reciprocated. Their minister, Manuel de Godoy, the Marquess de Godoy, known as Prince of the Peace because he had negotiated the 1795 peace agreement, was sleeping with the Queen at the time and was popularly loathed throughout Spain.
- 4.30 Both Ferdinand and Charles, the father and son, actually preferred for Joseph Bonaparte to become King of Spain than the other one, which is an extraordinary situation for the Bourbon family to have gotten into. Most of the Spaniards preferred Ferdinand to his father, even though they recognized that Charles IV was the legitimate

King of Spain. Somehow, Napoleon managed to get Charles IV, Ferdinand VII, Godoy, and the Queen of Spain, all out of Spain into Bayonne, in southwest part of France, where they were essentially put under house arrest and were at least not allowed to leave until they had all signed an agreement at Bayonne to make Joseph Bonaparte king, which Ferdinand VII seemed perfectly happy to do. He then went off to stay under house arrest to Fontainebleau with Talleyrand.

- 4.31 The Spanish people sided with Ferdinand VII, and it was in his name that they rose up on Dos de Mayo. Dos de Mayo, the second of May, 1808, was the time that a huge popular revolt took place in Spain, in Madrid, in the actual center of Madrid—it's the big square there. There was a massacre. Murat was in charge. Murat, who had put down any number of revolts, including the one in Cairo, used the same tactics as they'd used, that Lannes had used at Binasco and had been used at Pavia and in Cairo and so on, of extreme viciousness and violence, killing hundreds, and mainly innocent civilians.
- 4.32 You'll remember that marvelous portrait at the Prado in Madrid by Goya of the French firing squad shooting the peasants, especially the ones in white shirts with their hands up in the air, being gunned down by French troops, the most powerful image of Dos de Mayo. And Murat hoped and wrote to Bessières, who was a governor of one of the towns in Spain, that Napoleon assumed, that the same thing was going to happen in Spain as it happened in Italy and in Egypt, which essentially was that the extreme viciousness and violence did put down the revolt.
- 4.33 This did not happen in Spain for various reasons, not least because of the extreme support that the Catholic Church gave to the uprising, and also the fact that, of course, the Spanish outnumbered the French in Spain greatly. The revolt actually instead spread massively within days throughout Spain. And suddenly the French were caught.
- 4.34 Murat, in particular, was proved entirely wrong. He'd been writing to Bessières to say that all they need is this essentially whiff of grapeshot, and it will all be all right—well, it wasn't. The whole country rose in opposition. He himself was able to skip out of the country and wasn't held to account because he had been appointed King of Naples because Joseph had been King of Naples and was moving to Spain. And so there was a free throne that Napoleon gave to Murat, partly, of course, because Murat was married to his sister Caroline.
- 4.35 So you have King Joseph, who is not respected by the majority of Spaniards. There were some pro-Joseph Spaniards, many of them in the liberal elite that wanted to see Spain brought out of the Ancien Régime and brought into the early 19th century and who wanted things like the abolition of the Spanish Inquisition, which Joseph did do, and various reforms, essentially wanted same reforms in Spain that Napoleon had given the ones that I mentioned with regard to the Code Napoléon and so on. But they were few and far between. The peasantry, the Catholics who saw France as an atheistical Republic, were not going to put up with this.

- 4.36 So Joseph's rule in Spain only really extended to wherever there were French garrisons and French soldiers. He was well-meaning and quite hard-working, but he never really had the legitimacy necessary to be king. He turned out to be a pretty terrible strategist as well. Why he was even allowed or taken any notice of when it came to strategy, when you actually did have serious and substantial, genuine strategists there— men like Jourdan, Masséna, and Suchet, and others, is anyone's guess. Well, no, it's not anyone's guess. The answer is, of course, if you're the brother of Napoleon, you have to be taken seriously.
- 4.37 But the problem with the Bonaparte family is that they pretty much all, at some stage or another, let him down—only one didn't. Joseph in Spain was dreadful, as I pointed out. Lucien, who had almost saved the day— who had, in fact, saved the day by dragging Napoleon out of the Council of the Five Hundred on the day of the Brumaire coup and managed to protect him at the moment that Napoleon then sent in Murat and the grenadiers—Lucien later became Minister of the Interior, and he did various good work trying to put through the reforms of the consulate. But then he thought that Napoleon went too far. He didn't believe that Napoleon should become Emperor, and he went into exile in Rome.
- 4.38 The youngest brother, Jerome, became King of Westphalia, and then during the retreat from Moscow—sorry, during the advance on Moscow, he, for some reason, thought that he was a better strategist than Davout, refused to be placed under Davout's orders, even though Davout was, as I mentioned earlier, along with Masséna, the greatest of all of the marshals when it came to independent command.
- 4.39 Jerome got essentially huffy because he was a king, and Davout was only a prince. He threw his hands in the air and left the Russian campaign. Whilst they were on the way to Borodino and Moscow, he just went home to Westphalia. Napoleon was furious with him over that, as you can imagine. He finally, right at the end, manages to save his face by joining Napoleon at the very last minute at the Battle of Waterloo. But he doesn't do particularly well there. That's another brother that's letting him down.
- 4.40 Then there's King Louis, who married Hortense, who I've mentioned earlier, being Josephine's daughter, and they had the most terrible marriage. Why? They were married for dynastic reasons, of course, between Josephine and Napoleon. But it was an awful marriage. Neither of them loved one another. It's possible that one of the children was not Louis anyway. And when Louis became King of Holland, he turns a blind eye to all of the smuggling going on between Britain and his Dutch subjects.
- 4.41 This is what happened again and again. It happened with Murat and Caroline in Naples. It happened with Louis in Holland and to a lesser extent with Jerome in Westphalia. When they became kings, they, perfectly understandably, constitutionally, put what they thought was the best interests of their people above the best interests of Napoleon and the French Empire. In a sense, that's what you're supposed to do if you're the sovereign of a country.

- 4.42 But what they forgot, essentially, was that the only reason they were there was because of their brother. Nobody would ever have made them kings and sovereign rulers if they hadn't been. Their job in these places was to do what Napoleon needed and to promote the interests of the French Empire, not their own subjects. Having forgotten that, they naturally fell into huge clashes with Napoleon. In the end, Louis had to be, in fact, overthrown by his brother. Napoleon also, at one point, wanted to put Joseph under house arrest. In his house, Mortefontaine, when he was flung out of Spain.
- 4.43 You have another sister called Élisabeth, who was the Grand Duchess of Lucca and Piombino. She was a good-hearted philanthropic lady who did the best she could for Lucca and Piombino, and doesn't seem to have otherwise affected history, hugely one way or another. The worst of them was Caroline, who turned against her brother and actually joined the allies in 1813 and encouraged them to attack Napoleon. She and Murat, essentially—there's one biography of them called *The Betrayers*—they betrayed Napoleon, and they didn't get anywhere with that because they were overthrown by the allies. And so she was the worst of the lot as far as Napoleon was concerned.
- 4.44 There was only one who was of any worth to Napoleon, and that was Pauline. Pauline Borghese, as she was known because she was married to her second [husband], to the Italian Prince Borghese. Her first marriage was to General Leclerc, who was sent off by Napoleon to put down the slave revolt in Haiti. He did that with terrible viciousness, truly appalling viciousness. Pauline went out with him, and then he died of yellow fever, and she had to come back.
- 4.45 We know—again, very difficult as a historian, as a biographer, to write about sexiness—but we do know that she was sexy. Actually, we know quite a lot about her physique, owing to the fact that there is a splendid Canova portrait of her in stone, lying on a sofa that you can see in the British Embassy in Paris. She's got this fabulous figure. It's said that the champagne goblets that we drink champagne out of, the big ones like that, were originally sculpted from her breasts. And so hope it's true.
- 4.46 She was beautiful. She took lovers, including Marshal MacDonald. She had a great sense of humor, and all around was obviously a great girl. And she stuck by her brother. When Napoleon went to Elba—was forced into exile in Elba in 1814—she was the only one of the children who stayed in contact with him and actually went out to visit him. She didn't visit him in St. Helena, it's true. But she, in 1814, sold her diamonds in order to raise money for Napoleon's return to the throne—sorry, 1815, I think that was. So Pauline is a character; she's a figure. I find her very attractive historically.
- 4.47 But otherwise, the whole family let him down, let him down terribly. They didn't just let him down in a political sense with regard to what they did, but also the very fact that he had turned to his family in that maybe Corsican, clanish way, rather than continuing the meritocratic route that essentially the French Revolution was all about, was in and of itself a slap in the face to meritocracy.

- 4.48 There are any number of people in Westphalia, or Holland, or Spain, indeed, who could have been very good prime ministers or leaders of those countries. But instead, he went down the old classic Ancien Régime, legitimacy route of sticking in your family and assuming that you could trust them, which, in his case, in many cases, he couldn't. It was a slap in the face for the concept of meritocracy. That concept that I mentioned earlier about how the place that you could rise to was no longer based on who your family were, who your father and grandfather were. Well, he went back on that. And the highest that you could rise to in Holland, say, was entirely down to who your brother was. That obviously was a betrayal of the revolutionary principles.
- 4.49 So also was what he did in July of 1808, which was to return entirely to the aristocracy, to the concept of aristocracy. He made various marshals of his into princes, counts, dukes, and so on. Several of them he gave, as well as vast amounts of money, also estates outside France. They were all rich enough to be able to buy estates inside France and grand houses in Paris. That, too, was a bit of a return to the Ancien Régime attitude towards life.
- 4.50 When a young man said to Lefebvre, when he looked at Lefebvre's gorgeous, massive house in Paris and spoke rather enviously about it and said, "Well, you've done all right, haven't you?" Lefebvre said, "Right, come to the end of the garden. Come on outside." This was a dinner party. They got up and went to the end of the garden. He said, "I'll fire 60 shots at you, and if I miss, you can have the house. It's totally your call, because I've had thousands of bullets fired at me for me to be able to get this house," which is a classic. It tells you a lot about Lefebvre, but it also tells you a bit about quite how grand and gorgeous and magnificent these houses were. But they do represent a return to the concept of aristocracy.
- 4.51 The war in Spain has its ups and downs. It's true that there are some moments where the marshals, especially Soult down in the south, in Extremadura and Andalusia, do get control of the situation. Suchet, on the Eastern side of Spain, also manages to control large regions. Nicolas Soult also, at one point, manages to calm down parts of Portugal. But overall—and there's proper French control in and around Madrid for a good deal of the Peninsular War—but otherwise, the Peninsular War is a constant battle against the forces of the guerrillas, essentially, a really nasty, long, harsh, dirty war that is fought between the counter-insurgents of the French and the Spanish.
- 4.52 Some quarter of a million French troops are killed and wounded in the course of this campaign that goes on from 1808 through to the point where the last Frenchman is forced out of the Iberian Peninsula in 1814. The Peninsular War is a war in and of itself. It's going on while other wars are going on. It's going on while there's a war in Austria in 1809, another war, obviously, in 1812 in Russia. But you can see the Peninsular War as what Napoleon called the Spanish ulcer, because it was an ulcer for his empire. He constantly had to send more and more young men who were conscripted into the fighting.

- 4.53 There were any number of battles. The French tended to win the set-piece battles against the Spanish. But once the Duke of Wellington landed just north of Lisbon in August 1808, he, combined with the Portuguese and later the Spanish, did manage to win a series of victories, Roliça and Vimeiro, right at the beginning in August 1808, but then taken through to Battle of Fuentes de Oñoro in May 1811, which stopped Masséna from relieving the key city of Almeida, which essentially the Almeida and Badajoz were the two gateway cities to Portugal. And he goes backwards and forwards, backwards and forwards.
- 4.54 You also get a moment where Sir John Moore, with another expeditionary force in late 1808, comes up to push the French back, and then is himself forced back by Napoleon to Corunna, where Soult essentially fights more at Corunna. Moore is killed, but the British expeditionary force is able to escape from Corunna. This struggle was incredibly brave—you get moments like the Siege of Zaragoza, where it's called the "War to the Knife," where the women on the roofs throw slates down onto the attacking French, where you have terrible sieges, rather like the one in Genoa, where people are eating the cats and dogs.
- 4.55 You have groups—it's very, very difficult for the French to communicate with one another at all. Basically, the marshals don't help one another. Soult, Masséna and Ney—Masséna and Ney fall out to the point that Masséna has to actually sack Ney and send him back to France because Ney refuses to take Soult's orders any longer. Suchet refuses to help Soult, who refuses to help Marmont. By "help," I mean send troops—they're always looking to defend their own number of troops and not help the people in the next door provinces. So opportunities, if they had worked together to crush various Spanish forces between them, are missed time and again.
- 4.56 Napoleon can't, except for when he's actually on the ground for three months in late 1808 and early 1809, can't coordinate the marshals, or at least they don't do what he says. If they do, it's months too late. They don't get the orders, many of them, for weeks anyway, because you have to send a huge body of men to actually take orders from one part of Spain to another, because they will be attacked by the marauding local warlords who, when they capture French soldiers, torture them horribly before they're allowed to be killed. They're nailed to barn doors and nailed to trees and so on, forced to die unbelievably painfully.
- 4.57 So as a result, as you can imagine, as always happens in these dirty wars, the result is that the French then torture Spanish and Portuguese guerrillas who they capture under arms, and the whole thing spirals into—again, Goya captures it most brilliantly when you see the severed arms and legs of various French soldiers put up on trees in order to discourage other soldiers. It's a really, really nasty campaign, and the French see very little way out. If a message takes six weeks to get from Andalusia to Napoleon in Paris, and then another six weeks to get back, essentially, whatever is happening is three

months late. The marshals know that, and they use it in order to say that the situation has changed, and I can't do what Napoleon and Berthier are telling me to.

- 4.58** So the Spanish War, the Spanish ulcer, it's called the Peninsular War, is a massive drain on Napoleon's resources at a time when he can least afford it, because just as he was about to chase after Sir John Moore up in Corunna, he then has to stop at Valladolid, I think it was, and return to Paris. The reason is that he has two things that he's got to get back for.
- 4.59** Firstly, Talleyrand—the unbelievably wily and frankly untrustworthy Foreign Minister who has served the Revolution—he's a defrocked bishop and an aristocrat who served the Revolution, served the Directory, served the Consulate, served the Empire, but at the same time was always serving himself and doing deals in contact with the enemy and taking bribes and so on—he and the secret police commander, Fouché, later the Duke of Otranto, seemed to be in cahoots working against Napoleon. Napoleon gets news of this and worries about it, and wants to get back to Paris.
- 4.60** When he does, he confronts Talleyrand and says, "You're just a shit in a silk stocking," and momentarily, at least, dismisses Talleyrand. Not for long, he should have had him shot; it would have been much more better for his regime, frankly. So that's one reason he has to leave Spain.
- 4.61** The other is that Austria is rearming, and it looks like Austria is going to try again, just as it did in 1805, to rip up the peace treaty and defeat Napoleon. In my next lecture, I will tell you about the campaign in Austria, which winds up with the famous Battle of Wagram. Ladies and gentlemen, thank you so much.
- 4.62** We spoke earlier about his emergent sense of greatness and using this halfway point as an artificial moment in time. What's his self-awareness of where he is on the trajectory at this moment in time? Is it inevitable? Does he have a self-awareness of what could go right or what could go wrong?
- 4.63** Yes, he had huge self-awareness. He was a highly intelligent man. He also, because of his reading of history, recognized that great empires rise and fall, but he very much felt that his was on the rise.
- 4.64** By 1809, it was. Apart from the Spanish ulcer, overall, he was doing well. He had made this peace with Russia, which had been a traditional enemy, a very dangerous enemy, and all of that seemed to be over. He was safe on his throne. The French people were behind him. He thought that he could muscle Britain into a negotiated peace. If he could, then he felt his problems would be over. So it was not quite the zenith of the empire—that comes in the next lecture—but he's on his way there.
- 4.65** What he doesn't factor in enough, really, is, first of all, the Spanish ulcer starting to get really bad, which it does in late 1811 and certainly 1812. He doesn't really factor in the problem that the Russians can change their mind, again, obviously. He also hasn't truly

grasped the problems of the marshals all falling out with one another and the effect that that would have in military terms.

- 4.66 So there are problems. He's a fantastically intelligent figure who can spot them. There are lots of problems that he deals with, especially internally. Yes, he's worried about, and rightly so, but it's his own problem, his own making, the way in which, however many times you beat Austria, as you'll see with the Wagram campaign, they keep coming back. That's a problem fueled by British cash; the Austrians return again and again and again. So he has to try and work out what he's going to do long term about that, and he comes up with a scheme in 1810.
- 4.67 At the beginning of the lecture, you mentioned that he only sleeps for four hours each night. I guess people were a bit different back then. Or how do you think this compromised his decision-making, emotional regulation, and performance?
- 4.68 Well, he also took catnaps. So it wasn't just four hours. He was able to grab a quarter of an hour here or 10 minutes there. I don't think it did affect his performance, not negatively, anyhow. It meant that he was able to run his entire empire from a very centralized position. Margaret Thatcher actually only slept four hours a night, and she also catnapped often before Prime Minister's questions. Some people can; other people can't. The only reason I mentioned it, I think, was that it meant that he was able to work a 20-hour day. You can get an awful lot more done than if you have eight hours of solid sleep, like we're all told by the doctors that we're supposed to.
- 4.69 You mentioned several problems that Napoleon had that you say that he considered and perhaps didn't deal with particularly, but certainly recognized that they were there. I think I remember reading somewhere that Napoleon had said that his biggest mistake was not paying enough attention to L'Ouverture after the Haitian revolt. Do you think that he actually meant that as a problem that actually he'd missed, or is that a distraction to draw attention away from the other more European problems that he didn't pay enough attention to?
- 4.70 I think certainly the latter, yes. The French record in Haiti was a terrible one, and it was monstrous. The death of L'Ouverture— actually in the Jura Mountains, you can go into the actual dungeon that he was kept in, completely freezing cold. It's a forbidden place when you go there. You feel for this person who, of course, was brought up in the West Indies. But the idea that that was his biggest mistake, considering that Haiti wasn't that important—the price of sugar obviously went up as a result of the Haitian revolution. But compared to revanchist Austria, which went to war for 109 months against Napoleon, I think, is pie in the sky, frankly.
- 4.71 My main question is: Napoleon obviously made a lot of friends and a lot of enemies. Did that enemy and allies that he made, does it still have influence or did it create any precedence for the world allies that we see today?

4.72 Well, yes, it did actually, because it was when the allies came together in the Congress of Vienna that Napoleon, which happened after the fall of Napoleon, that the British and French made friends and were not to fight each other ever again. They had been fighting each other for 22 years prior to 1815, the Congress of Vienna. Over the previous hundreds of years, they were fighting each other for something like 75% of the time. But obviously, afterwards, they were on the same side in the Crimean War, the same side in the First World War and the Second World War, at least for parts of the Second World War. So it is a sea change, a massive sea change that overcomes the Anglo-French relationship once Napoleon is defeated.

Lecture 5: Austrian & Spanish Campaigns

At a glance — The Austrian and Spanish campaigns and their strains on the empire.

- 5.1 Napoleon's campaign against Austria—the war was started by the Austrians as usual—began with a ruse de guerre. The French army was able to get into a position in April 1809 to be able to take on the Austrian army at a battle called Aspern-Essling.
- 5.2 Now, it's important to get the geography right for this. There was an island called the Island of Lobau, a very small island. It's tiny, in fact, which was in the middle of the Danube River. In order to get the army across the Danube onto the plain that they wanted to fight the Austrians on, they needed to cross two sets of bridges: one going onto the island and the other coming off from the island.
- 5.3 The bridges going over to the island were incredibly rickety; they were small. They were made of wood that the—what were called pontonniers, the French bridge builders—had built. And the Austrians— and by the way, it was freezing cold. There was ice going down the river. But there was also, much more importantly, lots of debris that upstream the Austrians were putting into the river and trying to smash the causeway bridge. In fact, at one point, they knocked down a mill, an entire water mill, and they put all the wood from the mill down to try to destroy the bridge.
- 5.4 Once the army had gone over onto the island and then had debouched into the plain beyond the island, the Austrians did manage to smash the bridge behind. Essentially, the French army was stuck on the other side of the Danube with the Austrian army coming towards it and no means of escape if they were to lose the battle.
- 5.5 They fought this battle of Aspern-Essling. It's called that because there's one village called Aspern, and about three or four miles on the same bank of the river, another village called Essling. If you go to that battlefield—I do recommend it—you can see the barn at Aspern; it's the great granary barn that was one end of Napoleon's line.
- 5.6 Then there's the village of Essling at the other end. He had his cannon placed in the center, and he made a series of very brave cavalry charges. Bessières led several of them. It was where Marshal Lannes and Marshal Masséna were hoping to stop and defeat the Austrian army. But they were heavily outnumbered, and the Austrians had large numbers of guns as well. After the artillery duel, there was an infantry duel, and after the infantry duel, there were cavalry charges backwards and forwards.
- 5.7 It became clear that Napoleon had to retreat. Fortunately, just in time, the pontonniers managed to rebuild one of the two bridges. So in a very, very difficult military maneuver that was brilliantly organized—not least by the Chief of Staff Berthier— the army was able at nightfall to get back over onto the island of Lobau. So this is another defeat, essentially, for Napoleon.

- 5.8** To make it worse, when, during the battle, Marshal Lannes sat down and there was a lull in the fighting—you often get this actually in Napoleonic battles, moments where the battle dies down, ready for the next group of reinforcements to be sent into the battle—he crossed his legs. At that point, a cannonball ricocheted and hit him in the knees— both knees, he had his legs crossed.
- 5.9** So he had to be taken from the battlefield in immense pain. It took him nine days to die, not from the actual wound itself, but from the gangrene that came in after the wound was dealt. He died in immense pain, of course. Napoleon went to visit him every day, and he lost one of his closest friends. His greatest friends were Marshal Bessières and Desaix, who was killed at the Battle of Marengo, and Marshal Lannes.
- 5.10** What they had to do then was to go back to Vienna, and they waited for another two months for reinforcements to come from Paris. And then they went back over the much stronger now bridge of boats, over into exactly the same place as they were before, the plains, the flat plain—it's called the Marchfeld, and it's a completely flat, like the top of a plateau. In fact, it was used by the Austrian army for maneuvers because it was so flat. You got very good cavalry ground. That's what you need with cavalry: flat ground.
- 5.11** There they fought the Battle of Wagram, which is one of the great Napoleonic battles. It goes over two days, the fifth and the sixth of July 1809. This is important because almost all of those battles that I've mentioned already— from the Italian campaign and other campaigns, really—just take place on one day. The decision is: they start fighting soon after dawn, and by the time the sun goes down that same day, one side or the other will have won. That no longer becomes the case after about 1809. You get many more battles that go over two days, and sometimes, in the case of the Battle of Leipzig, three days.
- 5.12** This is bad for Napoleon because it tends to mean that the allies he's fighting against have more time to bring up reinforcements during the night. So two-day campaigns don't allow for these great coups, these great acts of maneuver, these enveloping attacks on the flanks that Napoleon used to win battles with so successfully earlier in his career.
- 5.13** At Wagram, he wins again. There's a moment where Masséna, who has fallen off his horse and isn't able to walk or ride, essentially directs the battle—for his corps, at least—from his carriage, which was quite a brave thing to do apart from anything else, because obviously it drew the attention of all the Austrian artillery to fire at his carriage.
- 5.14** Marshal MacDonald manages to bring his entire corps from one side of the battlefield, where he's no longer needed, in square formation—remember, I told you yesterday about how squares couldn't be attacked successfully by cavalry? In square formation,

he brought them right the way across the other side of the battlefield, where he was badly needed. So he did extremely well at Wagram.

- 5.15** Overall, the organization of it by Berthier allowed Berthier later to be dubbed the Prince de Wagram. So it was a victory, but not a decisive one, because so much of the Austrian army was able to retreat in good order. And although they were off the battlefield, nonetheless, the Austrian army had not been completely annihilated. They go back to a place called Znaim, and then there's an armistice. So Napoleon has won the Wagram campaign, but not decisively.
- 5.16** What he does in 1810 is to use a brilliant tactic, essentially, to make peace with the Austrians, which is to marry the daughter of the Emperor of Austria. Francis II of Austria's daughter was the Archduchess Marie-Louise. She was 18 years old; Napoleon was 40, and they got married on the 2nd of April 1810. In fact, rather weirdly, in the 18th century, you could get married without being present. He was officially married in March, the previous month, and Berthier took the place of Napoleon in Vienna to marry Louise. But the wedding that we all understand, where you do at least have both the bride and the bridegroom present, took place at the Louvre on the 2nd of April. What this effectively did was therefore make France and Austria into allies.
- 5.17** Of course, before he was able to do that, he had to divorce Joséphine, who was 47, and was no longer going to be able to give him an heir— one of the major reasons, apart from wanting peace, was also that he very much wanted to have an heir to the Empire, who was the King of Rome, and he was born in 1811. But his relationship with Joséphine was a long and loving one. I mentioned earlier about how much he adored her and fancied her. He found out on the Egyptian campaign that she was being unfaithful to him. He came and raged about it, but nonetheless forgave her.
- 5.18** He also embarked, whilst in Egypt, on the first of his 22 affairs with mistresses. He had children by some of them, proving, therefore, that he was capable of having children. He was very generous to his mistresses, which was easy to do because he was basically paying them out of the French treasury rather than out of his own pocket.
- 5.19** The peace with Austria was always going to be a difficult one because he was not giving back any of the lands that he had taken after the Austerlitz campaign of 1805. Also, the foreign minister and later Chancellor of Austria, Klemens von Metternich, was fundamentally opposed to the French alliance. He had been an ambassador to Paris. He knew Napoleon, and he knew Napoleon's ambition and the effect that that was likely to have on long-term Franco-Austrian peace.
- 5.20** Klemens von Metternich was a truly brilliant diplomat; he was one of the great diplomats of the 19th century. One thinks of Talleyrand, of Lord Castlereagh, the British Foreign Secretary, and Klemens von Metternich—these are the giants who dominated the diplomacy of those years. He recognized the long-term threat to Austria that Napoleon's demand for hegemony in Europe posed.

- 5.21** Now, there is a huge problem that Napoleon still has— remember, even though he's managed to make peace with Russia in 1807 and now Austria in 1810 by marrying Marie-Louise—and that is still Spain. Spain, the Spanish ulcer, as he called it, was a problem for him throughout this period. Sometime in 1810, as well as enjoying the attentions of his young wife and creating the King of Rome, he should have found time to have returned to Spain and dealt with the problem there, specifically with the Duke of Wellington constantly using Portugal as his springboard to make attacks into Spain.
- 5.22** There's one which ends in the Battle of Talavera, which is a terrible battle where the wounded are all lying in a cornfield. Then, as cornfields do on hot days in July, if there's a battle going on, it caught fire, and these poor wounded men were all burned to death. Some of these battles really are truly horrific.
- 5.23** But what Napoleon should have done was to have gone to Spain and to have fought Wellington. As it was, he only ever fought Wellington in one battle in either of their careers—we'll be coming on to that, needless to say, in a few lectures' time. What he does instead is to send Marshal Masséna. Marmont is already there. Masséna, this great marshal who was so successful in so many battles—the Battle of Zurich that we mentioned, the Italian campaign, and so on, this great marshal— along with Davout, the best of the marshals as a soldier, a strategist, and a tactician. He sends him to try to capture Lisbon and defeat Wellington, who is in Lisbon.
- 5.24** Masséna doesn't want to go. There's a real rule in history that I feel ought to be more widely accepted and appreciated, which is that if a commander doesn't want to command a campaign, don't send him on one. Masséna was ill. He'd had his eye shot out by Napoleon in a hunting accident, which also was obviously not ideal. He'd had that fall from the horse that I mentioned earlier just before the Battle of Wagram. He was gouty, and he wanted to essentially retire and enjoy being a prince and having huge amounts of money—large amounts of it stolen by him on these various campaigns.
- 5.25** The last thing he wanted was to go and risk his reputation and career and try to force Wellington out of Lisbon, force him to evacuate the British, essentially back to Britain and retake Portugal. But Napoleon absolutely insisted. He called him the "darling child of victory" and said that it would be easy, and also told him that he would ensure that Masséna got everything he needed when it came to reinforcements, arms, ammunition, food, and so on, that he was going to be incredibly well supplied.
- 5.26** He also told Masséna that he was going to be able to appoint his own lieutenants, but it became quite clear very soon after that that, in fact, his lieutenants were going to be Junot and Ney. You'll recall how Ney was impossible as a subordinate, owing to the fact that he didn't take orders from anyone, really, apart from the Emperor. That was the point at which Masséna should have said, "No, I'm not going at all because I'm not allowed to take my own lieutenants." But he didn't; he went to Portugal.

- 5.27 When he, in October 1810, with this large army, got to within 15 miles of Lisbon—he'd already had to fight a battle called Bussaco, in which Wellington held him up, and it allowed Wellington to get back into Lisbon—there is a particular day that Masséna gets to 15 miles outside Lisbon and suddenly sees something that he should have been warned about and extraordinarily wasn't, which is something called the Lines of Torres Vedras.
- 5.28 The Lines of Torres Vedras are a brilliant series of fortifications, many of them still around today. I do recommend—I'm constantly recommending, aren't I, in this lecture series, but I've visited 53 of Napoleon's 60 battlefields in 16 countries. I'm a true believer when it comes to actually physically seeing these places.
- 5.29 The Lines of Torres Vedras are one of the most impressive views that you get in the whole of the Napoleonic series of battlefields, because what Wellington did, or at least Wellington's engineers did, and the Portuguese who put the muscle into it—and it must have been the most extraordinary amount of work involved; they were paid to do it, and of course, it was very much in their interest that their capital shouldn't fall to the French again— but what they did was to create these miles and miles, nearly 30 miles of fortresses using the escarpments and the mountains that are outside Lisbon, that ring Lisbon on every side, except obviously the sea, and it was impossible to get through them.
- 5.30 You'd have a mountain and an escarpment, and then suddenly fortifications connecting the two, which were fully manned by the Portuguese army and the British army. They go all the way around. Masséna rides up to them. Somebody fires a cannonball at Masséna and misses, and Masséna doffs his hat, goes back to his headquarters and starts the siege. The siege goes on for months and months and months. It's not until January 1811, by which time his army is starving at his headquarters in Santarém, outside the Lines of Torres Vedras, that he realizes that he has to go back.
- 5.31 The reason that his army is starving is because Wellington has adopted the policy of scorched earth. This is a policy whereby, when the Portuguese were moving back towards Lisbon, they destroyed everything. They cut down the olive trees. An olive tree can live for many hundreds of years, but not obviously if it's cut down and rooted up. They herded all of their cattle, every single animal, back into Lisbon, behind the Lines of Torres Vedras. These poor Portuguese peasants had their homes set fire to, or set fire to their own homes on occasion, in order for the French army to have nothing that they could live off. They could not live off the land, that key Napoleonic policy that dated back to Italy.
- 5.32 And so whilst the people behind the Lines of Torres Vedras and in Lisbon were able to eat, the French army at Santarém couldn't. The huge amounts of supplies that Napoleon had promised were not forthcoming. As I said, in January 1811, Masséna, with this ill, famished, broken army, had to pull back.

- 5.33** This is the point where there was a series of, basically, frankly, mutinous rows between Masséna and Ney—Ney, who didn't really have a very much better argument about what to do, frankly, but he gainsaid every decision of Masséna as Masséna was withdrawing out of Portugal into Spain. Of course, Wellington came out of the Lines of Torres Vedras to chase Masséna out of Portugal. Every decision of where to fight Wellington was questioned by Ney. The popularity of Masséna collapsed in his own army, the Army of Portugal. In the end, he was forced out of Spain.
- 5.34** Napoleon, instead of supporting Masséna, supported Ney. Although Ney had been sent back to Paris by Masséna, Masséna himself was then recalled and stripped of his command. And so the "darling child of victory" was essentially humiliated and disgraced by Napoleon.
- 5.35** This is an important aspect of Napoleon—he was very kind to people who were successful, and he made them counts and princes and dukes and gave them huge amounts of money. They were called dotations. He would give hundreds of thousands of francs in dotations. They would wind up with massive estates. He would make them sovereign princes and so on.
- 5.36** But if you lost, then there was a stick as well as those carrots I've just mentioned. You could be busted down. They all kept their title of Marshal at this point, but they were a disgrace. They were sent off to internal exile on their estates, essentially, and not employed. To some people, Marshal Macdonald, for five years, was disgraced, not for a defeat; that was for an act of political opposition. But he was harsh on you if you didn't match up to his expectations.
- 5.37** The series of battles that take place in the peninsula is key to Napoleon's rule, which is why I'm going to talk to you about them, despite the fact that he wasn't there. He didn't go back after he had left in January of 1809 in order to go off and fight the Austrians; he never returned to Spain—a major, major problem.
- 5.38** Because you have battles such as Albuera in May of 1811. I've already told you about the Battle of Fuentes de Oñoro, which Masséna had to fight. It's 11 miles wide, the front at Fuentes de Oñoro—usually, Napoleonic battlefields are about three, five miles wide. Battle of Waterloo, three and a half miles wide, for example. Fuentes de Oñoro was a really wide battle. It's 11 miles wide, which worked to Wellington's advantage because he had more cavalry and better-foraged cavalry.
- 5.39** The Battle of Albuera, however, was completely different. This was a battle between Marshal Beresford, the British and the French, which was a terrible battle because neither side was willing to withdraw. They came within just a few yards of each other. It was a bit like a First World War battle where there were no trenches, essentially. They were so close to one another that they used the corpses of their comrades as balustrades over which to fight. So as the corpses built up, they would be hauled in, and the soldiers would fire from behind a great wall of corpses on both sides; it was

just an appalling battle. Between 4,000 and 7,000 people killed in that single battle alone, both sides declaring victory.

- 5.40 But in fact, it was a true Pyrrhic victory. And this is something you get more and more towards the end of the Napoleonic Wars, Pyrrhic victories that are so costly to both sides that ultimately it's worse for France because France, of course, has a smaller population than the combined populations of the allied coalition governments.
- 5.41 You then have the fall of Ciudad Rodrigo, which is one of the key fortresses between Portugal and France, which surrenders in January of 1812. Then, between March and April 1812, Badajoz, another nodal-point fortress, which is the gateway to Portugal, is captured by Wellington.
- 5.42 In July of 1812, Marshal Marmont fights the Battle of Salamanca—this is a wonderful battlefield, by the way, completely untouched. You have the Lower Arapile and the Upper Arapile. These are mountains—well, they're not mountains; they're small hills, really. They're outside the beautiful ancient city of Salamanca. You have the bigger one and the smaller one. Marmont and Wellington were marching on either side of these hills, with a hill in between them; they were marching parallel.
- 5.43 Wellington was watching incredibly closely to see if there was a moment when he could—he rode about 20 miles during the battle. He desperately needed to work out whether any units of Marmont's army went faster than the others, and therefore, a gap opened up between them. And as he got past the lesser Arapile, he noticed that that had happened.
- 5.44 So he sent his cavalry in between the two sections of Marmont's army, fell upon the larger of the two sections, and by the time the other one was able to rearrange itself and organize itself, Wellington had won a major victory at Salamanca. The smaller of the two French units had moved away, and Wellington had won the day.
- 5.45 He never lost a gun; he never lost a battle, which, considering that he had fought in India as well, in charge of the sepoys, the Indian forces who were fighting for the British Raj, and fought several battles in India, as well as the Portuguese campaign, and obviously, Waterloo, quite an extraordinary achievement. He was turned back from Burgos. Between September and October 1812, he besieged the important city of Burgos, and he was forced to retreat from that when French forces came to relieve Burgos. But that wasn't a defeat. As I say, he didn't lose a gun.
- 5.46 He later came back on the 21st of June 1813 with a smashing victory over Jourdan and Joseph at the Battle of Vitoria, which was so much of a rout that it essentially forced the French to evacuate Spain. Then it was Marshal Soult, who had to conduct a very, very long and harsh rear guard campaign—the Battles of Nive and Nivelle— finally ending on the 10th of April 1814, at the Battle of Toulouse, which Wellington also won. It was a long and painful withdrawal.

- 5.47** There were some successful marshals in Spain. Suchet on the Eastern side of Spain did pretty well, but even he was forced to retreat after the Battle of Vitoria. In fact, if you go to Windsor Castle, you can see Jourdan's baton, which was captured at the Battle of Vitoria, and so were all of the King of Spain's great art collection.
- 5.48** And so when the Duke of Wellington gave the art collection back or offered to give the art collection back, the King of Spain said, "No, it's your heroism that has won me my country back," along, obviously, with the Spanish soldiers and guerrillas. He said, "You keep the art collection." If today you go to Apsley House on Hyde Park Corner, you can see the magnificent Goyas and Velázquez. In fact, it's difficult to think of a great artist who isn't in some way represented in that amazing collection that's up in the Waterloo Gallery at Apsley House.
- 5.49** One of the great tragedies and painful facts about the Battle of Toulouse is that, actually, Napoleon had abdicated four days earlier, and so the battle needn't have taken place, but the news of the peace had not reached Soult or Wellington by the time the battle took place. So everybody who was killed in that battle, essentially, died for nothing. It's one of the great sadnesses and ironies, essentially, of the Napoleonic Wars, in my view.
- 5.50** So you have this long-running Spanish ulcer, which draws in a quarter of a million—and kills or wounds a quarter of a million of the French army. That sounds like it should be the death knell of any regime. But actually, as you'll discover in the next lecture, much worse things happen in Russia. Thank you very much.
- 5.51** We started off by talking about a ploy, an act of deception, and then continued on to speak of battles where Napoleon himself wasn't physically present. And throughout the course of these five hours, we've spoken a lot about facts, figures, and events. But we, throughout that, saw that your mission is very hard, as a historian, to articulate the presence of charm and sexiness and charisma. I'm wondering at what point Napoleon's myth might have taken on a life of its own?
- 5.52** So on the one hand, he's able to inspire troops to fight in a battle in a completely separate country. But then, on the other, he may become a known quantity in advance, where you mentioned that his preferential tactics aren't as successful in elongated battles and that countries, like Portugal, were able to prepare for him in advance and to what might he have become a victim of his own success in that regard?
- 5.53** Yes, that's a very good question. He was certainly becoming a victim of his own success, not least because the allies, after carefully analyzing what he had been doing and really looking into the way in which he had been so successful over them, learnt their lessons and adapted their strategy accordingly.
- 5.54** They had an understanding that you basically don't fight Napoleon directly if you can avoid it, and instead concentrate on attacking his marshals, which was easier in Spain because Napoleon wasn't there at all. But that also becomes true in the later

campaigns, especially the 1813 campaign, where the allies go out of their way to avoid fighting Napoleon in person and concentrate instead on his lieutenants.

- 5.55** The other thing that is very important is that they learn the corps system, which I mentioned about how the corps system were basically creating mini-armies. Well, by 1812, all of the allied forces had themselves adopted the corps system. You got a much more efficient Austrian army, Russian army, British army, and so on, because they were fighting Napoleon essentially with his own tactics. So yes, his enemies were not just sitting back and constantly taking it. They were thinking about how to use his own successes against him.
- 5.56** I'm sorry, this is a very military question rather than a conceptual one. It's something that I've never understood. I wondered if you could clear up for me—I've read that, and you mentioned today, that Napoleon puts his cannons in the middle of his army. So he's got the *pas de charge*—incredibly successful, enormously frightening, massive troops going towards the enemy lines, cannons in the middle.
- 5.57** What the British tended to do was to put their cannons on the end of the line. So if you got your cannons in the middle and you got a mass of men walking forward, there comes a point where you can't use your cannons because otherwise, you shoot your own men in the back. Whereas the British can provide covering fire from the sides of their armies for longer. I have just simply never understood why such a genius of artillery knowledge and concept could make such what seems to me—not being military—to be a fundamental error. Can you clear that up for me?
- 5.58** Yes. You're wrong about him putting his artillery in the middle all the time. He didn't. He did at the Battle of Aspern-Essling, and you get it to a degree with a ground battery at the Battle of Waterloo. But otherwise, no, he would parcel out batteries of cannon wherever he felt that they were needed. Of course, if you could get some higher ground, that was always important. You, by and large, needed to make sure that artillery was able to cover the fields of fire necessary. So you don't put them in front of undulating ground where you can't actually hit the opponents.
- 5.59** So no, he was a genius when it came to artillery placement. It was just that particular battle because he knew that he would be taking on larger forces that were going to be coming at him, that he tried to turn the center of the battlefield into dead ground.
- 5.60** Had Napoleon not given up on the notion of meritocracy and promoted his own family, do you think that the marshals' hostilities amongst themselves might have been muted because there would have been the possibility of more kingdoms which they could have been rulers of, more [principalities]? They would still have been competitive, surely, but it might have redirected their energies towards Napoleon's ends.
- 5.61** Yes, I do think that. The marshals—especially once Murat became King of Naples, and as we will be coming on to Bernadotte becoming King of Sweden—both of them essentially turn the rest of the marshals into an incredibly jealous bunch who all want

to become kings themselves. Nicolas Soult wants to become King of Portugal. Poniatowski wants to become King of Poland. His uncle was the King of Poland. Actually, also it's thought that Murat would like to have become King of Poland as well as King of Naples. Davout is supposed to also have hoped that he was going to become King of Poland.

- 5.62 So if it had been more of a meritocracy and more of those marshals had been able to have got the kingdoms such as Holland and Westphalia and others that were parceled out to the Bonaparte family—Spain, of course, as well. Then, certainly, there might have been a bit less of this internecine hatred that's going on in the marshalate. However, equally, it might have just meant that lesser marshals would have been just as jealous and difficult and ill-tempered with the ones who had wound up getting kingdoms.
- 5.63 You described Napoleon as being very precise and micromanaging, [deciding] where the cannons should be positioned. You also described him to be telling jokes to his people and caring about them like a father would care about his child. He was promoting people to become millionaires with a medal of honor. After that, he stands up, goes to the map and says, "And now we are invading Russia."
- 5.64 This is quite a large range of human behavior. I'm interested in—according to today's standards—if Napoleon would qualify for a mental condition or a psychiatric disorder, if we are looking at this behavior.
- 5.65 I don't think so. I think this is very much what a conqueror needed to be able to do in the 18th century. I don't think it turns you into a sociopath that you have to do so many different things all at the same time. It's just the Arctic loneliness of command that these people had to deal with, in particular, of course, at the very apex of his rule.
- 5.66 No, I'm always very nerve-wracked, really, about trying to ascribe modern-day pathologies to people who've been dead 200 years. It's done constantly, people saying that Nelson had this or that Julius Caesar had that disease, when you actually don't have the patient in front of you in order to diagnose them. No, I don't think he did have an issue, a problem, medically, apart from obviously the ones like hemorrhoids that we do know about. But as far as mental diseases are concerned, no.
- 5.67 In the next lecture, I'll be talking about the concept of the Napoleon complex.

Lecture 6: Napoleon's Invasion of Russia

At a glance — The catastrophic 1812 invasion of Russia.

- 6.1 Napoleon's invasion of Russia is sometimes put down to the fact that he had a Napoleon complex. This is, to put it at its crudest, the fact that he is a short man, which we've already established—he wasn't—and therefore he had a lot to prove, and therefore he went around invading countries.
- 6.2 Apparently, there is a Napoleon complex, but Napoleon himself did not have one. He was perfectly justified in wanting to go to war with Russia in 1812. It became obvious by March of 1812 that he was facing the Russian complete abandonment of what had been agreed at Tilsit. The Tsar was beginning to trade with England, which, it had been established at Tilsit that he wouldn't. They were also arguing over various rulers in Germany as well. So it was a clear breakdown, and it was going to lead to a clash.
- 6.3 Napoleon only really wanted to go about 50 miles into Russia. He wanted a three-week campaign. He certainly had no plans to go all the way to Moscow. He also had beaten the Russians twice in the 1805 campaign and in the 1806 to '07 campaign. He had an army well over twice the size of the Russian army. There were about a quarter of a million Russians facing his force of 615,000, which was the largest army in the history of the world at that time, the same size as Paris. So it wasn't an insane idea to invade Russia.
- 6.4 What went wrong was that he went too far into Russia. Although Tolstoy's *War and Peace* is one of the greatest novels ever written, it gets the 1812 campaign completely wrong. It argues essentially that there was a deterministic force which had nothing to do with Napoleon, which drove France to invade Russia in 1812. This is rubbish. In fact, it did come down to Napoleon. If Napoleon had not wanted to invade Russia in 1812, France would not have invaded. So don't listen to Leo Tolstoy on this. Listen to me.
- 6.5 The assumption that the cold weather was the only thing that wrecked Napoleon's campaign is also wrong. In fact, it was the hot weather that they had to face as they were moving hundreds and hundreds of miles into Russia that caused the first set of problems.
- 6.6 Firstly, it exhausted the horses. They didn't bring enough forage. The Russians adopted the scorched-earth policy that I mentioned earlier, that Wellington had adopted on the way back to Lisbon, but the Russians adopted it in a far, far wider geographical area, and it was just as vicious. So the Napoleonic soldiers had nothing to live off.
- 6.7 They also suffered from typhus, which is an appalling disease. There was a tick that, when the men were huddled together at night, they got lice and various ticks and animals that dug into them—a little bit like Lyme disease ticks. What happened was they would burrow deep into your skin and then die in your body. This would get very

badly infected. After five or six days, you would die in terrible agony. This happened to no fewer than 100,000 French troops on the way to Russia, on the way into Moscow.

6.8 So already, of his huge central fighting force, you already had lost one-sixth by the time you actually got to fight the Battle of Borodino on the 7th of September 1812. They hadn't lost a battle up until then. They'd captured Smolensk. They'd moved from Smolensk further on in. Napoleon was enticed, essentially, in. He had a choice of going north to St. Petersburg because, of course, the Russians have two capitals—in St. Petersburg and Moscow.

6.9 He decided to go from Moscow. It was the main road link, essentially. It was one of the great capitals. It had the Kremlin and so on. But the Tsar himself was in St. Petersburg at this time. Outside Borodino, about 75 miles or so outside Moscow, there was the Battle of Borodino, and it was another of these Pyrrhic victories that I mentioned because of the huge losses on both sides, the equivalent of a jumbo jet smashing into the ground and killing everybody on board every five minutes for the seven hours of the battle—that's how many people were killed.

6.10 The Russians, who suffered greater casualties, drew back and allowed Napoleon to keep the battlefield, and therefore, Napoleon claims it as a victory. You will see that Moscova is one of the battle honors that he has around his tomb, along with genuine victories like Rivoli, I think, is there, Marengo is there, but there's also the Moscowa, which is the French word for the Battle of Borodino, which the Russians called Borodino. That was on the 7th of September.

6.11 By the 16th of September, the French were in Moscow. They had the Kremlin. They captured the Kremlin. Napoleon himself put himself into the Kremlin and lived there for the next month before they left on the 18th of October. But soon after he moved into the Kremlin, there was a terrible fire. This was started deliberately by the Russians. Rostopchin, their governor, actually ordered Russians to set fire to their own capital. That's a sign of quite how fanatical they were about expelling the French invader. It was not just a scorched-earth, but a scorched-city policy.

6.12 The French managed to put out most of the fire. They caught 300 incendieursts who they shot. But nonetheless, it made it much more difficult for the French occupying army to stay in Moscow. They weren't going to be able to stay for the entire winter. At some stage, they had to leave. Napoleon put it off as long as he possibly could because he was expecting peace negotiations to start with the Tsar. But Tsar Alexander I wasn't going to make peace. He wasn't about to start negotiating.

6.13 For this, Napoleon was unprepared, owing to the fact that every time he had marched into an enemy capital—be it Berlin or Vienna or Cairo—the enemy would negotiate. But this time, not least, of course, because the Russians have two capitals, it didn't happen. So there was a long period where Napoleon should have retreated from Moscow, but he didn't. It wasn't, as I say, until the 18th of October 1812, that he did,

giving orders to Marshal Mortier to blow up the Kremlin, which Mortier tried to do rather half-heartedly and didn't really succeed in doing.

- 6.14 Now, I've been asked about how he was able to keep lots of different ideas, sometimes completely opposing ideas, in his head at the same time; how he was not able to be so overwhelmed with what was going on that he wasn't able to do anything else, the way in which he was able to run his empire despite being on campaign. This is an essential feature about Napoleon, which is his immense capacity to compartmentalize.
- 6.15 A classic example happens during the fire in the Kremlin. He was forced to leave the Kremlin for a few days in order to live in a palace outside Moscow because of the fire, at least in the outskirts of Moscow. It was when he was there that he wrote the rules of the Comédie-Française. So, there's a massive fire in Moscow. You're 1800 plus miles away from France. You fought this massive battle of Borodino, and you've captured one of the enemy's capitals. And nonetheless, you are able to sit down and write the rules for this new comedy troupe—or at least acting troupe—that is opening in Paris.
- 6.16 He was also able, on the eve of the Battle of Austerlitz—again, think of all the things that you have on your mind prior to a massive battle in Bohemia, a make-or-break battle for you, because that was when he wrote the regulations setting up a girls' school in Saint-Denis.
- 6.17 He was on campaign at one point when he wrote to the prefect in Genoa telling him to stop taking his mistress to the opera. It was an extraordinary mind that allowed him, even in battles, to write letters. Cannonballs are flying, and he will sit down and dictate a letter that has got absolutely nothing to do with the battle at hand. Now, that is a very unusual capacity, but one that Napoleon had, and one which, overall, of course, he put to very great use because he was able to work so hard. But it does show that he was an extremely unusual figure with a very unusual mind.
- 6.18 The tragedy of the retreat from Moscow, which, of course, is one of the great moments in world history, is it really stems not just from the amount of time that he spent in Moscow, but also the route that he took back from Moscow. The amount of time—actually, he left more time to get from Moscow to Smolensk than he had taken going from Smolensk to Moscow. It wasn't that he had completely run out of time; he hadn't.
- 6.19 It was the fact that on the 25th of October, a week after leaving Moscow, he was stopped at a battle called Maloyaroslavets, which he won. It was fought by his stepson, Eugène, the viceroy of Italy. But it was, again, a Pyrrhic victory. He felt that on the road to Kaluga, which was down in the south, there was a Russian army behind and that he wouldn't be able to brush that out of the way and take his forces down to Kaluga.
- 6.20 If he had done that, he could have got south enough for the winter to be significantly less vicious than it was when it started snowing in full blizzards from the night of the 5th to the 6th of November. But instead, he decided at Maloyaroslavets, after a

conference with his marshals, to adopt the same route back to Smolensk as he had taken via Borodino.

- 6.21** Actually, when they went past the battlefield of Borodino, where all the corpses had been left unburied and stinking, as you could imagine, they could smell the corpses for miles before they actually got to the road going through the battlefield. It was horrific. They found one person, actually, who had been wounded at the battle, who had opened up the carcass of a horse and had lived inside this dead horse for all the time, for the weeks in between. You can imagine what that must have been like. They managed to get that chap back and on the road again. I don't know whether he made it back to Paris, but nonetheless, it was very hard on the army.
- 6.22** They hated all that. The demoralization set in really before the snows came down. But when it did come down, it was absolutely catastrophic for the Grande Armée. There are rumors of cannibalism. Certainly, pretty much all of the discipline broke. The men died by the side of the road. Stragglers were left—in fact, they weren't just left; they were immediately stripped of their clothes, and if they had decent boots on, they'd be stolen. The army collapsed.
- 6.23** There were a few battles that took place along the way, especially the Russian Cossacks tried to kill and capture as many French stragglers as they could. The Russian peasants and partisans tended to torture the French, when caught. So quite a few of them committed suicide on the route back. Of those 615,000 men who went into Russia, half a million died there— died or were captured or so badly wounded that they died later of their wounds. Some were captured and at the end of the Napoleonic Wars, they straggled back to France—we don't have the numbers for that.
- 6.24** The ones who did survive tended to be the ones who were in the northern group under Macdonald, Oudinot, and Saint-Cyr, who could withdraw, although they themselves also had to fight pretty tough battles at Polotsk and elsewhere. But the ones from the central force were absolutely, and in this case, literally decimated. This, of course, meant the end of the Grande Armée in any sensible way of seeing it—the old Grande Armée, the Grande Armée of Wagram and Austerlitz and so on.
- 6.25** There was also an extraordinary epic moment at the Berezina River, where Napoleon got back to the Berezina with Victor, Davout, and a few other of the corps, and he had to cross this river where huge flows of ice, little icebergs, were going down the river. He managed to get some 300 Dutch pontonniers to actually wade into the river and build a trestle bridge that got the army from one side to the other. The bridge kept breaking down and the pontonniers kept going back in. They would then come back, warm themselves by the fire, drink some eau-de-vie, and go back in again to make sure that this bridge was going to be able to be built that could save the army.
- 6.26** It was a miracle that anybody got across, but the people who didn't get across were the stragglers, the women and children who had come on the campaign, the wounded—

they were all left on the wrong side of the river, essentially, when the bridge broke for the last time and were massacred by the Russians. You have this catastrophe.

- 6.27** When Napoleon got to Smorgoni on the 5th of December, he had a conversation with the marshals and decided to go back to Paris himself. He got into a sled with Caulaincourt, his Master of the Horse, who had been Ambassador to Russia, and it was on that sleigh journey that he said that the difference between the sublime and the ridiculous is but a single step. He was talking, of course, about this Russian campaign. It could have been so sublime; it could have been a great victory. But in the end, it turned out to be an utter catastrophic disaster.
- 6.28** But he knew that he had to get back, firstly, to shore up his own political position, because in October of 1812, there had been a rumor in Paris that he had died, and a general in Russia—General Malet— tried to take over the ruling of France, take over the government of France, and was only just prevented from doing so. Nobody thought about Marie-Louise or the King of Rome. Napoleon was furious about the way in which the authorities had dealt with the Malet conspiracy.
- 6.29** He also realized that in order to save the rest of the army, he had to get back to Paris in order to calm the political situation and build a new army. So he wrote a bulletin in which he essentially admitted that there had been a disaster in Russia. He didn't give numbers because he recognized that that would be completely demoralizing for France. He also said that he was in good health, which has forever afterwards been held up as a sign of his selfishness. But actually, it was important in an imperial government; the health of the emperor was always an important statement to make.
- 6.30** So he started to try to conscript a new army. Now, the problem was that people were willing to allow their 17-year-old, 18-year-old children to be conscripted into the French army when it was winning, but they weren't so happy in 1812 and 1813, especially in 1814, to allow their children to go off, their young sons to go off, to fight for a campaign where you had such massive chance of dying or being wounded.
- 6.31** You have a conscription crisis that takes place in 1813, where instead of joining the colors, these young men, fresh out of school, go off and hide in the hills and the mountains and avoid conscription. It becomes much more difficult for the prefects of each of the départements to provide troops for Napoleon. But nonetheless, they do.
- 6.32** The new armies are created. Napoleon, in 1813, fights the battles of Lützen and Bautzen, both, again, victories, but expensive ones. What they have found is that the horses are no longer available because so many horses died in Russia, both on the way to Moscow and obviously freezing to death on the way out, and also being used for food on the way out of Russia as well, that there isn't the cavalry necessary to do the wide encircling, outflanking maneuvers that have been so successful in earlier battles. The lack of cavalry is a major problem.

- 6.33** On the eve of the Battle of Lützen, when part of a reconnaissance patrol, Bessières, his great friend, took a cannonball straight in the chest, killing him instantly. So there's another of his friends— the last, really, of his close friends, after Desaix and Lannes—who dies in 1813.
- 6.34** The Battle of Dresden in August 1813 is a victory for Napoleon, an expensive one, but nonetheless is a victory. What happens then is an armistice that is agreed at a place called Pläswitz. Under the terms of the armistice of Pläswitz, both armies stop for two months—stop fighting. Napoleon has to do this because he needs reinforcements, and he needs more cavalry.
- 6.35** But overall, the armistice is used more successfully by the coalition than by the French. And there's also a meeting at somewhere called Trachenberg, where the allies come together to work out their plan to defeat Napoleon. What they agree at the convention of Trachenberg is that they will not give Napoleon battle where he physically is, but they will attack his lieutenants, his marshals. This is the idea of Bernadotte, who in 1810 had become the King of Sweden with Napoleon's blessing.
- 6.36** Napoleon should not have given his blessing that an enemy of his should have become king of such a strategically important place in the north. If you're trying to invade Russia, you don't want an enemy to your north. Bernadotte made an alliance with the Tsar of Russia. Even though Sweden and Russia had had terrible relations over the years—indeed, Sweden had invaded Russia in the 18th century—nonetheless, there was an agreement between them.
- 6.37** Napoleon had the problem of now a Swedish army joining the Russians, and also in 1813, the Austrians, because Klemens von Metternich recognized his moment. When the Grande Armée was destroyed in Russia, he got the Austrians to change sides. The Austrians had sent a contingent with the French invading Russia, but when it became clear that Napoleon had been defeated, Metternich got the Austrians to change sides. At the same time, at the end of December 1812, the Prussians also changed sides. Napoleon was faced with losing everything in Poland and everything in Germany. The 1813 campaign was essentially about trying to retain Germany.
- 6.38** But what happened when the armistice of Pläswitz came to an end in August was that the agreement at Tauroggen was put into place, and there were a series of defeats that overcame the marshals when Napoleon wasn't present. You have the Battle of Großbeeren, where Oudinot was defeated, the Battle of Dennewitz, where Ney was defeated, the Battle of the Katzbach, where Macdonald was defeated, and also somebody who wasn't a marshal, but would have been had he not been defeated: General Vandamme lost a serious defeat at the Battle of Kulm.
- 6.39** And so what you have by October of 1813 is a really serious danger for the French because you have a force of some 257,000 men from Austria, Prussia, Sweden, Russia,

and some of the smaller German Principalities, all joining together at Leipzig to try to defeat the 177,000 men that Napoleon had managed to get together.

- 6.40 Many of Napoleon's troops were incredibly young—they were 16-year-olds, some of them. They hadn't fought before, of course. They were only being taught how to use muskets on the march to Leipzig. Because they were hairless, they were called Mary-Louises because, of course, the 18-year-old Empress, Marie-Louise, had this lovely fair complexion. Well, the soldiers were nicknamed Mary-Louises because they were so young. They fought well, in fact, actually; the Mary-Louises were brave soldiers. But nonetheless, they, of course, were nothing like the old grizzled, hardened, tough veterans of battles like Austerlitz. Those men had died in the snows of Russia.
- 6.41 At the Battle of Leipzig, which took place between the 16th and 19th of October, there was no fighting on the 17th—that day, they just spent in their cantonments waiting for the battle to resume and bringing up reinforcements and so on. But at that battle—it's named the Battle of the Nations, and there's a fantastic monument there. If you climb to the top of the monument, you can see the whole battlefield in panorama.
- 6.42 The first day went all right for Napoleon. Then there was the second day, the 17th, on which there was no fighting that day. The 18th was a much more dangerous situation for Napoleon because he was outnumbered—177,000 to 157,000. These are massive numbers for Napoleonic campaigns. This is the biggest battle in the history of the world up until that point, even bigger than Borodino. But Napoleon's army has basically been ground down. He's got lots of marshals there: Marmont, Ney, Oudinot, Murat—who's come from Naples, especially to take part in the campaign— Marshal Poniatowski, the Pole, and Marshal Macdonald.
- 6.43 But on the 19th, a catastrophe occurs where the French army is forced to flee back to the bridge over the Elster River at Leipzig. A jittery corporal, there are lots of actual—there's a great deal of disagreements about how this happened, but one of the more believable accounts that I go with is that a jittery corporal, whose job it is to blow up the bridge as soon as the French army is over and before the Austrian-Russian and so on, coalition army, gets to the bridge, he panicked, essentially, and blew it up too early.
- 6.44 He blew it up when there were loads of French soldiers on it, but more importantly, trapping thousands of French soldiers on the wrong side of the river as the coalition forces are moving in for the kill. It's a fast-flowing and wide river, the Elster. So you get a number of soldiers trying to get across and drowning. You get an attempted surrender. And you get some who carry on fighting and who are massacred on the riverbank.
- 6.45 Macdonald rides his horse into the river and somehow manages to—the horse gets swept away, but towards the other side—and he manages to get out and survives. But Poniatowski doesn't; Poniatowski is drowned only two days after he had been made a marshal. In fact, he was made a marshal by Napoleon at the beginning of the Battle of

Leipzig, and he dies two days later, bravely attempting to get his horse. He'd been wounded as well, so it made it much more difficult to climb up the muddy bank of the other side of the river. The 1813 campaign, therefore, ends in disaster.

- 6.46** Napoleon does manage to make it back. There's a battle called Hanau, which the French win, but again, not decisively. The French, therefore, have to evacuate the whole of Germany, apart from a few important cities like Hamburg, which they put garrisons in—this one, in fact, under Marshal Davout, I seem to remember. But otherwise, they're forced back into France itself.
- 6.47** That is where the 1814 campaign is fought, in January of 1814, by which time, Bernadotte of Sweden and the various other commanders—Schwarzenberg of Austria, Wrede, various other important Prussian commanders, including Gebhard von Blücher. There's even a small British contingent. At the Battle of Leipzig, it had rockets, which was a new invention, not terribly successful. Nonetheless, they were there, too. Hence, this term: the Battle of the Nations.
- 6.48** One of the other big problems on the 18th of October, so the day before the catastrophe, was that the Saxons and the Württembergers, who hitherto had been fighting for Napoleon, changed sides during the battle. Instead of them defending an important part of the line, they turned around and started attacking their own, what had hitherto been their own side. So Napoleon and his troops were very conscious of the fact that anyone who wasn't actually French might be about to betray them.
- 6.49** In the 1814 campaign, however, pretty much the only people who fought for Napoleon were French—a few Polish lancers, also very, very good fighters, the Poles, especially cavalry, especially the lancer regiments. But otherwise, it was a small French army, as I say, with much fewer cavalry than they'd had in 1811, 1812.
- 6.50** Nonetheless, Napoleon does show some of his old genius, his old military genius. You see it in the battles. There are four victories that he wins in five days. Again, they're beautiful battlefields. They're untouched. They're just outside Paris. They're in the Champagne region. It doesn't get better than that, frankly, when you go battlefielding. So do go to Champaubert, Montmirail, Château-Thierry, and Vauchamps. There's another lovely battlefield called Montereau, where you climb a hill and you can see the battlefield perfectly. There's a moment where Marshal Lefebvre, apparently foaming at the mouth, charges his hussars down the hillside to capture one of the two bridges there at Montereau.
- 6.51** But however hard they fight, ever-increasing-sized armies are coming: the Russians, the Austrians, the Swedes, and so on. They are pushed back. There are some battles, La Rothière, that they straightforwardly lose. Marmont and Mortier are pushed back into Paris itself to defend Paris. And Napoleon stays outside of Paris to try to fall on the lines of communication of his enemies, and frankly, works miracles with very small numbers

of men. It's largely because the marshals are under his direct control again, unlike the case in 1813.

- 6.52 However, by the 31st of March 1814, it becomes very clear that the worst has happened, and that is that Marmont, entirely on his own volition, has surrendered Paris. What he did was to march his corps out of Paris and march it into the Russian camp, where his men were disarmed, and so Paris could not be defended.
- 6.53 Napoleon, when he was told about this on the night of the 31st of March, simply couldn't believe this message. It made no sense to him at all. Mortier, who was willing to carry on fighting and indeed did fight in some of the gates, including the Gate of Clichy in Paris. But Marmont had not just surrendered, but had actually disarmed his own corps, and it really meant that there was no hope.
- 6.54 And Marmont had grown up with him, had been his bosom friend, had been his aide-de-camp and had betrayed him in this terrible way. And he was called, actually, because he was the Duke of Ragusa, the verb raguser meant in French, "to betray." And he lived for the rest of his life hated by Frenchmen, essentially, for having done what he did.
- 6.55 Napoleon was at Fontainebleau, his hunting lodge, which was actually by then a beautiful palace. And he was with some of his more trustworthy soldiers and his guard, the Imperial Guard, his elite troops. And they wanted to carry on the fight. The Imperial Guard were up for fighting on, but the French marshals were not. On the 2nd of April, Marshal Ney, Oudinot and several others, including Macdonald, essentially made it clear that Napoleon had to go into exile, had to start negotiating with the allies and go into exile.
- 6.56 Napoleon attempted to commit suicide. He took poison. He had a little leather pouch hanging around his neck, which he'd had around his neck ever since he was nearly captured the day after Maloyaroslavets. It had hellebore, and I can't remember the other name of the other poison—it's in the book. He swallowed it, but the poison had gone off in the intervening couple of years. So all he did was to spend the night retching and throwing up, and was unbelievably ill. By the next day, he recognized that he wasn't going to commit suicide, but was instead going to go into exile.
- 6.57 He formally announces his abdication. He signs the abdication document—you can still see the desk that he signed it on in Fontainebleau. Then he went down into the Cheval-Blanc courtyard, the great steps of Fontainebleau coming down, the horseshoe steps, and said goodbye to the Imperial Guard. They were crying, and he was crying, and they cried into the flag, and he got into a very lacrimose moment for the Empire. He got into his carriage and was driven off south to exile on the island of Elba, just off Italy. As you shall discover soon, he doesn't stay there. Thank you very much indeed.
- 6.58 I'm particularly interested in the evolving relationship between Napoleon and his marshals. I'm going to ask you actually a question on your next book, which you're

currently writing. We've established that his marshals are particularly driven and ambitious individuals. You also mentioned a sequence of Pyrrhic victories of the French army. Do any of his marshals at any point think they can stage a coup and replace Napoleon altogether?

- 6.59** Yes. Well, first of all, thank you very much indeed for advertising my next book, which is called *Napoleon and His Marshals*, and is coming out in the fall of 2026 in the United States. The answer is no. Nobody thinks they can replace him, but they all think at different stages whether or not they can survive him, whether they can keep their estates and their money and their wonderful huge houses by changing sides.
- 6.60** He helps this process because at the time of his abdication at Fontainebleau, he releases his marshals from the oath that they have taken to him. Lots of them immediately go off to King Louis XVIII of France, who is coming to Paris, and they offer to lead the French army under the king. The king, very sensibly—the Bourbons get a lot of things wrong, but they very sensibly accepted the allegiance of all of the marshals who offered it. Not all of them did offer it, but the key ones—Berthier in particular, and many of the others, Macdonald, Ney, and so on, do. It's a moment that is very important in what's called the first restoration.
- 6.61** I was going to ask, you've mentioned this idea, this activity of battlefielding, and you've said that you've been to forty and more of these battlefields— fifty-three, okay, perfect. I was wondering, as a historian, when you go to these locations, what are you looking for? In the sense of, are you matching eyewitness testimonies and seeing the landscape and this idea of having an embodied history by going to these locations? And what do you benefit from doing that?
- 6.62** Yes, it's a very good question. Exactly that. You get the maps, you walk the ground, and you read the testimonies of people who fought in the battle, and obviously, historians' testimonies as well about what went on. And when you go to something like the Battle of Salamanca with the upper and the Lower Arapiles, when you stand on the top of the Lower Arapiles, you realize why Wellington was able to spot the gap in Marmont's army, and that Marmont himself wasn't because of the topography; there's a great gap in the battlefield because the Upper Arapiles is there and you can't see around it, for example.
- 6.63** At Waterloo, the folds of the ground are tremendously important because there's various places that the grand battery, Napoleon's grand battery, could not fire at the allied line. Although Waterloo is slightly different because the actual front line has been completely wrecked by the building of the 160-foot-high lion mound. You can pretty much establish where troops were and when under what circumstances, how they were moving, where they were moving.
- 6.64** On top of the fifty-three Napoleonic battlefields, I've also been to battlefields in eight countries, just looking at the marshals' battlefields where Napoleon wasn't there. They,

too, can be tremendously interesting. The battle that Masséna won at Gaëta, where you're able to— if you get high enough, you're able to see where Masséna pushed forward the trenches before the threatened last stage of the attack.

- 6.65** It really does work. It really is worthwhile and helpful to go to battlefields. You can sometimes get the genius of Napoleon coming through the coup d'œil that he has of spotting opportunities and where they crop up. I've never regretted ever going to a battlefield.
- 6.66** You spoke of Napoleon's great love for Joséphine. How does his perception of love change when he marries Marie-Louise? And what were the causes and effects of his establishing the Duchy of Warsaw?
- 6.67** The concept of love—first of all, in the 18th century; secondly, amongst kings and queens and emperors, in this case; thirdly, amongst Frenchmen—is different sometimes from the modern assumptions about love that we have today. The aristocracy, especially the French aristocracy, and especially the 18th-century French aristocracy, was not expected—the men, at least, were not expected to be faithful to their wives; Napoleon certainly wasn't. As I mentioned, he had 22 mistresses. However, that didn't mean that he didn't love Joséphine.
- 6.68** It's a difficult concept for us, perhaps, to appreciate with our modern concepts of love. But he did love her, and he was sad when he had to divorce her for dynastic reasons because he wanted to have an heir, and she could no longer provide him with one. Marie-Louise, on the other hand, certainly could and did in pretty short order.
- 6.69** There's something a little distasteful, isn't there, at least to modern-day sensibilities, about a 41-year-old man marrying an 18-year-old girl. But nonetheless, again, dynastic considerations come first in these circumstances. Marie-Louise was pretty and fell in love with Napoleon. It was a very good relationship until it wasn't, until the moment came, which I'll be talking about in the next episode, about what happens when they are split from one another.
- 6.70** What would it take for Napoleon to actually succeed in the Russian campaign and how his definition of success was changing as the campaign unraveled?
- 6.71** It would really have taken him either to have not gone so far into Russia, to have stopped at Smolensk—a number of marshals suggested to him to stop at Smolensk in August of 1812, so before the typhus outbreak and long before Borodino, and make it into a two-year campaign. "Stop at Smolensk, wait until the winter was over, and then start again in the spring of 1813." If he'd done that, he might have—well, he couldn't have done worse, so he would certainly have done better.
- 6.72** Also, maybe go north to St. Petersburg and take St. Petersburg instead of Moscow, because Moscow does drag you hundreds and hundreds of miles into Russia. The advantage of taking St. Petersburg would have been that it would have cut Russia off

from its timber and various other resources and its trade with England and so on. He could have, when the typhus had broken out, he could have stopped then as well.

- 6.73** Or he could have just left Moscow after having looted Moscow, left Moscow as soon as he could, really, as soon as the fires were breaking out, pretty much. You take Moscow, loot it, and then go straight back.
- 6.74** Or he could have pushed back after Maloyaroslavets and continued to take on the Kaluga Road, because what we know—but he didn't know—was that the Russians under General Kutuzov were going to retreat if he did do that. They were under orders not to fight another battle, which he assumed that they would do on the road to Kaluga.
- 6.75** So there you are—there's four what-ifs, essentially, which would have left him, if not a great conqueror in Russia, at least still in control of the Grande Armée. If the Grande Armée had not been destroyed on the retreat from Moscow, then the Austrians certainly wouldn't have changed sides, neither would the Prussians, or the Saxons, or the Württembergers. Who's to say you might have a Bonaparte on the throne of France today?
- 6.76** My question is regarding Napoleon's ability to compartmentalize because it seems it put him in a positive light. But don't you think that it can be negative for leaders to have that? Like a typical investor who's already lost 10% of their asset, they still look for other potential businesses elsewhere rather than focusing on the problem. The second question is: Is this a common trait for great leaders, such as Churchill, Thatcher, and others?
- 6.77** No, I don't think it's a bad thing because he was still able to focus; this was the extraordinary thing. When he needed to focus on each thing, he was able to do it. But it didn't mean that he wasn't able to focus on something completely different as well, and not have the overwhelming fact that's in front of your eyes affect your judgment for other things. So he was able to work on several things all at the same time, but still stay focused on the most central one.
- 6.78** I haven't seen it, frankly, in that many other people. Churchill tended not to compartmentalize. He was a much more emotional figure than Napoleon, anyway. He was constantly bursting into tears. He was a great regency character, really, Winston Churchill, and not the cold, cool calculating figure that you need to be if you're able to compartmentalize.
- 6.79** Margaret Thatcher—that's an interesting case in point. She could go to sleep for a quarter of an hour before the Prime Minister's questions. That's the time when most Prime Ministers would start to think about Prime Minister's questions, what they were going to do, they might have got nervous about them, but not Margaret Thatcher. Margaret Thatcher just wanted to have a nap beforehand. But that's not compartmentalization, of course, is it? That's working out how to parcel out her day.

Lecture 7: Hundred Days & Waterloo

At a glance — The Hundred Days and the defeat at Waterloo.

- 7.1 Having abdicated in April 1814 at the Palace of Fontainebleau, Napoleon was taken to Elba, where he was the sovereign ruler, but was not allowed to leave. He spent his time on Elba staying in touch with what was going on in France with various friends who were writing to him, getting the newspapers from the mainland and so on. But he also did positive things for Elba as well. He put into effect lots of reforms on the island that made it a more efficient place. That was totally typical of him. When he went to Malta on the way to Egypt, he also did things to do with his education reforms and local reforms and financial reforms and so on. He was a natural reformer.
- 7.2 He stayed on the island for 10 months because he was able to recognize that the Bourbons, back in Paris, were screwing everything up. Louis XVIII had come in, as was pointed out, in the baggage train of the allies, and so he wasn't terribly popular for that very reason alone. But also it was said of the Bourbons that they remembered nothing and forgot nothing. By that, it meant that they essentially remembered that they had been overthrown in the French Revolution back in 1789, and forgot that there was a reason for this.
- 7.3 They weren't able to do anything other than try to really go back to the old days, which the French people were not going to allow. They banned the tricolor, for example, which was tremendously unpopular. They put the entire army on half pay, which, needless to say, no soldiers were happy about. They had the Napoleonic titles revoked. They didn't treat the marshals with the respect that they initially implied that they were going to. Marshal Ney's wife was sneered at at court and so on. In very short order, the Bourbons made themselves unpopular in France.
- 7.4 That didn't necessarily mean that Napoleon was popular as the alternative. He nonetheless decided he was going to try his hand at a return. He was fortunate that his British jailer, essentially, Sir Neil Campbell, the British representative on Elba, needed to go regularly to Florence, either to his oculist there—he had bad eyesight—or to his mistress there, or possibly both. They're not mutually exclusive.
- 7.5 And when on the 26th of February, Sir Neil Campbell was away, Napoleon put his guard—some 600 members of the Imperial Guard who had come with him to Elba—onto a frigate and sailed for Fréjus in the south of France, the same place, actually, of course, that he had landed back in 1799.
- 7.6 He didn't know whether or not he was going to be arrested as soon as he set foot in France; he didn't know how he was going to be received. But he was fortunate in that the person who was in charge, the governor in that part of France, was none other than Masséna, who—although Masséna still smarted at the way he'd been treated, not just having his eye shot out by Napoleon, but also having been sacked after the defeat in

Portugal—acted deliberately slowly to see the way that the wind blew and didn't have Napoleon arrested.

- 7.7 So what Napoleon did was to move very quickly up what is today known as the Route Napoléon. It goes through every one of the villages and towns that he went through, including Grenoble and Lyon. He managed to get more and more people on his side, cheering his cause.
- 7.8 There was a key moment on the 13th of March—he landed on the first of March, so nearly two weeks later—when Marshal Ney, who had said that he was going to, he boasted to Louis XVIII, that he would capture Napoleon and return him in Paris in an iron cage, actually changed sides and supported Napoleon. So this was a huge boost to him. Marshal Soult was the Minister of War, and he also, therefore, was attempting to rally the Bourbon troops against Napoleon, and he, too, changed sides. So you had what seemed like a sea change of pro-Napoleonic fervor.
- 7.9 And this also came to a head when outside Grenoble, it's called the Field of the Return, "Champ du Retour", a regiment was formed up in front of Napoleon. And Napoleon threw open his overcoat and said, "Any of you who want to fire upon their Emperor, take a shot." And instead, the soldiers threw down their weapons and ran forward and hugged him and clung onto his legs and generally cheered him to the echo. And it became clear, therefore, that the army was going to support him. Various marshals didn't like that. They either went to their family estates or they went off with Louis XVIII and fled Paris. Some marshals went to join Napoleon.
- 7.10 And by the time that he got to Paris on the evening of the 20th of March, Napoleon was able to actually sit down and eat the dinner that had been cooked at the Tuileries for Louis XVIII. Louis XVIII had escaped earlier that day, and so Napoleon was back in charge.
- 7.11 What he did at the beginning was to pass a liberal constitution. This, he felt, would make him more amenable to the French people. It abolished slavery. It allowed for a form of constitutional monarchy on the English model. There were various aspects of it which he used to try to bring over the French people. He also had an enormous meeting of French soldiers and administrators and ordinary French people on the Champ de Mars, which is where the Eiffel Tower is at the moment, as a national celebration of his return, and of the liberal constitution, and to show national unity.
- 7.12 Because on the 13th of March, whilst he was still moving up from the south of France to Paris, the Allies who had been meeting in Vienna as a congress, in order to try and redraw the map of France, at which Talleyrand was present, but also Metternich and Lord Castlereagh, there was an agreement that they were going to not declare war against France. They were going to argue that he was just a brigand, essentially an outlaw; he was declared an outlaw. It was declared that anyone who killed him would

be not prosecuted, that he didn't represent France, and that France was still being represented by the Bourbons.

- 7.13** So you have this situation by the June of 1815 that armies are coming—huge armies, 350,000 Russians, 150,000 Austrians—to help the forces that are already in Belgium, particularly the Duke of Wellington with 77,000 men and the Prussian leader, von Blücher, Gebhard von Blücher, field marshal, who had 50,000 men. The scene was set for the Waterloo Campaign.
- 7.14** It was a problem for Napoleon that he had so few marshals with him. I've mentioned Soult, of course, and Marshal Ney. He also, just before, in the April of 1815, was able to appoint Emmanuel de Grouchy, a great cavalry commander, really fine cavalry commander, to the post of marshal. But where were the rest? There were 26 marshals in all. Beyond Soult, Ney, and Grouchy, where were they? Well, three of them, of course, were dead. His great friend, Bessières, who died at Bautzen. Lannes, who died after the Battle of Aspern-Essling. Poniatowski, who had drowned in the Elster, trying to cross the river at the Battle of Leipzig.
- 7.15** He had on his side, i.e. rallying to him. He contacted all of them. The ones who came to him were Marshal Suchet, who had done well in Spain and was a good commander in charge of an independent command—he could take care of himself. Marshal Brune, who you'll recall was the person who was blamed for having chopped off the Princess de Lamballe's head and stuck it on a pike during the French Revolution—which he couldn't have done because he wasn't in Paris at the time—and was also hated by the royalists in the south of France and also in the Vendée because he'd fought this dirty war campaign against them.
- 7.16** Marshal Mortier, who everybody liked; wasn't hugely impressive—he couldn't even blow up the Kremlin when he was given orders to, and he had plenty of gunpowder. But nonetheless, he also joined. Then crucially, the really impressive one who is Marshal Davout. Davout, the great victor of the Battle of Auerstädt in October 1806. You'll recall how he outnumbered—sorry, he was fighting against the Prussian force that outnumbered him by two and a half or three to one, and defeated it.
- 7.17** But what Napoleon did—and sorry, and to go through the others, the others basically stayed with Louis XVIII. Men such as Macdonald and Oudinot, Augereau, Marmont, obviously, having surrendered; Paris wasn't about to be allowed back. These people all cleaved to Louis XVIII. When Louis XVIII was forced from Paris, they went into exile with him. A few who didn't want to be on either side went back to their estates and basically kept their heads down. Masséna waited down in the south of France to see who was going to win and then was going to join whichever side that was.
- 7.18** The problem really was that Napoleon put the wrong people in positions that they should never have been put in. Suchet instead of being—who's a good battlefield commander and had won lots of victories, wasn't at the Battle of Waterloo because he

was put in charge of the army, trying to keep the Austrians out of the south of France. Brune was sent to the south of France, to Marseille, to try to put down a royalist uprising there. Mortier had sciatica—either genuine case of sciatica that was so bad that he wasn't able to get on a horse, or as Napoleon slightly suspected by the time he was on St. Helena, he actually was feigning the sciatica because he didn't want to fight at the Battle of Waterloo, and therefore didn't.

7.19 Most importantly, though, of all of them was Davout, who was given three extremely important roles. He was made governor of Paris, he was put in charge of the National Guard in Paris, and he was minister of war. In the course of being minister of war, he wrote to all of the marshals trying to get them back on side, not to Augereau, because Augereau had also shown how opposed he was to Napoleon, but to most of them. But the fact was that Paris was not the place for Davout in these closing days of the Empire.

7.20 The battlefield was the right place for Davout. Instead of being at Waterloo, he was miles away, which was a tragedy for Napoleon. Not least because the people who were at Waterloo, the three who were on the Waterloo campaign, Soult, Ney, and Grouchy, were all in the wrong positions. Soult was put in charge of—he was made chief of staff rather than having a professional chief of staff. Soult himself was a commander in chief, of course, and had been in that big retreat all the way across the Pyrenees to Toulouse. But he wasn't a chief of staff.

7.21 The finest chief of staff of the era, perhaps the finest chief of staff of any era, Alexander Berthier, was dead on the 15th of June. He was in his house, looking out of the window, and was either—he either fell out of the window or some Russian soldiers who were moving through the town threw him out the window. Russians have been known to do that. Or he committed suicide. To this day, we don't know which it is. Some of the people, his servant claims that he had been standing on a chair looking at the Russians who were marching through the town and just fell out of the window. But anyway, his body was found three stories down, and therefore, he was never going to be on Napoleon's side anyway because he had left Napoleon's employment after 1814 and had joined Louis XVIII.

7.22 But this meant that there was an opening as chief of staff, and Napoleon put the wrong person in it: Marshal Soult, who had not got staff experience. To have as his battlefield commander, Marshal Ney, also was a mistake, because although Ney was unbelievably brave—he had been very brave in the retreat from Moscow, he'd been the last person back over the Neman River, he'd been in charge of the rear guard. He had started with an entire corps, of course, when they invaded Russia of 20,000+, he was down to 30 men at the end of the Russian campaign. Many historians feel that he had been so mentally affected by the horrors of the campaign, of being in charge of the rear guard, that he simply wasn't up to much in the way of commanding troops after that. You do see that at the Battle of Dennewitz in 1813, that he made mistake after mistake.

- 7.23 Although he would have been brave in a straightforward fighting position, the idea of him being put in as battlefield commander was a big mistake of Napoleon's—not least because he never had a battlefield commander before, he had always commanded his own battlefields. He hadn't left the important decision-making up to anybody else, especially somebody who was as damaged as Ney.
- 7.24 Finally, there's Emmanuel de Grouchy, who had only just been made a marshal and was also in the wrong position because he was placed in charge of the right flank, and was sent off after the Battle of Ligny on the 16th of June to try to chase after the Prussians. What essentially happened was there was an attack that Napoleon led. He brought in, only on the 14th of June, he brought in Ney to command the left flank of the attack, which fought a battle at the crossroads called Quatre Bras. On the same day, on his right flank, Napoleon himself and Grouchy, fought the Battle of Ligny, which was a victory and which forced the Prussians off the battlefield. But which direction did they go to?
- 7.25 Over at Quatre Bras, Ney needed a division under General d'Erlon to help him win the battle of Quatre Bras. He sent a messenger to d'Erlon to say, "Come to Quatre Bras." Just as he was about to debauch onto the battlefield of Quatre Bras, d'Erlon got another message from Marsal Soult saying that he was needed at the battlefield of Ligny, which was 8-10 miles away. Instead of helping to win the battle of Quatre Bras, he turned his army round and marched off towards Ligny, which had been won by the time he had managed to get there. He could have been part of routing of the coalition forces, either at Ligny or Quatre Bras, but because of bad staff work, essentially, and Soult making an error, he didn't arrive on either battlefield at all.
- 7.26 This was to be a major problem for the allies. It meant that Blücher, after having been defeated at Ligny, was able to escape the battlefield with a large number of his army. Under normal circumstances, in Napoleonic warfare, what tended to happen was that you went back on your own lines of communication. If you're forced to retreat, you retreat in the direction that you know your reinforcements and supplies and ammunition and so on, gunpowder, et cetera, is going to be coming towards you.
- 7.27 But crucially, the Prussians did not do that. They instead went northwards. It's thought that General von Gneisenau, Blücher's chief of staff, persuaded Blücher of this. Blücher had been concussed. He'd fallen from his horse badly in the Battle of Ligny when his horse was killed as he was charging along, and he was concussed. He wasn't composed for the last part of the battle. So essentially, the decision was taken by Gneisenau to go north to somewhere called Wavre. And what that meant was that because Wellington's army, having held and stopped the French Ney at Quatre Bras, was also retreating north on the 17th of June, the day after Ligny, it meant that the Prussians and the Anglo-Allied army managed to stay in communication with one another.
- 7.28 This was crucial because with 77,000 men in the Anglo-Allied army—I called it Anglo-Allied because it had a lot of Dutch and Belgians as well as British troops— he had 156

guns. Blücher had 50,000 and 126 guns. Napoleon, once he had sent off Grouchy with 33,000 men, was down to 72,000 men and 252 guns. As you remember, the fighting in the wars of Italy was all about the policy of the central position where you hit the stronger of your two enemies and make sure that they don't manage to get together. If they do get together, then the mathematics is obvious what happens when Wellington's 68,000 plus Blücher's 50,000 is much stronger than Napoleon's 72,000.

- 7.29** On the morning—and the 17th is wet, it rains heavily, it means that the retreating Anglo-Allied army is able to take what I call the heights of Mont-Saint-Jean. They stay on a—it's not a huge ridge. Unfortunately, as I say, it's impossible today to actually find out what ridge it was like because this gigantic Lion's Mound has been built on Wellington's battlefield, where the Anglo-Allied were. But what he was able to do was to lie his men down behind the undulating grasslands there. So that they couldn't be hit directly by Napoleon's grand battery, and the grand battery had about 86 to 90 guns.
- 7.30** Blücher, meanwhile, as I say, is marching north and being followed by Grouchy. But the trouble is that Grouchy went off in the direction towards Namur and Liège, off eastwards, on the assumption that that's what people do in those days, go back on the lines of communication. It wasn't until a few hours later that it became clear that the Prussian army wasn't there, but had in fact, gone northwards.
- 7.31** So he came back and started going northwards and started on the morning of the 18th to come into contact with the rear guard of Blücher's army at Wavre. And so fighting had started by the time he got a message from Napoleon, sent on the morning of the Battle of Waterloo, the 18th, Sunday the 18th of June 1815, to tell him to come onto the battlefield.
- 7.32** Now, there's a great deal of problem about everything to do with Grouchy's movement, about the arguments that Grouchy had with his own generals—including Van Damme, the one who'd lost at Kulm in 1813—and what time various messages were sent by Soult and the wording of the messages.
- 7.33** There's one message by Soult that says that the French army had been victorious at Waterloo—which they didn't use the word Waterloo, they said the heights of Mont-Saint-Jean. And under those circumstances, why should Grouchy then march towards Waterloo when he was already starting to fight what he thought was the main part of the Prussian army at Wavre? But it wasn't the main part because the main part had been promised by Blücher to Wellington that it was going to come onto the attack, the French right wing at Waterloo. People who were staying in Wavre were the rear guard who were holding back Grouchy.
- 7.34** So although Grouchy had got this order and he could hear the cannon going off on his extreme left, he could hear the guns starting up at Waterloo, he stuck to his original orders given to him verbally and written by Napoleon on the previous day, the 17th, to

continue to engage the Prussians and try to stop the Prussians from joining the Anglo-Allied forces, which he was unable to do.

- 7.35** The Battle of Waterloo, which started in about 11:00 in the morning, very late—usually battles in those days started at dawn. He had to start late because the ground was so wet. Napoleon wanted the ground to harden before he started his grand battery attack. The reason for that is that a cannonball fired into the wet, marshy, muddy field just digs into the field. Whereas a cannonball fired on hard ground, bounces and bounces and bounces, and can kill people even on its fifth, sixth, seventh bounce.
- 7.36** Napoleon, being an artilleryman, knew how much more useful it would be for his artillery to be able to fire on hardened ground, which meant that the actual opening up of the ground battery doesn't start until a little after 11 o'clock. Basically, people weren't watching their watches. Their memories were affected by the battle. We can't be absolutely certain about any of the specific times. You can tell within half an hour or so. But these are not specific times.
- 7.37** The battle then opens with a—as well as the grand battery firing, which actually did tremendously little damage because, as I said, Wellington had ordered his troops to lie down behind the ridge. And a cannonball, they didn't—well, they did have howitzers, but they weren't in anything like enough use, mortars, essentially. So they were cannon that just fired in a straight direction. And if there's nothing that they can hit, there's no damage that they can do.
- 7.38** But what also happens at about 11:00 to 11:30 is an attack by the French on the château—it's more a farmhouse than an actual château—of Hougoumont, which is in the sector quite in advance of Wellington's army on the left of Napoleon's army. It's a farmhouse that Napoleon had to capture because otherwise, the British Guards Regiments and the Nassauers from Holland, would have been able to have sallied out and attacked him. So he needed to capture this farmhouse and also its orchard that is attached to the farmhouse.
- 7.39** I'd like to just mention the fantastic work that's being done by an organization called Waterloo Uncovered, where archeologists, usually men who have been affected by PTSD in the British army, have been uncovering some really interesting military archeology all around the farmhouse but also in the, and outside, the walled orchard. Which shows, from where the bullets are found and so on, and buttons and other parts of military paraphernalia, where these attacks were taking place.
- 7.40** It reminds us that really the whole thing became a battle within a battle because three or four times the number of French attackers tried to capture the farmhouse, and Hougoumont became a way that Napoleon had to feed more and more men into this battle within a battle. The farmhouse did not fall. It was protected because of the walls and because of the bravery of the guards and so on. The barn roof caught fire at one point where they feared that they would then have to give up the farmhouse, but they

didn't. That was a reverse. It became what's essentially known as the first of the five phases of the Battle of Waterloo is the defense of Hougoumont.

- 7.41** The second is a major attack again, around noon-ish by d'Erlon's corps. You remember the corps that didn't get to fight at either Ligny or Quatre Bras. They were brought up as the attack division for a central attack along to try to get to the top of the ridge and maybe, hopefully, as far as Napoleon was concerned, smash through Wellington's center. It wasn't a hugely imaginative attempted attack. You see this also at Borodino, the belief that just enough troops punching through into the center might then split the forces against you, and you rush through and managed to defeat each of them in detail. It had happened at Austerlitz, but it by and large doesn't work if the center is strong enough. Such was the case at Waterloo.
- 7.42** We don't know the, or can't be certain, at least, the exact formation that d'Erlon chose to attack in. It might have been in the form of a square. It might have been in the form of a lozenge. There's a great debate amongst historians about the formation of the d'Erlon assault. But what we do know is that managed to just about get to the crest of the hill under fire from the Anglo-Allied units, of course, and also under fire from artillery.
- 7.43** But then at the key psychological moment, before it got to the crest, Wellington unleashed the Union and Household Brigades, these two crack regiments— crack brigades, should I say—of several regiments of overwhelmingly British cavalry who hit the wavering front ranks of d'Erlon's corps. They charged through the hedges, sometimes over the hedges. A lot of these cavalry officers were hunting men, and the horses also were perfectly okay jumping over hedges. They smashed into the front ranks of d'Erlon's corps, which broke. They retreated in disorder.
- 7.44** The Union and Household Brigades then, as often happens with cavalry, over-excited, very difficult to maneuver, went too far. French cavalry, including some Polish lancers, were able to punish the Union and Household Brigade very heavily. In fact, Sir William Ponsonby, who was the Household Brigade commander was killed, and they were forced back. But basically, the key infantry attack, the second phase of the battle had also been won by Wellington.
- 7.45** By sometime around 4:00 PM, one sees the opening of Ney's great cavalry charge in the center. Why it took place in the way that it did is possibly because of Ney's need to try to recapture the initiative after the defeat of d'Erlon's corps. But he was not given direct orders by Napoleon to unleash this cavalry charge, and it was done too soon. When you have a cavalry charge, what you also need is infantry who follow it up, and if possible, horse artillery that are able to take advantage of the capture of ground and therefore are able to pour fire into the enemy ranks from the positions captured by the cavalry.

- 7.46 But there were no infantry and no horse artillery backup to Ney's charge. So this fantastic, enormous 10,000+ charge of Cuirassiers and other cavalry, heavy cavalry, hit the Wellington center left. It essentially broke itself on this because Wellington got his infantry, Anglo-Allied Infantry, to make up 13 battalion-sized squares, about 800 or so men in a battalion, all protecting each other's backs, and none of the squares broke.
- 7.47 The cavalry went round and round the squares and became more and more exhausted, especially, of course, in this quite rain-sodden ground, didn't manage to break any of the squares and therefore couldn't carry on charging beyond. And so the cavalry charge failed as well.
- 7.48 I've written a little book on the Battle of Waterloo, and in the appendix to it, I attached an explanation for why the attack took place in the way that it did. And it was written many years after the battle, about 20 years after the battle, by somebody who did take part in the charge. What he said was that the cavalry had been moving forward, and one of the officers in the front had, through his telescope, seen a slight retreat by the British Infantry. This was before they formed square, and they assumed that they were going to pull back.
- 7.49 The horses were going forward, and then they went forward a bit faster and faster. Before Ney or anybody else could stop the charge from taking place, it essentially took place by accident. Once the first couple of regiments had started attacking and going faster, then Ney had the decision either to let those regiments be massacred or to follow afterwards with the whole of the rest of the cavalry. The letter is persuasive to me, actually. I can see how that might have happened. But however it was, however it did happen, it was disastrous because Napoleon had lost his great, hopefully battle-winning, fighting force.
- 7.50 Would that have happened if Murat had been in charge of the cavalry at Waterloo? Perhaps not. Murat was the greatest cavalry commander of the age. But Murat had changed sides in 1813, then changed sides back to Napoleon, then changed sides back to the allies, and then, as Napoleon landed at Fréjus, tried to change sides back to Napoleon, and Napoleon had quite understandably thought that he was so impossible to trust by then that he didn't even reply to the letter that Murat sent offering him to help Napoleon again. But what if he had had the greatest cavalry commander of his age, rather than Ney who lost control of the situation? Anyhow, that was not to be.
- 7.51 In the fourth phase of the Battle of Waterloo, Grouchy having not come to the battlefield—and by the way, it would have been extremely difficult for him to have anyway because there were no east-west roads. He was already fighting, of course, as I mentioned in the north, it's very difficult to disengage successfully and just move off to a different part of the battle, of the countryside, essentially, it was miles away. Grouchy is blamed very widely for the defeat at Waterloo, especially, of course, by Napoleon on St. Helena. But I don't think it's fair, frankly, because Grouchy was obeying his orders and he had his own battle to fight.

- 7.52** The point was that he didn't do anything significantly to prevent these Prussians, led by von Bülow, the von Bülow corps, from entering the battlefield of Waterloo from 1:00 onwards. And by 4:30 or so, they had captured a village called Plancenoit on Napoleon's right, and Napoleon had to protect his right flank, and he put some of the Imperial Guard in to do that—either the young guard or the middle guard, I can't remember which. And as that fighting developed, more and more of Napoleon's forces had to be flung onto the right flank to hold back the Prussians.
- 7.53** That meant that he had far, far fewer men to deploy in the fifth and final phase of the Battle of Waterloo. This takes place between 6:30 and 7:30, or so, at night, because at 6:30, an important farmhouse on the road, the road that goes straight through the battlefield all the way to Brussels. On that road is a farm called La Haye Sainte. That had been held by the King's German Legion, which was a group of soldiers who had grown up in Hanover. Of course, King George III was also Elector of Hanover.
- 7.54** These extremely good, very tough soldiers had been—a few hundred of them—put into La Haye Sainte to hold, rather like Hougomont, a stronghold that Napoleon had to take if he was going to be able to maneuver around that part of the battlefield. These guys fought incredibly bravely. They were down to the end of their ammunition because they hadn't made a hole in the back of the farmhouse for ammunition to be fed through to them. It was one of the only mistakes that Wellington made that day. Otherwise, Wellington fought a pretty much totally faultless battle, whereas, as I'm pointing out, Napoleon didn't.
- 7.55** And La Haye Sainte fell to the French at about 6:30. This allowed Napoleon to order the Imperial Guard, this extraordinary elite unit, to march up the Brussels Road, past La Haye Sainte, and try to punch a hole like he'd hoped d'Erlon was able to do through Wellington's center left. He had the opportunity now.
- 7.56** But by that stage, a couple of things had happened. Firstly, of course, he'd had to weaken the number of guard that he could unleash on this attack because they'd had to hold off the Prussians at Plancenoit. Also, it had allowed, because of the defeat of the initial d'Erlon attack and the cavalry attack, Wellington was able to plug the gaps in his line and to place some of his best regiments, his toughest, most dependable regiments in the path of the Imperial Guard, and of course, also his artillery.
- 7.57** When the Imperial Guard attacked, they took terrible losses. At one moment, around 7:30 at night, they started to throw down their weapons, and the cry went up, "La Garde recule!" the guard is falling back. Then you have, "Sauve qui peut!", save yourself, run for your life, essentially. Once the rest of the army saw the Guard do this, this elite unit that they'd all looked up to, they themselves did the same thing, and the defeat was uniform across the board.
- 7.58** There was a moment earlier than that where Wellington raised his hat, and that was the sign for all the commanders right the way across the battlefield to move forward, to

attack. Once they did, the victory, was certain. It was a rout. The French army had been comprehensively defeated.

- 7.59** Napoleon wanted to stay and fight and die at Waterloo, but Ney grabbed the bridle of his horse and pulled him away. So Napoleon managed to get away. His carriage was captured and he managed to get back to Paris. And thereupon, he tried to get the Chambers, the Parliament to continue to support him. But by that stage, especially once bedraggled soldiers got back, and especially once Ney got back and made a speech in the Chamber of Deputies denouncing Napoleon, it was all up for Napoleon. He retired to Rochefort, where he surrendered to a British vessel in the harbor there.
- 7.60** He surrendered to the British because he knew that because of the depredations that had been forced on Prussia in the 1806-1807 campaign, if he'd fallen into the hands of the Prussians, they could well have just executed him. He knew that the British weren't going to do that. He rather hoped that he was going to be given a country house and allowed to live in the home counties as an English gentleman.
- 7.61** But considering what he'd managed to do after escaping from Elba and the 100,000 men who had been killed or wounded in the course of the Hundred Days Campaign, that was not something that the British government were about to allow him to do. And so instead, he was exiled to the island of St. Helena, which is the second most isolated and remote island in the world that anyone lives on, inhabited island in the world. It's in the Atlantic.
- 7.62** And when you go there, which I had to do, it took—you can fly there now, but when I was writing this book, you had to go by boat—and it takes six days and six nights. I had to sit next to exactly the same person at every single meal, a Swiss railway engineer, as it turned out. I got through everything I knew about Swiss railways within the course of the first course of the first meal. For Napoleon, it was an awful lot worse. I will tell you about St. Helena and also, of course, his legacy in the next lecture. Thank you very much.
- 7.63** You pointed out that Napoleon made very bad decisions about putting the right people in the right chair. I'm wondering if this behavior was consistent during his career or if it has something to do with the size of the army, or the situation of the state. Is there any trend you can tell us about?
- 7.64** No, interestingly not. It seems to be just a series of mistakes that he made in 1815. Earlier, he was extremely good at putting the right people in the right place all the way through his career. He was a very good judge of character, and he tried to make sure that the right person was in the right place, which he usually was. So this is a new departure.
- 7.65** Now, he didn't have that much to choose from. Of the 26 marshals, he only had seven who rallied to him. And so there wasn't exactly a plethora of opportunities, especially as one had sciatica and so on. But he did place Ney, and Grouchy, and Davout, and

Soult in the wrong jobs, essentially. Also, had he placed some of them in the right jobs, they would have done much better. Davout in charge as battlefield commander, wouldn't have made the same mistakes that Ney did.

- 7.66 Yeah, I would love to know—I'm just picturing the Battle of Waterloo, and I'd love to know Napoleon's—how he viewed Wellington and vice versa; how they viewed each other, whether it was from a place of respect? Then with that, I'd also love to know if there was any intelligence gathering on either side, figuring out what the other side was doing, if there were any moles or spies or anything like that.
- 7.67 Yes, Napoleon did know about Wellington, of course, because Wellington had fought six of his marshals in the Peninsula Campaign over six years, and had beaten five of them. On the morning of the Battle of Waterloo, Napoleon said to his marshals and generals at the breakfast before the battle, "Oh, I know Wellington. He's a bad general. You won't have any difficulty. This is going to be the affair of déjeuner." This is going to be over by breakfast. Of course, he's been attacked a lot for those remarks and for getting that so magnificently wrong. But not by me. I think that it's fair enough that if you're giving a pep talk to your generals on the morning of a battle, you don't talk up your opponent. Can you imagine a cricket captain saying that kind of thing?
- 7.68 But what he didn't do was to come up with any of the great enveloping movements or interesting battle tactics that he had done in the past. In Italy, he was constantly outmaneuvering his enemies. He was luring them into traps. He was using any number of brilliant operations to win these battles.
- 7.69 With the Battle of Waterloo—which admittedly is a small battle, it's only three and a half miles wide. You've got a forest on one side and a forest on the other. But all he tried to do was just basically punch his way through each time: at Hougoumont, with d'Erlon, with Ney, and with the Imperial Guard. When you're up against a defensive general like Wellington, who has not lost a battle and has some very solid troops who have fought through the Peninsula War and so on—although most of his troops hadn't fought at the Peninsula, in fact, but nonetheless, a lot of the officers had—you're not going to pull it off. So overconfidence.
- 7.70 The second part of your question? Intelligence gathering, yeah. Well, there's always a good deal of intelligence gathering going on. Wellington was helped by the fact that General Bourmont, who was a royalist, swapped sides about two days before the battle. He would have handed over as many of the battle plans as he knew about. That led to severe demoralization in the French ranks because if generals are changing sides, then you feel that you're being betrayed by your superiors. That's not good for morale. But they weren't able to look into the mind of the other general. They didn't know what the opposition was going to.

- 7.71** If you could go back in time, in any one moment of time during Napoleon's reign, and offer Napoleon one key advice—assuming he would listen to you—to avoid his downfall, what do you think that would be?
- 7.72** Can I be allowed two pieces of advice? Thank you. That's very sweet of you. Go to Spain in 1810, and whatever you do, don't go to Russia in 1812.
- 7.73** Could Napoleon have hung on to his power after 1815, or was it inevitable that the coalition would always oust him?
- 7.74** Yes, it was. Good question. It was always inevitable because they had declared him an outlaw on the 13th of March 1815. The Russians were sending 350,000; Austrians, 150,000; he already had 68,000 under Wellington, and 50,000 under Blücher. And he himself had an army of 72,000; plus Grouchy, actually, so make that 105,000.
- 7.75** He was so heavily outnumbered that the allies, even if he'd won Waterloo, he would still have had to have fallen back. He wanted to capture Brussels and force the British back to evacuate them back over the English Channel. But even if he'd done that, he'd have been forced to fight outside Paris in the same region as he had in 1814. No, I think it's pretty much all over at the moment that he wasn't able to persuade the allies to let him just stay on the throne.
- 7.76** This question is about the function of Napoleon and the marshals. How do they differ in traits or abilities? The marshals, he got 26 of them and nobody tried to kill him and tried to take the throne. How does it work? What kind of men are we talking about in general, who get orders and functions instead of taking over the throne?
- 7.77** The marshals have very little in common. When you look at the 26 of them, they are very, very different individuals. Courage, of course, raw courage, is one thing they all have in common. They all have enough ambition to want to be marshals of France. They absolutely want to get to the top of their profession. They tend to very much enjoy the titles and the money, essentially, that comes, and the estates and so on. That's something they all have in common. Maybe two of them actually don't take titles. Everybody else does. That's because those two still had a sense of republican principle. But actually, once Louis XVIII comes back, one of them did take a title.
- 7.78** They otherwise differed hugely in capacity and whether or not they could actually command armies when Napoleon wasn't present. Berthier himself, at the opening stage of the 1809 campaign, was put in charge of the Grande Armée, and he got his dispositions completely wrong. Napoleon had to gallop from Paris in order to put them right before the Austrian attack.
- 7.79** It's a mixed bag in terms of talent and ability. Of course, there are also various people who should have made the marshalate. Desaix would have if he hadn't been killed at Marengo. Various very good cavalry commanders, including another one who served

under Grouchy at Waterloo called Exelmans. These people were knocking on the door of the marshalate, and never quite made it.

7.80 One thing a lot of them have in common is they came from backgrounds where one or both parents die young, where they certainly were not particularly grand, were lower middle class or working class in some cases. Murat is the son of an innkeeper, Ney is the son of a barrel cooper, and so on. Lannes, the son of a peasant, essentially. They really do come up from the ordinary folk, apart from the seven who were nobles.

Lecture 8: Final Years & Legacy

At a glance — Napoleon's final years in exile and his enduring legacy.

- 8.1** When ABBA tells us that at Waterloo, Napoleon did surrender, they actually got it wrong. It wasn't for another month. In July, 15th of July 1815, that Napoleon surrendered to a British admiral at Rochefort.
- 8.2** What happened then was that he was taken in HMS Bellerophon to the English Port of Plymouth and stayed on the ship in the harbor there and was stared at by hundreds of little vessels that went out to try and catch a view of him—which he quite enjoyed and strutted around a bit on the deck. Then he was taken on a different vessel, which was HMS Northumberland, to St. Helena, on a long journey that took several months.
- 8.3** When he saw the cliffs of St. Helena just outside Jamestown, he said, "I wish I'd stayed in Egypt." It was perfectly understandable that he should feel like that because he knew that he wasn't going to get off this island. There were two frigates that the British had going round and round the island 24 hours a day, and this was going to be the place that he died.
- 8.4** Some of his marshals also came to a very sticky end. The sadness of Marshal Ney, this extraordinary brave figure—he hadn't done very well at the Battle of Waterloo, but he was the bravest of the brave, as Napoleon had called him. He was given the opportunity to escape France, and either through stupidity or possibly through a sort of death wish, he never took any of the opportunities to do so.
- 8.5** He went off to stay in his wife's cousin's château, and he left his great big bejeweled sword in the drawing room, which was seen by somebody who told the police, and the police came round and arrested him. This was August, so this was a couple of months after the Battle of Waterloo—had any number of opportunities to escape the country.
- 8.6** The Bourbons didn't really want to execute him. They were furious about him changing sides after having promised them that he was going to put Napoleon in an iron cage. But nonetheless, they gave him any number of opportunities to escape. He didn't take them, so they put him on trial. He managed to screw up the trial as well because if he had a—well, he did have a court-martial with other marshals sitting in judgment on him.
- 8.7** It's terrible to think that so many of these marshals had actually fought with Marshal Ney, and were willing to pronounce a death sentence on him, but they were. Not Mortier or Moncey, I'm pleased to say, but some of the other ones, like Augereau and Marmont, were, and to their eternal shame.
- 8.8** But what happened was that he was executed. He was shot after he had given up the court-martial route that he possibly could have got through and instead chose to be put on trial in the Chamber of Peers, which voted overwhelmingly for him to be shot. They

were royalists. He was taken to the Luxembourg Palace early one morning and shot. In fact, he gave the order to the firing squad to fire, which is rather magnificent.

- 8.9** In the October of 1815, Murat decided that having been thrown out of, or at least escaped from his Kingdom of Naples, that—back in May, after he'd lost the Battle of Tolentino—he decided he was going to have another go. He landed with a very small force, about 300 men, some say only 30 men, on the Calabrian Coast and was essentially just captured, put under arrest, and shot after a kangaroo court found him guilty.
- 8.10** He was tremendously vain, Murat. He used to love dressing up. He used to wear the most magnificent, strange uniforms—very brave in a battlefield to draw attention to yourself, by the way, in the way that he did with these great plumes, helmets, and strangely colored, velvet coats, and so on. His vanity stayed with him to the last when he told his firing squad, "Don't shoot at the face."
- 8.11** You also have the death of Marshal Brune, which you'll recall was a—that also happened in 1815. You'll recall how he had been very tough against the royalists in the Vendée and in the south of France and also in Marseille. He was absolutely loathed by them. When they managed to trap him in Avignon, in a hotel in Avignon, he was dragged outside and lynched, just cut to pieces, essentially.
- 8.12** They then threw his corpse into the river and from the Pont in Avignon. Then his corpse was used for firing practice by people on the side of the river, so they shot at it as it went down the river. It was then pulled out and buried in the mud by the side of the river. His beloved wife, who he had a proper love attachment to, then fished his body out and tried to get him a pardon and spent years and huge amounts of money to sue people who said that he had been a coward. And finally, even under the Bourbon law, he was exonerated.
- 8.13** The last of the marshals to die in violent means was Marshal Mortier, this one who everyone liked—but clearly not absolutely everybody—because he was assassinated by an anarchist. Many years later, during the Orléanist regime, King Louis-Philippe, he was standing next to Louis-Philippe at a military review, and something called the infernal machine, which was essentially a pipe bomb. It fired loads of bullets all at the same time, like 40, all at the same time. You can still see it, by the way. It's in one of the museums in Paris. Although King Louis-Philippe, who it was intended to kill, survived, Marshal Mortier was shot and killed.
- 8.14** Napoleon's exile and his death on the island of St. Helena were part of the—essential part, essentially, I think—of the whole of the Napoleonic epic. If he was ever allowed to create his own myth, it was there. He wrote a book called—ghosted autobiography, essentially—called the *Mémorial de Sainte-Hélène*, which became the biggest bestseller of the 19th century. Sold even more copies than *Uncle Tom's Cabin*, which is the second biggest bestseller.

- 8.15** It's easy to understand why. It's his own story from his own point of view. It's pure propaganda. He doesn't get anything wrong, apart from possibly appointing Grouchy as a marshal. He admits that that was a mistake, or at least he tried to argue that that was a mistake. But otherwise, it's a rather brilliant work of propaganda because it created the necessary conditions to turn him into the epic figure that he is.
- 8.16** He was also treated pretty shoddily, frankly, on St. Helena by the British governor, Sir Hudson Lowe, who was a pedantic, pettifogging figure who wouldn't allow Napoleon to have newspapers. In fact, he wouldn't allow Napoleon to have much, really. He was constantly saying no to anything Napoleon asked for. He stopped Napoleon having the doctor that he liked, an Irishman called O'Meara, who also wrote a very good book.
- 8.17** He was a bit of a martinet, frankly, and Napoleon hated him as well. He'd been in charge of the Corsican Rangers, i.e. Corsicans who were anti-Napoleon, which Napoleon understandably didn't like. The whole thing, those last few years, five years, five and a half years on St. Helena, are a sad postscript epilogue to the Napoleonic story, but an important one because the image of the eagle chained to the rock is a strong one.
- 8.18** You really want to come off St. Helena. I don't want to be too nasty to St. Helenians, or "Saints", as they call themselves. But frankly, when you go there, you want to leave pretty much that afternoon or a week, if that's when the plane is going to come and take you off. The idea of being there for five and a half years would frankly kill anyone, I think.
- 8.19** He was killed by cancer. There are lots of weird conspiracy theories about how he was poisoned by his wallpaper—the idea that there was arsenic in the wallpaper that killed him. It's true that there was a lot of arsenic in his hair. A rather eccentric Canadian billionaire bought loads and loads of Napoleon's hair. Napoleon used to cut off locks of his hair and give it to people at different stages in his life. I have some, actually, at home, from the St. Helena period, and I haven't had it checked for arsenic. I also have some of his wallpaper, actually, which I certainly haven't licked, just in case I'm wrong, and there is arsenic.
- 8.20** But the point is that there's a huge amount of arsenic in lots of people's hair. There's arsenic in George III's hair. There's arsenic in various members of the Bonaparte family's hair. Arsenic was used for a lot of things in normal life in the 18th century. And that explains why there's arsenic in Napoleon's hair.
- 8.21** He was not murdered. It's blamed on the Comte de Montholon, whose wife he was sleeping with—and he was sleeping with her, and they possibly had a child. But again, the assumption that Montholon, who thereafter became the leader of the Bonapartists and never said a word against Napoleon, might have murdered him, just doesn't add up.

- 8.22** Whereabouts, then, is the legacy of Napoleon? If you go to Les Invalides, where he's buried in Paris, on the banks of the Seine, as he said in his will—he wrote a long will with several codicils, leaving huge amounts of money to various people who had helped him in his career, all the way going back to Toulon. The only drawback was that he didn't actually have any money when he died, and so the money couldn't be paid, until his nephew, Napoleon III, became Emperor of France in 1851, and then had a—sorry, he became President of France in 1848, he was emperor by 1852. He had a coup on the 2nd of December. You'll remember how important the 2nd of December is as the anniversary of the coronation and of Austerlitz.
- 8.23** Then the people who were still alive 30 years later, because Napoleon died on the 5th of May 1821, did get paid out by the French state. So ultimately, the will was honored. But in that will, he said he wanted his body to be buried on the banks of the Seine. Of course, when he actually died in 1821, he wasn't buried there. He was buried on St. Helena. The last thing that the French government wanted, the Bourbons, and then later the Orléanists wanted, was to have a great monument to Napoleon.
- 8.24** But by 1840, the Orléanists had changed their mind, and they did want more pride and a sense of the glory of France. They therefore actually built the Arc de Triomphe, which was just in its early stages under Napoleon and hadn't been built. They brought back the body, where it was buried again on the 2nd of December 1840, in the wonderful tomb of Les Invalides. It didn't do the Orléanist government very much good. It was overthrown in 1848 at the beginning of the great revolutions that swept across Europe in the spring of 1848.
- 8.25** Where else do we look for his monuments? Well, European law, of course, is very much based on the Code Napoléon. There he has a standing monument. What everyone thinks of European law, it nonetheless is an enormous body of law, and that is a Napoleonic legacy.
- 8.26** Where he is horribly misunderstood and wrongly accused is this idea that he was a dictator, anything like the dictators of the 20th century. Now, it's true that he had a secret service of a kind. The secret service was also in existence during the Ancien Régime, and secret policemen were common in Austria and Russia and Prussia, other areas of Europe at the same time. He imprisoned opponents, but not many of them and not for that long. It's certainly nothing like as long as the Ancien Régime did, where they essentially threw away the key.
- 8.27** You have this sense of him being a dictator, especially via a referendum. He had a referendum to confirm himself as First Consul, and then First Consul for Life, then Emperor. In each case, there were massive majorities. Now, actually, there was a majority for all of this, but he didn't mind adding a few noughts to the yes column when these votes were counted. This was not, by any sense, an idea of a modern democracy. But nonetheless, he was genuinely popular.

- 8.28** And he couldn't have been less like Adolf Hitler or Mussolini or Stalin. Hitler had no sense of humor whatsoever. There's no Hitler joke. He wasn't somebody who would ever tell a joke in the way that Napoleon was constantly showing his magnificent sense of humor. Also, obviously, when it comes down to the treatment of the Jews, Napoleon's policy of freeing the Jews whenever the Grande Armée liberated a city—he would go to the Jewish ghetto and give civil and religious rights to the Jews—it could not be more different than Adolf Hitler.
- 8.29** Winston Churchill, who is a very good judge of these things, called Napoleon, "The greatest man of action since Julius Caesar." That in itself, I think, is an extraordinary legacy, especially if it's Winston Churchill who is saying that about you. Of the 60 battles that Napoleon fought, he won 46, drew seven, lost seven. Now, if you're a supporter of a baseball team or a football team, and they play 60, won 46, drew seven, lost seven, I think you'd be pretty impressed with that as a record.
- 8.30** He managed in these battles—and we've spoken about many of them over the previous seven hours—he managed in these battles to win, whether he was in the defense or the offense; whether he was enveloping from the right, the left, or in some cases, both at the same time; whether he had fewer men or more men; whether he was fighting in the snows of Russia or the sands of Egypt or the marshes or the forests. He was an extraordinary, capable, military commander who had few equals in history. Those people that he was looking to himself, like Caesar and Alexander the Great and so on, he has the right to be seen on that level.
- 8.31** One of the things that truly mattered in explaining why he was able to lead these men through these blizzards and deserts was that he made people feel that their lives mattered. So many people can go through life thinking that they don't really matter to history one way or another, and that their lives, though enjoyable or not, actually are not something that is going to bother anybody else after they've died. And that is not the feeling that Napoleon engendered in his forces.
- 8.32** He would say, "Look, forty centuries are looking down on you and what you're going to achieve today. You are part of history. You are part of a greater thing than yourself." That's a very difficult thing to explain to people, but nonetheless, he was able to do that because as he said, "One must speak to the soul. It's the only way to electrify the men." You remember also the remarks he made about honor being the key factor in the belief system of a Frenchman. Those are things that people will follow you for and will fight, and in some cases, die for.
- 8.33** I think he's important in other areas, too. On the Bellerophon, the ship that took him to Britain, there was a young midshipman called George Home, and he said of Napoleon—all the midshipmen and the officers were all ready to be shocked and horrified by Napoleon; they'd been brought up by their parents to think that Napoleon had horns and a tail and was an evil and monstrous figure. Of course, in no time at all, they were

charmed by him and they hung off his every word, and they really enjoyed their interactions with him.

- 8.34** But what Home said was, "He taught us what one individual could achieve in a life so short." That, I think, is another factor about Napoleon. He was somebody who, through his energy, through his luck, through his extreme hard work and self-education, was able to achieve things in a life that was cut off by cancer at the age of 51, that almost nobody else has managed to. When one thinks of all the various aspects of his life that you've been hearing about for the last seven hours, this is one individual who is able to do as much as he did. He teaches us that.
- 8.35** And he also teaches us that determinism is wrong. It matters what individuals do. There is a moral responsibility on all of us to try to do the right thing because there is no such thing as "que será, será," in history or in our own personal lives. Leo Tolstoy was completely wrong to say in that 90-page or so philosophical disquisition in *War and Peace* that Russia would have been invaded by France without Napoleon. Of course, that's not the case. It takes the individual to take the decisions. All history is, ladies and gentlemen, is an agglomeration of the individual's choices and decisions, multiplied by the billions of us who are on the planet.
- 8.36** So one can't just stand back and play no part in the world. One has to be connected with it. One has to do what you see as the right thing. And you see this also, of course, with Winston Churchill himself. In 1940, if he had not been there in May 1940, if Lord Halifax had been Prime Minister, we would have tried to have made peace with Adolf Hitler at the time of the fall of France, and that would have been catastrophic for Western civilization. And so you have a moment where certain individuals do make choices, and that isn't just great men and women of history. That comes down to us as well. I think there's an important moral aspect to the legacy of Napoleon.
- 8.37** I'm going to now list his leadership qualities, and there are a lot of them. Some of them might seem a bit contradictory. Some of them he was particularly good at in one part of his life, but not in others. Some might not seem so important, but certainly were at some stage in his careers. One must also, I think, think about whether or not we ourselves are capable of some of these things, and maybe we'd be more successful in life if we were, and there are things that we should concentrate on and try to do ourselves.
- 8.38** And this is the list. Compartmentalization. We've spoken about this ability to concentrate entirely on something that needs to be concentrated on, whatever's going on around one.
- 8.39** Meticulous planning, always so important with Napoleon. He put in enormous amounts of time working out the contingencies of what would happen if certain things were to happen. So he was not left waiting and bereft of ideas when things went wrong. He was

constantly planning, and planning is vital to understanding him. He would set up committees to plan and to look at aspects, especially in the Conseil d'État.

- 8.40 Appreciation of terrain. He had a great topographical sense of what was behind the hill. This is the phrase that's often used for Wellington. It's true of Wellington, but it's also very true of Napoleon. He had a great grasp of geography. It was one of the important subjects, obviously, in his school and university, because topography is so important in battlefields. But appreciation of terrain was vital to him.
- 8.41 Superb timing. The attacks, the certain attacks, the classic example, I suppose, being of the launch of Soult's corps at the Battle of Austerlitz coming out of the mist and going up the Pratzen Heights in December 1805. Sometimes timing went badly wrong, as we heard about the Battle of Waterloo with Ney's great cavalry charge. He should have been there. Instead of staying static, where he was quite far back at the Battle of Waterloo, he should have been doing what Wellington was doing, which was riding around, being at the key place.
- 8.42 Wellington went to every single part of the battlefield, including La Haye Sainte— not Hougoumont, because he'd have been stuck in there. But when he was actually in a square when the squares were being attacked, he was constantly moving around with his staff, many members of the staff, of which, of course, were killed at the Battle of Waterloo. But so when Napoleon wasn't there, then the superb sense of timing sometimes didn't come off. But when he was, it tended to be.
- 8.43 Steady nerves. Again, very important, especially in battles, not to panic. He kept his nerve— cannonballs were being fired all around him at the Battle of Wagram, and he didn't allow it to affect the calm decision-making that he took, for example, on that day.
- 8.44 The appreciation of the importance of discipline and training. French soldiers would— except for right at the very end with the poor old Marie-Louises, as they were sent into battle. He was constantly training. The way in which he did it was to have the young recruits being parceled out amongst the old veterans so they could learn on the march the do's and don'ts of fighting battles from the people who had fought many of them before. He put a lot of thought into interdisciplinary training.
- 8.45 He also worked hard to understand the psychology of the ordinary soldier. We've heard, of course, about the way in which he would be kind to the drummer boys and the sentries. He would take some joshing from the ranks as they marched past. He understood what the ordinary soldier wanted: he wanted glory, he wanted to have the Légion d'honneur pinned on him in front of his comrades, knowing that that would make them fight harder.
- 8.46 Then, on the negative side, the shaming. You'll remember the shaming of the 39th and the 85th demi-brigades, which forced both of them, essentially, if they were to keep their honor, to fight harder in the next battle. Then there was the issuing of

inspirational speeches and proclamations, those harangues that I mentioned, like on the bridge at the Battle of Lodi, sending men into battle after having heard a speech.

- 8.47** The great proclamations were an essential part also of explaining to the ordinary soldier what was going on. He was very good at writing quite personal proclamations that would tell the soldiers what the Queen of Prussia was like, for example. I mean, there's no way a soldier would ever meet the Queen of Prussia. But if there's a piece of gossip about her that Napoleon has written in a proclamation, it makes the whole enterprise all the more personal. *Esprit de corps* is again and again the *élan* of the French army. That sense of morale was what managed to see them through difficult decision and a difficult situation again and again.
- 8.48** Controlling the news mattered to Napoleon. He would, quite frankly, lie in bulletins about how many men he'd lost and how many enemy soldiers he'd killed, wounded, and captured. The numbers that he told the French newspapers about, bore very little connection to the numbers that we know genuinely were killed, wounded, and captured from things like the muster rolls.
- 8.49** At the end of a battle, every regiment would have a muster roll. They would call out the name of the soldier. It's a bit like that last scene in *Zulu*—you might remember—where the names are called out. If anybody knows what happened to the chap, if he was killed, or wounded, or captured, or whatever, then it would be noted down by the company sergeant, major, or the adjutant. This would happen.
- 8.50** Napoleon would therefore get the muster rolls, would be able to work out that he had lost 1,600 men in X battle. They also counted, very often, the number of enemy dead that they were burying. He would know the real number, but he certainly wouldn't publish that number. That number would be something that he and Berthier would internally digest. But as far as newspapers back in Paris were concerned, the numbers would be whatever they needed to be, a bit like adding the naughts to the referenda results.
- 8.51** He adapted the tactical ideas of others in an important way. There were people, Guibert was one of them, there was another one called Gribeauval, these people were writing books about tactics in the 1760s, 1770s, 1780s. Napoleon read all these books and worked out for himself what he thought would work. There's something called the *Bataillon Carré*, which is a way in which a battalion would be sent into battle. That idea came up in the 1760s.
- 8.52** Lots of people didn't take any notice of it, but he did, and he was able to adapt it. He didn't have to invent these ideas. They were always in the ether. Some would work, some wouldn't. But to stay open to the concepts, the intellectual concepts that were swirling around, was something that he was extremely good at. He never got stuck in a mindset, let alone a mindset where everyone's thinking the same. He was very good at picking the ones that worked and the ones that didn't.

- 8.53** He was always very good also at asking pertinent questions of the right people. There was a time when he was about to open a bridge in the middle of France, and he asked some questions—he used to rattle off machine gun fire questions—he asked the engineer who he had been introduced to all about the bridge. It became quite clear to him as he was getting the answers that the engineer hadn't got the first clue and hadn't been the person who built the bridge at all. He was the boss of the person who had built the bridge, and he was the one who wanted to meet the emperor. He certainly wanted to get the pat on the back and the Légion d'honneur, and so on from the emperor.
- 8.54** But when Napoleon recognized that he hadn't built the bridge, he insisted on meeting the person who actually had, who, fortunately, was in the crowd and was pulled forward. As the original man was allowed to slink off into the background, Napoleon asked him all the questions, the engineer answered them, and he gave the engineer the job of his boss.
- 8.55** You see that kind of thing happening the whole time with Napoleon. He wanted to talk to the man who knew the answers, and he slung questions, whether it was about economics or about engineering or about military matters, until he was happy that he understood the situation as well as the man that he was talking to. That was really important.
- 8.56** It also helped enormously to have a formidable memory. On several of the occasions when he was fighting, he would be able to remember where he had met the person before. It's a politician's trick, basically, of course, to be able to do that. Most of us can't. But if you can, it's invaluable. When he was crossing the Alps in 1800, he stopped for a drink of water with an old peasant woman. Then he met her again, years later, in a completely different situation and remembered her, and gave her 40 livres for the water that he had her pull out of the well. I mean, it was a feat of memory. But of course, that woman is a complete supporter for life from then on, not least because of the 40 livres. But the idea of being remembered by a great person just for your face and personality is a formidable thing to be able to do if you were a leader.
- 8.57** He had a deep learning and a deep appreciation of history. Now, of course, as an historian, I'm bound to rate that highly. It's the thing that I like the sound of, needless to say. But he was somebody who appreciated history and learned from it, which obviously is hopefully something that we're all doing right now.
- 8.58** He could be ruthless, utterly ruthless, when it was necessary. As we know from the massacre at Jaffa—which was a straightforward war crime, or at least would be today, it wasn't in the 18th century, but today it would be seen as one—he could be just appallingly violent with the way he put down all the chopping off the heads of the Cairo uprising in October 1798, is another classic example of this.

- 8.59** Sometimes it worked. In fact, it almost always worked in Europe, except for in Spain, where the viciousness and the violence of Murat was responded to by the Spanish people with even more viciousness and violence going back. It is really important as ever for me to remind you that for all the wonderful stories and the beautiful uniforms, and the splendor and the glory, and the honors and so on, at the bottom of all of this was warfare in its most vicious in tooth and claw.
- 8.60** Personal charisma is a huge element in all of this. It's difficult to be—charisma is a thing that can be learned. No one's born charismatic. You see, there are certain tricks of the trade. With Adolf Hitler, he would never be photographed wearing spectacles because that didn't fit into the overall concept of the Aryan Superman. There's only one photograph of Adolf Hitler wearing glasses, which was taken by Heinrich Hoffmann in a plane, and he didn't want any photographs ever shown of him wearing spectacles. He would do things like not blink when he was meeting somebody. I mean, it's a sort of game that you usually grow out of by the age of seven. But nonetheless, the Führer would indulge in that. He of course, had huge agencies entirely created to try to create this charismatic effect: Joseph Goebbels' propaganda ministry, and Leni Riefenstahl's movies, and Albert Speer's rallies and so on. The creation of charisma often comes with success. It doesn't predate success.
- 8.61** That isn't true of Napoleon. Napoleon showed charisma to Masséna and Augereau at that famous meeting on the 26th of May 1796. They responded. In fact, Augereau said, "That little general, I'm almost frightened of him"—this Pierre Augereau, who's not frightened of anything and kills men in duels and fights in every army that he can. That level of personal charisma was something that was essential to Napoleon.
- 8.62** His calmness under unimaginable pressure, especially in moments that look like defeat. At the Battle of Marengo, when he's being pushed back and Desaix hasn't arrived yet, he manages to keep the army in order. You imagine the pressure on each man who doesn't want to be killed by the oncoming Austrians. If he turns and runs, he'll be able to outrun the rest of his comrades, but he doesn't do that because he's kept in order, partly through the training, partly through discipline, partly through the charisma of his commander, and partly through fear, of course. So all of these things come together. And what you need more than anything else is for the commander in chief to be calm, and Napoleon always was.
- 8.63** The other thing is an almost obsessive-compulsive attention to detail. The letters that he writes, so many of those 38,000 letters that he writes, are all about incredible details. If he notices that some of the cannon don't have water buckets underneath them as they go along the road, he'll send a message to a marshal saying, "Make sure you get enough water buckets." He sent hundreds, literally hundreds of letters to do with shoes: "Have your soldiers got enough shoes? Have they got a second pair of shoes in their cartouche, their knapsack?" Things like that really mattered to him.

Making sure the tiniest things were right, he found, meant that officers would also attend to the bigger things and the more important details.

- 8.64** Now, of course, if you're a marshal and you've been a marshal, you're twice as old as—like Sérurier was—twice as old as Napoleon. When this young 26-year-old whippersnapper turns up as a general and he's in charge, and then he's sending you messages about water buckets, you can legitimately think, "Oh, what's going on? I'm a veteran. Of course, I know about water buckets." But that's not the point. The point is that Napoleon's attention to detail was such that he was able to get into areas of especially military life. Why does it matter whether the prefect of Genoa is taking his mistress to the opera? Because it's bad for morale in Genoa if this man is humiliating his wife in public, and he doesn't want this man to do it. So he will write and tell him not to do it, even though there's a battle the next day.
- 8.65** A rigorous control of emotions. This is something that Churchill didn't have. Churchill would burst into tears at the drop of a hat, even in the House of Commons, sometimes while making a speech. Napoleon, on the other hand, did have a very strong command of emotions. He didn't let people know that he was downcast.
- 8.66** Now, he used to lose his temper a lot; he would shout and scream and yell. There's a six-hour meeting he had with Metternich in Dresden in June 1813, where he stomps and stamps, takes his hat off, and throws it on the floor and so on. None of it made any effect on Metternich whatsoever, who was a very cool customer. But it was for show; it was theatrical. It was part of his charisma, in a sense, this ability to lose his temper, and then moments later, go back to being absolutely calm and collected again. So this isn't an example of him being emotional; it's an example of him being essentially the actor that a lot of leaders need to be.
- 8.67** He had the ability to exploit a momentary, numerical advantage at the decisive point on the battlefield, and that is a very important aspect as well. When he saw his opportunity on the battlefield, he would always have a reserve, and he would fling it in at the key point to win the battle. He didn't do this at Borodino. This was one of the reasons why that battle was such an appalling Pyrrhic victory and so expensive for him. The reason was that even though various members of his entourage, such as Murat and Davout, begged him to send in the guard, Mortier's Imperial Guard, at the key psychological moment, he knew he was 1,800 miles from home, that if the guard didn't win and was broken in this, then the attack on Moscow would fail. So he decided not to. He held back the guard. But under normal circumstances, where you're not so far and so deeply in enemy territory, he was willing to make that numerical advantage count.
- 8.68** Of course, he was lucky. He was very lucky. He wasn't lucky at the end of his life—when he was on St. Helena; he wasn't lucky with the weather in Russia. There were lots of things he wasn't lucky about. But overall, he admired luck. He believed in providence. He believed in his contingency, his star, his destiny. He judged others on whether they

were lucky as well. He would ask of generals, "Is he lucky?" And the luck did run out, and of course, he died in exile on St. Helena. However, he was lucky for a huge part of his career, and that's something that obviously no one can create for themselves. It's you've got it or you haven't.

- 8.69** So even though he was ultimately defeated, Napoleon, I believe, is the wartime leader against whom all the others must be judged. And I want to take you back, therefore, to that sentence that I started with 8 hours ago now, at the beginning of this series of lectures, when he was commenting on that play, *The Templars*. You remember he said, "The hero of a tragedy, in order to interest us, should be neither wholly guilty nor wholly innocent. All weaknesses and all contradictions are unhappily in the heart of man, and present a coloring eminently tragic." And that, of course, does sum up, in a sense, Napoleon Bonaparte. He certainly was eminently tragic.
- 8.70** And what it does to sum up, and finally to end this lecture series, is to remind us of the other thing that he said about his own education, which I think should be true of us as much as it is of him. And that is, "The reading of history, very soon made me feel that I was capable of achieving as much as the men who are placed in the highest ranks of our annals." Ladies and gentlemen, thank you very much indeed.
- 8.71** In France, actually, in our school program, we don't have much lesson about Napoléon Bonaparte and the Empire. Do you have any idea why we are ashamed of this part of our history instead of being proud?
- 8.72** We don't actually have very much on Winston Churchill either. You can get through your time as a student in England and only actually have to learn about Churchill for 14 seconds. That's how long he's on a video that is a compulsory video for school children. It's absurd and ludicrous for a country not to admire its heroes. I think it's cultural suicide, frankly, for a country not to admire its heroes. But you're seeing it more and more. The attacks on the Founding Fathers in the United States is a classic example. And as a result, we have tremendous ignorance about the great men and women of our collective past.
- 8.73** I remember a survey that said that a large proportion, like 30% of British schoolchildren, thought that Winston Churchill was a fictional character, unlike the people who they thought really did exist, like Eleanor Rigby and Sherlock Holmes. There are some quarter of British school children who believe that the American War of Independence was won by Denzel Washington. So this is not just your country that seems deliberately to want to shoot itself in the foot, but it's pretty widespread and tragic as well.
- 8.74** Is there any part of Napoleon's life that remains a mystery to you? If you could meet him and perhaps interview him today, what would you ask him?
- 8.75** God, that's a good question as well. What is a mystery—I'd quite like to know why d'Erlon's corps attacked in the way that it did at Waterloo. Was it the best formation

that he could have had? Did he have any say over that? That would be interesting. I know it's a little bit detailed question. I'd quite like to—I'd love to meet him, obviously. I'd give my little finger right now in a guillotine in order to spend dinner with him and ask questions. But with regard to the thing, I think, I suppose, I would like to ask him about this concept of destiny, the extent to which he thought he was following a star of destiny, how he thought luck factored into his career.

- 8.76** What I wouldn't like is for him to go down the rabbit hole of why he lost Waterloo. He had some 12 reasons that he gave to do with the weather and Grouchy and Ney and so on, and none of them were his fault. That could actually be a little bit boring having to listen to him rant on about why he lost Waterloo. But It would be utterly wonderful to be able to spend time with Napoleon. Thank you.
- 8.77** I think you've, for me, made a very compelling, beguiling case for Napoleon being a great man, following a star of destiny. I think the thing that I continue to struggle with is, but at what cost? When you consider the figures of the Frenchmen born between 1790 and 1795, one in five of them were killed. When the citizens went back into Moscow, 12,000 people, corpses had to be put on a funeral pyre. When you look at Goya's picture of the devastation in Spain, when you think of the armies that rampaged across the whole of Europe and the typhus and the cholera and the bubonic plague that followed in their path, all of that death and destruction— you've got the blocks of granite on one side, and then all of that horror and death and unemployment and dislocation on the other side. How do you balance the scales?
- 8.78** Well, you don't blame Napoleon for every war that's fought between 1789 and 1815. The fact is that the legitimist powers—Austria, Russia, Britain, and Prussia—wanted to smash the French Revolution and to stop the concept of meritocracy because they were legitimists and they believed in aristocracy and wanted to go back to the point before the French Revolution. So even if Napoleon hadn't been Napoleon, you'd have still had these wars. They started many more wars than Napoleon did.
- 8.79** The two that you mentioned—the Peninsular War and the Russian campaign— were started by Napoleon, and absolutely, he was responsible for those 12,000 deaths in Moscow and so on. But there were seven wars of the coalition. He started two; they started five. You can't blame him for everything.
- 8.80** In a previous lecture, you mentioned that he had a feeling of necessity to expand his territory. I'm interested in what you think is—where does this come from? Is this downstream from his philosophy or even connected to the concept of dictatorship?
- 8.81** No, that was the Napoleon complex. He's accused of having this desire constantly to increase territory. After 1810, he didn't. He was—until, of course, the attack on Moscow—but in 1810, 1811, he wasn't trying to increase his empire. Even in 1812, he wasn't trying to bring Russia into his empire. He was trying to punish Russia for breaking out of the Continental System. So no, I don't think that there was anything

inherent in Napoleon needing to expand his empire. He wasn't like Hitler, for example, who desperately did need to continue as a juggernaut constantly. I don't think he does fit into that overall framework.

- 8.82** You mentioned multiple times that Napoleon was extremely driven and motivated. I wanted to ask about what you think fueled this drive, ambition, and motivation beyond reading history?
- 8.83** I think he had the ambition of trying to get as far as he could under his own steam with his own capacities to extend his talents as far as they would allow when it came to getting on in life and society. And of course, he got to the very top as emperor. So he did prove to himself his capacities. After the Battle of Lodi, he did recognize that he had the element of greatness within him. And therefore, I don't think it's right to blame people for ambition if they have the qualities necessary and the capabilities and the intelligence and so on. He had all of those things. Therefore, I think, in fact, if he wasn't ambitious, he would have been selling himself short.
- 8.84** In our modern world, do you think there are any preconditions for someone to rise up and become someone like Napoleon, Julius Caesar, or Alexander the Great in a positive way, maybe not even in war or even in politics or corporate? If there are, what would that look like? What would our version of Napoleon, in a positive way, look like? If not, what are the blocks?
- 8.85** Well, there are any number of blocks, especially in democracies, of course. You can't control the news cycle in a democracy where there's freedom of speech. I don't know. What's closest to Napoleon today? I'm assuming the answer must be these tech giants, these people who have unbelievable power, vast wealth, their power knows no territorial limit, and so they're just as powerful in the countries they were born in as elsewhere. If you're looking for the modern-day Napoleon, I suppose you're looking at Zuckerberg or Musk or one of these other—Bezos—or one of these other figures.
- 8.86** Obviously, with regard to military and political affairs, there are any number of dictators—Xi and Putin, who are around today, but they're not benevolent dictators. They're not people who are creating Code Napoléons and trying to reorganize their countries in a positive way. They're people who are rampaging around the world and causing much more trouble than anything positive they're doing.
- 8.87** So maybe our world is all the better now for not being open to obvious Napoleons. We can consign him happily to the 19th century, but there are a number of aspects to him that I think are useful for us in the present day. Otherwise, I wouldn't be doing this job.